

SUCCESS SECRETS
OF
SOLOMON

SUCCESS SECRETS OF SOLOMON

THE ANCIENT BLUEPRINT FOR
WISDOM, WEALTH, AND SUCCESS

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Solomon had the unique opportunity to ask for anything he wanted. He desired and asked for wisdom so he could benefit and bless his nation as he led it. Because of his wisdom, he was blessed with wealth, peace, and esteem. Solomon was the wisest and wealthiest person of his time—many believe he was the wisest and wealthiest of all time. He had so much gold that he used it for horse troughs. His success was unrivaled.

Proverbs are his teachings to the next generation and to us. He makes some of them challenging in the beginning. He taught that seeking wisdom was like seeking treasure. It is challenging in the beginning, but once you start finding it, it becomes easier. So, the first chapter breaks the ground to see if we will dig up wisdom. As the *Proverbs* go, they flow with meaning and messages that contain principles that will add value and create peace and prosperity.

I have invested a lifetime in Solomon's *Proverbs*. When I follow them, I find success and serenity. When I ignore them, I have earned failures and frustrations. This book is for enlightenment, not entertainment. It will be enjoyable, but its value has been proven for centuries. I am excited that you have chosen to go with me through *Solomon's Success Secrets*. They are secret, not because they are hidden, but because they must be desired. Desire this wisdom, and whatever else you desire can follow.

This book is designed for reading one page a day and reflecting on it. I suggest reading multiple times. You will be amazed.

“A FATHER’S DESIRE”

Proverbs 1:1-4: “The proverbs of Solomon the son of David, king of Israel; To know wisdom and instruction; to perceive the words of understanding; To know wisdom and instruction; to perceive the words of understanding; To give subtilty to the simple, to the young man knowledge and discretion.”

I have prioritized reading the book of *Proverbs* daily in addition to my other readings. It has been my passion because I have experienced its benefits and the burdens of not following its principles. As a student of success and successful people, no one can compare to Solomon’s Success. Other kingdoms and empires conquered more and gained more assets, but He accomplished his phenomenal success mostly peacefully! People actually gave to him, versus him taking it by force or mistreating people. He was the icon of success, wealth, and wisdom of his time. He was not a perfect man, but he was in a class by himself in biblical and ancient history.

Proverbs is mainly a collection of individual proverbs that flow from Solomon’s desire for his son to be a great leader and to have a happy, prosperous life. It is a father guiding his son to success and away from things that would hurt him. Proverbs are practical and applicable in our daily lives.

He states his purposes in our text. He wants us to “know wisdom.” He refers to more than intellectualism, but to knowing how to use it and having “discretion.” In other words, he wants to educate and equip his son (and us) with the “knowledge” he needs to make wise decisions (“discretion”) in any area of life. He wants his son to “know instruction.” This word means discipline. He wants his son to gain knowledge and be disciplined to apply it when it matters most. *That means making decisions based on principles and not out of emotion.*

God wants the same for us! As our Heavenly Father and the Source of All Wisdom and Knowledge, He desires us to benefit from these teachings. Are you ready?

“WHEN WISDOM BEGINS”

Proverbs 1:5-6: “A wise man will hear, and will increase learning; and a man of understanding shall attain unto wise counsels: To understand a proverb, and the interpretation; the words of the wise, and their dark sayings.”

Solomon knew that wisdom began the moment his son started listening. He says a “wise person will hear” means listening with purpose. The purpose was to “increase in learning.” *The wise person has a teachable, receptive spirit.* Solomon knew his son *wouldn't automatically be wise* because he had a wise father. His son had to desire it for himself!

We, too, will not be wise just because God is our Heavenly Father. *We have to want it! We have to be teachable.* We have to listen on purpose with the intent of learning. *Becoming a wise person is a proactive process!* It takes effort and focus. *Becoming a wise person is also a personal process!* It cannot be bought or caught. It must be sought! Solomon couldn't do it for his son, and no one could do it for us. We have to personally and passionately want it. When our minds are open, wisdom can be planted in us. However, no wisdom can be planted inside us when we are hard-headed and closed-minded.

Wise people seek out “wise counsels” because they want to understand wisdom's ways. They find people and resources to help them understand or get the personal “interpretation” of wisdom's words. It isn't *the act of hearing* but *the attitude of wanting* to get it that starts us growing in wisdom. Any parent or teacher will tell you that just because someone can hear what is being taught does not mean they are learning.

How proactive are you in personally seeking wisdom? How teachable are you? Do you hear or learn? In what ways have you sought wise counsel to gain understanding?

“THE FOUNDATION OF WISDOM”

Proverbs 1:7: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge: but fools despise wisdom and instruction.”

Proverbs 9:10: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom: and the knowledge of the holy is understanding.”

The way to begin to receive divine wisdom is to have the right attitude toward God. One must be teachable, but one also must have a *respectful* and *reverent* attitude toward God! Solomon is teaching his son that respect and reverence for God are the foundation of wisdom. *Once that foundation was laid, He knew he could build life and leadership lessons on top of it.* Without the solid ground of reverence for God, everything he taught his son would crack and crumble down from the pressures created by life and from being a leader.

Position, power, and prosperity can cause a person's ego to gain control of their decision-making process. *When that happens, foolish decisions are made. EGO means Edging God Out. Ego causes arrogance and self-willed behavior* that Solomon knew would be destructive for his son and his kingdom.

Reverence and respect for God produce humility and a surrendered will, which allows a person to be a candidate to receive wisdom. It creates an attitude that will be submissive to principles and respectful to authority. When we revere and respect God, we will respond to God. *We will be reachable and leadable, and the consequence will be wisdom.* Wisdom is a byproduct of having the proper disposition toward God's Position in our laws.

“THE FOUNDATION OF FOOLS”

Proverbs 1:7: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge: but fools despise wisdom and instruction.”

Proverbs 9:10: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom: and the knowledge of the holy is understanding.”

The foundation of wisdom means having the right attitude toward God, respect, and reverence for God. That disposition makes one teachable, causing the heart to be receptive and responsive to wisdom. The foundation of fools is the opposite. They “despise wisdom and instruction.” They have a disrespectful attitude toward God and authority, which makes them *unreceptive* and *nonresponsive* to any wisdom.

The word “instruction” implies discipline. Fools hate discipline. They despise discipline and only want to do what they want without regard for consequences. They despise anyone who tries to exercise authority over them. They have a pervasive bad attitude that leads them to connect with anyone who is a source of wisdom or discipline.

Those who are wise have a respectful and reverent attitude toward God, so they gain “knowledge of the holy” and “understanding.” They get it! Fools never get it! They never gain understanding, so they rebel even more. *They develop a more profound resentment* toward wisdom and wisdom’s representatives! *They blame others for their foolishness* and become mad at the world. They never look in the mirror or see that the negative that surrounds them is a result of cause and effect.

Solomon himself could not get through to a fool. No one can build positive things because their foundation is foolish. It goes deep and is built with materials of disrespect, selfishness, and arrogance. They sabotage their relationship with the wise, so they can live foolishly and do what they want. They make enemies of the wise and befriend the foolish. They have no “fear of the Lord”!

Proverbs 1:7: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge: but fools despise wisdom and instruction.”

“WISDOM SHOULD BEGIN IN THE HOME.”

Proverbs 1:8-9: “My son, hear the instruction of thy father, and forsake not the law of thy mother: For they shall be an ornament of grace unto thy head, and chains about thy neck.”

Solomon’s wisdom teaches that God has a divine order to life. Wisdom should begin in the home if the parental influences are wise themselves. The first school of wisdom should be in the home, in the divine order of things. It is the first place a child is introduced to instruction and discipline.

In most cases, the *road to rebellion* or the *way of wisdom* begins in the home. The dynamic of the parent-child relationship influences the child’s attitude toward authority and God himself. The child’s will can become hardened to instruction or receptive to instruction. *When a child rebels at a young age, it often sets them on a course of a fool because they haven’t learned to respect authority and receive instruction.*

Solomon tells his son that listening and learning from his parents’ instruction would decorate his life with grace and honor. Few things decorate our life better than a respectful and wise attitude. *Giving respect causes one to receive respect. As a future king, Solomon’s son could force respect, but Solomon knew it was better for him to earn it by being respectful.*

Few things in life are as unattractive as a disrespectful attitude and a rebellious spirit. Solomon desired to raise a respectful son, not a spoiled brat. With all the wealth and excess he was surrounded by, his son could have easily become indulgent. Solomon wanted his son to become honorable, respectful, and wise. *Our Heavenly Father desires the same of us!*

“WISDOM’S FIRST LESSON”

Proverbs 1:10: “My son, if sinners entice thee, consent thou not.”

Proverbs 1:18-19: “Surely in vain the net is spread in the sight of any bird.

And they lay wait for their own blood; they lurk privily for their own lives.” Please read all verses 10-19.

Solomon’s first *practical lesson* to his son is to avoid negative influences and associations. He knew his son’s relationships would influence him to be wise or act foolish. A wise man like Solomon knew that our relationships build or break us. *Our relationships are assets or liabilities to us*, even more so if we are in a leadership role like the young prince.

Solomon knew that people who are negative influences are great salespeople. They know what to say and do to “entice.” They paint a beautiful picture of everything but the negative consequences! Those consequences are deliberately left out.

Solomon said these negative influences set a trap for themselves, destroying *their* lives while hurting others. Today, we say the negative influences are self-destructive. They sabotage themselves, and that will ultimately destroy their own lives. Solomon was trying to get his son to have discernment and see past the immediate enticement to the end result.

Wisdom’s first lesson is simple but can often be complicated because of the emotions created by these negative Influences. We should review our relationships often to see if they are assets or liabilities. We should also review them to see if they are helping or hindering us from finding and following wisdom’s ways!

“WISDOM IS AVAILABLE”

Proverbs 1:20-22: “Wisdom crieth without; she uttereth her voice in the streets: She crieth in the chief place of concourse, in the openings of the gates: in the city she uttereth her words, saying, How long, ye simple ones, will ye love simplicity? and the scorers delight in their scorning, and fools hate knowledge?”

Solomon clarifies to his son that wisdom is available to anyone who *wants it*. It speaks loudly, or it “crieth.” It doesn’t hide. It is in the “chief place” or the most public of places. It is in the opening of the gates or the main entrance to the city. Solomon figuratively communicates that wisdom is easy to find if a person is looking for it!

Wisdom wants to be found. It cries, “How long... will you love simplicity?” In other words, how long will you love living without wisdom when it *is available*? It is not God’s will for us to live without the benefits and blessings of wisdom. He doesn’t want us to have to face life living foolishly. Solomon wanted his son to benefit from wisdom; God also wants that for us. *God desires us to live a life of wisdom to be successful and avoid as much self-induced pain as possible.* Therefore, God makes wisdom available to everyone who wants it!

Many people never hear wisdom’s cry because they don’t want to hear It. They don’t see it sitting right in front of them because *they aren’t looking for it*. Wisdom will call for us, but it will not capture us. *We see what we are prepared to see and hear what we want to hear.* So, if we don’t wait too long, it will be available when we want to find wisdom!

Our eyes and ears will be opened when we open our hearts to wisdom. We will see things differently because we are receptive and responsive.

“WISDOM REQUIRES CHANGE”

Proverbs 1:23-25: “Turn you at my reproof: behold, I will pour out my spirit unto you, I will make known my words unto you. Because I have called, and ye refused; I have stretched out my hand, and no man regarded; But ye have set at nought all my counsel, and would none of my reproof.”

Wisdom is personified as speaking to a foolish person who refuses to listen. It clearly teaches us that we aren't getting wisdom's lessons because we aren't listening. Wisdom is reaching out, but the fool isn't responding. Wisdom is speaking out, but the fool is refusing. So why doesn't the foolish person listen? Because listening requires them to “turn ...at wisdom's (my) reproof”. It would require them to change!

Wisdom often demands change from us, but always for our benefit. Yet, change is resisted by most, and even more so when one is hard-headed like the fool seen here. *Wisdom creates growth, and growth requires change.* The foolish person resists growth and change because they can't see that they need it. They often ignore any wisdom or warning until it's too late to change.

Those who seek wisdom and are sensitive to wisdom's voice change because they *want to*, not because they *have to*! They have become trusting of wisdom's advice and admonishments. They know when wisdom stretches out her hand to lead them in a direction, it will be a better direction. *Wisdom desires to protect and prosper. The wise trust this divine guidance, whereas the fool trusts themselves.* Their ego causes them to refuse to accept wisdom's helping hand. They don't want to be led; wisdom will not pull them.

Wisdom will only send out invitations. It is up to us to decide whether to accept or decline them. Just know that when we accept wisdom's invitation, it will require change. It may be a simple change in our attitude or actions. It may also be a significant change in the direction of our entire lives. However, we can be confident that wisdom will only ask us *to* change if it will benefit and bless us!

“WISDOM’S WARNING”

Proverbs 1:24-28: “Because I have called, and ye refused... Because I have called, and ye refused; When your fear cometh as desolation, and your destruction cometh as a whirlwind; when distress and anguish cometh upon you. Then shall they call upon me, but I will not answer; they shall seek me early, but they shall not find me:”

Wisdom gives a harsh warning to the foolish. Wisdom warns that there will come a time when it will not try to help them change any longer. Wisdom will ignore their calls because they are based on the desire to get out of trouble and not on a desire to change. Wisdom warns that there will come a time when it will walk away and leave them to the consequences of their foolish choices.

The consequences are referred to as “desolation” and “destruction”. They will produce “distress” and “anguish”. They will be given over to their “fear.” It is not God sending these things, but rather it is the self-created consequences of their foolish choices. It is the *consequences of a life that rejects wisdom’s help and disrespects God*. It is a life full of negative things that happened because they are reaping what they have sown. A life of misery is created and caused. The fool is not a victim of circumstance but a victim of their choices!

We must understand that God will forgive anything, but it doesn’t mean we are free of earthly consequences. There may be consequences if we knowingly reject wisdom’s ways and warnings. A wise person will respect and respond to wisdom when they have a choice. Know that its consequences are set in motion once we make a choice. We are free to the point of choice, but the choice controls us. So, choose wisdom and its reward, not foolishness and its ruin.

“WISDOM PRODUCES PEACE”

Proverbs 1:31-33: “Therefore shall they eat of the fruit of their own way, and be filled with their own devices. For the turning away of the simple shall slay them, and the prosperity of fools shall destroy them. But whoso hearkeneth unto me shall dwell safely, and shall be quiet from fear of evil.”

Proverbs is a book of contrasts and comparisons. Solomon compares wisdom's benefits and blessings to a fool's life. The fool's life is full of the “fruit of their own ways.” It is full of negative consequences. It is full of headaches and heartaches from their “own devices.” Their life appears to be cursed, but their choices cause it.

On the other hand, those who listen to wisdom will “dwell safely” or have peace. They will be free from the “fear” caused by foolish choices. The lifestyle of a fool is full of drama. The life of a wise person is “quiet”. It is peaceful in comparison to the life of a fool.

Fools are always digging out of holes, so they never progress in life. They are always in repair mode, trying to fix the messes they have made. Whereas wise people make mistakes, they are easier to repair, so they can invest more time building their lives. They progress in life because they can invest their time in positive pursuits. The fool is wasting their life away, repeating the same mistakes over and over.

The fool's life is full of “fear” or anxiety because they have created enough to start expecting it. The wise person is free from anxiety and expects prosperity. They have peace of mind because they live peaceful lives!

“WISDOM IS CONDITIONAL” PART 1

Proverbs 2:1-5: “My son, if thou wilt receive my words, and hide my commandments with thee; So that thou incline thine ear unto wisdom, and apply thine heart to understanding; Yea, if thou criest after knowledge, and liftest up thy voice for understanding; If thou seekest her as silver, and searchest for her as for hid treasures; Then shalt thou understand the fear of the LORD and find the knowledge of God.”

The word “Then” in verse 5 makes it *conditional* based on the preceding verses 1-4 instruction. *When* the conditions of verses 1-4 are met, a person will begin to understand Wisdom’s Person and Principles. They will begin to receive Divine insight and intelligence that will cause them to respect God.

The primary condition is a receptive heart! One that will remember (“hide”) what it is taught by wisdom. A heart that will “apply” what it learns. A heart and mind that will “incline” or listen to wisdom is a must. It literally means to tune into wisdom! A heart dialed into the Divine Frequency that transmits wisdom will “receive” instructions. By the way, we can’t tune wisdom in when it benefits us and tune it out when we don’t like its instruction.

Wisdom must be our prayer. If a person “criest” after it and “lifts” up their voice, they will receive wisdom. God will grant wisdom if we sincerely seek it! *It is God’s will for our lives!* James 1:5 is clear: we are to pursue wisdom in our prayers.

Wisdom must be a passion. One who lifts their voice and cries after something is passionate about wanting what they are seeking. Wisdom doesn’t manifest itself to the passive or complacent. It reserves its relationship for those who seek it with passion!

“WISDOM IS CONDITIONAL” PART 2

Proverbs 2:1-5: “My son, if thou wilt receive my words, and hide my commandments with thee; So that thou incline thine ear unto wisdom, and apply thine heart to understanding; Yea, if thou criest after knowledge, and liftest up thy voice for understanding; If thou seekest her as silver, and searchest for her as for hid treasures; Then shalt thou understand the fear of the LORD and find the knowledge of God.”

Again, Wisdom Is conditional. It will only have a relationship with those who have a *receptive* and *responsive heart*. Then Wisdom will reveal itself to those who *pursue it in prayer*. Further, it reveals itself to those who *seek it with passion*.

Wisdom must also be our prize. Solomon says *if* we seek it like hidden “treasures,” we will receive it. Wisdom must become a treasured commodity for us. We must be willing to value its rewards so much that we will pursue it like a treasure hunter would seek treasure. Think about the early explorers who left the Old World behind in pursuit of the treasures of the New World. Even today, treasure hunters will make tremendous sacrifices looking for treasure. *That pursuit is the attitude we must have to find the treasure of divine Wisdom*. When we see Wisdom’s value, we will seek Wisdom’s values!

Wisdom must be the priority. It allows us to “understand” and “find the knowledge of God.” Wisdom cannot be fooled. It will only have a relationship with those few who prioritize it! Wisdom will not be an option. It demands to be the main thing! It is what we pray for! It is what we are passionate about! It is the prized treasure of our lives! It is the priority!

Few people would do what Solomon did when told by God that he would be granted whatever he prayed for. He chose Wisdom. Would you? If God said I will give you anything, you ask for this one time, no matter what it is. Would you choose Wisdom so you could bless and benefit others? Solomon got it! He valued Wisdom, and that created tremendous value for him.

“WISDOM’S BENEFITS”

Proverbs 2:5-6: “Then shalt thou understand the fear of the LORD and find the knowledge of God. For the LORD giveth wisdom: out of his mouth cometh knowledge and understanding.”

Solomon teaches that once we meet the conditions of wisdom, we begin to receive its benefits. Wisdom will change our *perspective*. *When wisdom begins to cause us to “understand” and we receive “knowledge of God,” our perspective towards everything in life begins to change.*

God is the source of this wisdom, so we view life from a divine perspective. We begin to receive divine illumination. Illumination means we start understanding and gaining divine knowledge. The light that enters our mind through our spirit allows us to see life from a different perspective. We start getting it because our hearts are receptive to this divine influence and intelligence. We connect to “the knowledge of God.”

This divine “knowledge and understanding” changes our perspective and perception. We perceive things differently, even divinely. Every life situation and circumstance is perceived differently because of divine illumination. We understand things differently based on our new knowledge. Wisdom begins to enable and empower us to live divinely.

If our *perspective* and *perception* aren’t changing, we aren’t being influenced by wisdom!

“WISDOM’S BENEFITS”

Proverbs 2:12 -13: “To deliver thee from the way of the evil man, from the man that speaketh froward things; Who leave the paths of uprightness, to walk in the ways of darkness;”

Proverbs 2:16-17: “To deliver thee from the strange woman, even from the stranger which flattereth with her words; Who leave the paths of uprightness, to walk in the ways of darkness; Which forsaketh the guide of her youth, and forgetteth the covenant of her God.”

Once wisdom gives us discretion or the power and perspective to make good decisions, we will see people differently. We can *see through the surface* of people and read *the true meaning* behind their words. Wisdom will give us the benefit of choosing wise partnerships.

We will be able to choose wise personal relationships. *We will not only listen to their words* but also *see what path they are on*. We will have the power and perspective to ask if the path they want us to follow is wise or foolish. We will develop discernment about people. we will become perceptive, not just buying into their word or enticements at face value.

We will be able to choose wise, private relationships. We will discern when someone only uses *flattery to manipulate* for their foolish games. We will be able to see past the outward beauty and see the ugly truth about the person. We will become discerning about those who will ultimately be destructive to us.

Wisdom’s goal is to protect us and realize that those people we partner with in life will hugely influence us and our future. Wisdom wants to protect us from people who will cause us heartache and help us avoid the pain and misery caused by partnering with foolish people.

“WISDOM’S BENEFITS”

Proverbs 2:9-11: “Then shalt thou understand righteousness, and judgment, and equity; yea, every good path. When wisdom entereth into thine heart, and knowledge is pleasant unto thy soul; Discretion shall preserve thee, understanding shall keep thee.”

Notice the word “*then*” again, indicating something conditional. Once our hearts are receptive to wisdom and allow it to change our perspective, we will perceive things and life differently. As we understand wisdom’s desire to protect us, “*then*” we are ready to exercise “discretion.” Discretion is the ability to make wise decisions, and these will help “preserve” us.

Wisdom gives us the benefit of power. This power is the ability to make wise choices. The fool does not have this ability because their perspective and perception about what is wise or foolish are warped. They are not looking at things from a divine perspective. *Therefore, they will make foolish choices because they lack the enlightenment from wisdom.*

Discretion is the ability to make wise choices, our most crucial life skill. Solomon desired this quality for his son. He knew it would help his son succeed and avoid many self-created heartaches. *God desires the same for us, but it is conditional on our attitude toward wisdom.* It happens “when wisdom entereth into thine (our) hearts.”

Discretion is a tremendous benefit from wisdom. No part of our life isn’t helped. There will never be a day we don’t need it. The quality of our decisions determines the quality of our lives!

“WISDOM’S BENEFITS

Proverbs 2:20-22: “That thou mayest walk in the way of good men and keep the paths of the righteous. For the upright shall dwell in the land, and the perfect shall remain in it. But the wicked shall be cut off from the earth, and the transgressors shall be rooted out of it.”

Wisdom will not only allow us to discern people who are unwise for us not to follow, but It will also allow us to find wise people. Solomon wanted this for his son. He wanted him to make partnerships and relationships with people who would help him walk in the ways of Wisdom. Solomon knew his son, or *we will only be as wise as the people we surround ourselves with!*

Wisdom will encourage us to follow wise paths. *Wise people leave clues behind for us to follow.* However, we cannot have relationships with fools and expect to find Wisdom’s clues. Wise people have learned that the world can be deceptive and dangerous, so they have marked out paths of safety so we can navigate through life successfully. If we follow the paths created by the wise, we will *live successfully*. If we follow the paths created by fools, we will live *life regretfully*.

In his wisdom, Solomon recognizes that we all follow something or someone. Even those who think they aren’t following anyone are following the appetites of their mind, so they are following after pleasure. It is inescapable that we are following something or someone in some way. Conscious or unconscious, it happens by design or default, but we follow an influence. The wise person will choose to find and follow the paths of wise people! They realize it is the *surest* and *safest* route in their life’s journey. It is also the *swiftest* path to abundant life!

“WISDOM’S BENEFITS CONCLUDED”

Proverbs 3:1-2: “My son, forget not my law; but let thine heart keep my commandments: For length of days, and long life, and peace, shall they add to thee.”

Solomon continues to teach his son the importance of choosing a life of wisdom and its benefits. The words translated in verse 2 have more meaning than many realize. One of the benefits of wisdom is a life of peace. *A wise person’s life is tranquil and calm. The fool’s life is chaotic and stressful!*

The wise person will benefit from a long life. They are blessed because they are free from the stress and strain of the life of a fool. They not only have the length of days, but they will have a quality life (“long life”). The fool has a poor quality of life because of the stress and strain caused by their foolishness. You’ll often hear foolish people say, “They hate life.” They *endure life* while the wise *enjoy their life*. Even the wise have trials, but are less affected because they make better decisions. Quality decisions produce a quality life!

A long life without peace is a life of misery. A long life that is a quality life is a life of happiness and joy. A long life full of heartache and regrets is a life of unhappiness and depression. Wisdom will bless us with a life worth living! *Wisdom will add quality to our days as well as quantity.*

“HOW TO CREATE FAVOR”

Proverbs 3:3-4: “Let not mercy and truth forsake thee: bind them about thy neck; write them upon the table of thine heart: So shalt thou find favour and good understanding in the sight of God and man.”

Even a King or future King needs goodwill and favor from the people around him. Solomon knew there were two ways leaders lead. They can lead *by force* or *by favor*. *Those who lead by force breed opposition*, and *those who lead by favor breed goodwill*. Solomon gives his son profound but straightforward advice to live by “mercy” and “truth.”

Those words are powerful in Hebrew. They mean to treat people with love, kindness, and respect. Further, it means to be loyal and faithful. That’s it! Just treat people with kindness, respect, and love. Part of that is being merciful or forgiving.

The true measure of character for people with position, power, and privilege is how they treat people around them and under them. Solomon wanted his son to treat people with love, kindness, and forgiveness. He wanted his son to have favor with people. He wanted his son to reign in goodwill and be respected, not feared.

Solomon teaches that there is a direct correlation between how we treat people and having God’s favor. God will bless the “blessers”! God grants favor or special blessing to those who treat others with love, respect, and kindness. If you want to see good things happen for you, start treating people with kindness, respect, and love. It is a divine principle, so it is available to everyone. Therefore, God is not showing favoritism, but you are accessing His favor. People respond to and give to people who treat them with kindness, forgiveness, and respect!

“HOW TO RECEIVE DIVINE DIRECTION”

Proverbs 3:5-6: “Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths.”

Solomon was the wisest man ever because he realized the need to receive divine direction in every area of his life. Maybe he was taught that by his father, David, or perhaps he learned from David’s mistakes. Regardless, he desires his son to benefit from divine guidance throughout his life.

Solomon teaches his son that there are *three qualifiers* to have God “direct his (thy) paths.” The first is that we Trust in God to be the directing force in our lives. It means having faith and confidence in God to guide our lives. It is a simple Trust, yet many people make it too complicated. We begin to sow doubt when we start overthinking and overanalyzing God’s direction for our paths. This kind of complicated, convoluted thinking causes confusion. If we are in a *state of Trust*, we believe and receive divine direction. *Our responsibility is to trust, and He is to direct.* It is that simple.

At the same time, the next qualifier is that we do not trust ourselves. It is to choose God’s direction over my desires. We are, by nature, predisposed to foolishness, not wisdom. When we add emotions into that equation, we desperately need divine guidance. A wise person will admit that and see how their emotions and mind have misled them in the past. We have an innate need to justify our behavior, so we often convince ourselves that what we are doing is “right,” “good,” or “best.” Admitting our tendency to be dysfunctional, delusional, and self-deceptive is crucial, so we learn to rely on divine guidance. *Then* we avoid leaning on our understanding.

The last qualifier is that we acknowledge and ask for divine guidance in every decision and every area of our lives. Whereas we are to be in a *continuous state of Trust*, we are to seek divine guidance in every area of our lives. *We are to remain dependent upon God’s leadership by acknowledging our dependence and asking for and accepting divine guidance.* Once we ask for direction, we trust He will somehow direct our steps. It is vital to note that WE TRUST that we will be directed if we are worried about making a mistake. That is precisely what will happen, or we will have paralysis caused by analysis!

Trusting God for divine direction is the foundation of receiving divine direction. However, all three qualifiers work in conjunction and congruence simultaneously. To take away one, and that disrupts the others.

“THE CHOICE”

Proverbs 3:7-8: “Be not wise in thine own eyes: fear the LORD and depart from evil. It shall be health to thy navel, and marrow to thy bones.”

The choice, as presented by Solomon, is a simple one. Will we be wise in our conceit, *or* will we respect God’s wisdom over our own? *Wisdom begins when our Ego ends!* When we respect and revere (“fear”) God enough to allow Him to become the Ruling Force in our lives, we let go of our Ego. We will seek divine guidance and leadership. The fool says *I know best*. The wise *man knows God knows best!*

When we respect God’s wisdom, we will respond to it. It will cause us to “depart” from evil or harmful things. God will not guide us to things that are harmful to us, whereas our dysfunctional Ego will. Our Ego will make us think we know best or can handle it. Our Ego will get us in trouble. On the other hand, wisdom will *guide us from trouble*.

Living, respecting, and responding to God’s leadership will lead to a healthy lifestyle. This lifestyle benefits and blesses us with “health” on the inside. It will strengthen us and support us like healthy bone tissue. Most medical and psychological experts agree that stress and negative emotions diminish and destroy our health. Living with the negative emotions created by the foolishness of the Ego can be destructive to our health. Wisdom will support our health.

The choice is ours: Ego’s ways or God’s wisdom. We can choose a life based on the foolishness of the Ego or a life based on following divine leadership. We can choose a healthy lifestyle or a self-destructive lifestyle.

“WISDOM TEACHES HONOR”

Proverbs 3:9-10: “Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the first-fruits of all thine increase: So shall thy barns be filled with plenty, and thy presses shall burst out with new wine.”

Solomon teaches that a wise person will honor God with their Substance. The Old Testament principle was to give the “firstfruits” to God to demonstrate respect and appreciation for whatever they were blessed with. A wise person understands that every blessing and success ultimately comes from God. *This act of worship acknowledges God as the Giver and keeps the ego in check.*

Solomon, blessed tremendously with wealth, realized the danger that wealth and success can bring. *If we aren't careful, the very things God blesses us with can be what will cause us to become arrogant and independent.* There is deception and danger in thinking Look at what I've done! Thinking thoughts like, look how smart I am. Wise people humble themselves by giving God free offerings that acknowledge Him as the Giver and Granter of All Success.

Solomon teaches that honoring God with our Substance has positive consequences. When we honor God by giving him the “first fruits,” God will bless us with more! Giving creates Growth! In fact, it allows for abundance and prosperity. It is a divine principle, so it may seem counterintuitive. However, the wise person has learned to *trust* in divine principles and experience their rewards.

Success and Substance can honor God if we follow divine principles. Conversely, the same Success and Substance can feed our ego and cause arrogance if we choose not to follow divine principles. So, we will either honor ourselves or God with our Success and Substance. The wise will honor God!

“PAIN IS A DIVINE TEACHER”

Proverbs 3:11-12: “My son, despise not the chastening of the LORD; neither be weary of his correction: For whom the LORD loveth he correcteth; even as a father the son in whom he delighteth.”

Solomon’s culture believed in corporal punishment. Pain was used as a teaching and correcting technique. It wasn’t the only form of teaching, as we can see by how Solomon invested so much time in teaching and instructing his son. So, Solomon used the father-son relationship to instruct his son that God would also use pain to teach us when necessary.

God hard-wires us neurologically to learn that pain means bad. Touch a hot stove and get the lesson fast. God wired us emotionally to understand that pain means something bad or hurtful, but our hardheartedness or dysfunction makes us slower to react at times. It makes some people more stubborn! Solomon warned his son against this and *wanted him to realize God was trying to help him learn from his mistakes*. It was an act of love from God, trying to prevent worse things from happening in the future, just like a parent would correct their child.

A wise person will learn from painful experiences. A fool will not learn the lesson, but they will experience the pain! They will experience it over and over as it intensifies over time. *The lessons get bigger, and the pain gets worse*. That is a foolish way to live! Some foolish people never learn; not getting the lesson takes their lives.

Solomon wanted his son to learn from pain and not repeat his mistakes. God wants the same for us. He will use painful situations and circumstances to try to prevent worse things down the road. *God doesn’t send every pain, but he will use any pain to teach us if we want to learn*. My friend, you are in pain, so why not get the lesson? Ask, what lesson am I being taught through this pain? How can I avoid it in the future?!

“WISDOM CREATES HAPPINESS”

Proverbs 3:13: “Happy is the man that findeth wisdom, and the man that getteth understanding.”

Happiness is primarily a by-product of the positive choices we make in life. Nothing *enables* and *empowers* us to make a positive choice like divine wisdom does! Wisdom’s goal is to help us make the best possible decisions and create the best outcome from those decisions. The combination of positive decisions and positive circumstances creates happiness.

When one gets the understanding that comes from wisdom, life becomes much easier than a fool’s drama-filled life. A wise person’s life is marked with more peace and success, which breeds a happier lifestyle. *Ironically, the fool is seeking happiness, but it eludes them.* They seek fun and pleasure, hoping to bring happiness, but it never does. They are unsatisfied. So, they search for more fun and pleasure, yet happiness still evades them. In contrast, the wise person moves from happiness to happiness!

The way to get happiness is to get wisdom! One must understand that only divine wisdom can bring it. It is avoiding as much self-induced pain as possible by making positive decisions! It is enjoying the positive outcomes and successes resulting from living a lifestyle of wisdom. When we seek happiness, we will be easily misled! We will be led to happiness when we seek wisdom because it is a by-product of wisdom.

“WISDOM’S VALUE”

Proverbs 3:14-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her.”

The length of days is in her right hand, and riches and honor are in her left hand. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her, and happy is everyone that retains her.

Solomon was the world’s wealthiest man. His net worth couldn’t be calculated in the billions. He was probably the world’s only trillionaire. He had so much gold that he used it to cover his horse troughs. Yet, he taught his son that wisdom was the most valuable thing he possessed. It was by far his greatest asset and commodity.

He taught that while wisdom is invaluable, it will create tremendous value for us. *Wisdom is invisible, but it creates visible rewards in our lives.* Wisdom is essentially intangible, yet its by-products are very tangible. Solomon tries his best to impress upon his son the value of wisdom. He compares it to silver, pure gold, and precious gems, and finally, *he adds them all together and says, “all the things you could ever desire added together can’t compare to the value of wisdom!”* Wisdom is invaluable!

Solomon discovered that when he treasured wisdom, all the things men treasure came from seeking wisdom! He also observed, as we will see later, that when people sought after things and happiness without wisdom, it turned them into fools. He discovered God would allow these tangible things men seek after to be a part of our lives and become blessings to us *if we follow after wisdom first. However, if we pursue tangible things, making them our main prize and pursuit, they will end up cursing our lives!*

“WISDOM’S VALUE”

Proverbs 3:14-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her. Length of days is in her right hand; and in her left hand riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her: and happy is every one that retaineth her.”

Solomon lists some very tangible by-products of wisdom, which he calls the merchandise of wisdom. That means wisdom can be exchanged for these items. It is essential to look at his illustration and see that *one must first possess wisdom* before it can be given in exchange for these benefits and blessings.

He first says wisdom can be exchanged for a long life. Wisdom’s primary role is to enable us to make the best possible decisions in every area of our lives, producing a lifestyle conducive to longevity. Making wise choices includes *healthy choices*.

The second thing he teaches wisdom can be exchanged for is riches. Wisdom can enable us to make decisions that create wealth! *Solomon supernaturally demonstrated this ability*. It doesn’t mean it leads to overnight wealth, but wisdom allows us to make sound, stable decisions that add wealth over time. A fool might gather riches, but likely loses them because of foolish decisions.

A wise person’s first goal is to make wise decisions that demonstrate respect for God. *That is the filter for all their decisions*. A fool would decide to make money regardless of whether it is wise, shortsighted, or disrespectful of divine principles. Solomon learned a secret: if you seek wisdom first, you can exchange it for anything of value! *We can seek wisdom and create* health and wealth for ourselves!

“WISDOM’S VALUE”

Proverbs 3:14-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her. Length of days is in her right hand; and in her left hand riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her: and happy is every one that retaineth her.”

Wisdom can be exchanged for honor. Respect and honor are by-products of wisdom. As you value wisdom, people value you more and more. They will appreciate your insight and intelligence. They will value your discernment and perspective. Well, otherwise, people will at least honor you because they *see* your value. *As more wise people see your value, you will become more valuable to them.*

The foolish are warped in their thinking. They respect foolish people. They will brag about how crazy a person is or what magnitude of foolishness they did. They will brag about how “wasted” they got or how “wild” they were. At the same time, they will not respect the wise person because they cannot see the value of wisdom.

In some ways, the real question is who will honor you! *Even the fool is celebrated in some circles.* Some celebrate murderers. Judgmental people celebrate other judgmental people. A wise person wants the respect and honor that comes from wise people!

Whatever we value, we will respect and honor! *If* we realize wisdom’s value, we will value the honor of the wise!

“WISDOM’S VALUE”

Proverbs 3:14-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her. Length of days is in her right hand; and in her left hand riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are Peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her: and happy is every one that retaineth her.”

Wisdom can be exchanged for a pleasant life. A pleasant life is a life that is pleasing to the spirit. It is a life that “tastes” good. It isn’t full of bitterness that is created by foolish choices. *Never underestimate the value of having a pleasant life full of things pleasing to you and God.* It is very satisfying at the end of the day! Very satisfying at the end of life as well!

Wisdom can also be exchanged for Peace. Peace is a deeper quality than pleasantness. However, they work together to produce *contentment*. The fool’s life is full of chaos, while the wise have a life full of contentment! The wise follow “paths” that lead to Peace! The fools follow paths that lead to an absence of Peace.

Of all the things wisdom can be exchanged for, a peaceful, pleasant life is probably the most sought-after by the wise. Wealth, success, and honor don’t produce the same feeling of satisfaction that a peaceful, pleasant life does!

Follow wisdom and find Peace! Follow wisdom and find the real Good Life!

“WISDOM’S VALUE CONCLUDED”

Proverbs 3:14-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her. Length of days is in her right hand; and in her left hand riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her: and happy is every one that retaineth her.”

Solomon concludes by saying Wisdom (“she”) is a tree of life. Wisdom is personified as a tree that continuously produces life-giving fruit. Wisdom will continue to produce benefits that enhance our lives. Wisdom’s fruit only makes us better. It gives life. The comparison, which is unspoken but implied in the original writing style, is that *foolishness is a tree that produces death and destruction*. Going back to the Garden of Eden, Solomon illustrates that Wisdom is the choice that produces life.

One can sustain a positive life when one eats from the Tree of Wisdom. He has taught that it will create health, longevity, and prosperity. It creates a pleasant, peaceful life that is honorable. The fruit is available for those who “lay hold” of it! Those who hold unto it as if it is a matter of utmost importance!

“Happy” is a person who values Wisdom. *Happy means blessed and envied by others! It means to be fortunate!* Being fortunate is from the perspective of an outsider looking in at the pleasant, prosperous life of the wise. It looks like good things happen for them, but the wise know they are created by following Wisdom’s “paths.” The wise have learned that following Wisdom’s “paths” *creates positive by-products*. It is more *cause and effect* from the perspective of the wise. They are happy and fortunate because they are on the right path, the path of divine Wisdom!

“WHICH TREE ARE YOU EATING FROM?”

Proverbs 3:1 4-18: “For the merchandise of it is better than the merchandise of silver, and the gain thereof than fine gold. She is more precious than rubies: and all the things thou canst desire are not to be compared unto her. Length of days is in her right hand; and in her left hand riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her: and happy is every one that retaineth her.”

It is vital at times to *slow down for reflection* and *self-examination*. Increasing knowledge is essential, but stopping and applying the knowledge to our lives is wisdom. So, let’s ask ourselves: *Which Tree are we eating from?* Are we eating from the “tree of life” (wisdom), or are we eating from the Tree of Death (foolishness)?

How do we know which Tree we are eating from? Examining our lives to see if the by-products discussed before *come from following wisdom’s paths are present in our lives!* Is prosperity (“riches”) present? Is honor and respect present? Is our life, for the *most part*, pleasant and peaceful? Is there a sense of happiness and good fortune? If we eat from the Tree of Wisdom, we will enjoy its sweet fruit!

Conversely, not enjoying the fruit from the Tree of Wisdom could be a sign that we know wisdom’s paths but aren’t following them. Eating the bitter fruit of continuous drama, upheaval, and unrest is a sign we are eating from the wrong Tree! The thing about the bitter fruit of the Tree of foolishness is that it slowly destroys our lives! It drains us of life, love, and happiness! It decays and destroys the quality of our lives and often even the quantity of our days!

So, which Tree are you eating from? It is not too late to eat from the Tree of Life and regain a healthy, happy life!

“WISDOM’S POTENTIAL”

Proverbs 3:19-20: “The LORD by wisdom hath founded the earth; by understanding hath he established the heavens. By his knowledge the depths are broken up, and the clouds drop down the dew.”

Solomon had Insight into God’s wisdom. He knew God was the Ultimate Source of all wisdom and Intelligence. He realized what few do: He could access the same Intelligence that designed and created the world. Solomon saw the order of creation as a reminder that wisdom is all around us. He had tapped into God’s divine wisdom and wanted his son to do the same.

One only has to look at creation as Solomon did to see the potential of wisdom. It is sublime and divine what wisdom and divine Intelligence can do. From the time of Solomon to our time, we have yet to touch the potential of what wisdom can create and accomplish! There are still *great inventions* and *medical breakthroughs* waiting to be uncovered! They exist already, so they aren’t discovering it as much as uncovering divine wisdom. *Tremendous fortunes* will still be created from accessing the exact source of wisdom Solomon used! The potential of what can be done by accessing wisdom is almost unlimited. It is Divine!

Whether you face a simple personal problem or a significant one like a cure for cancer, the answer can be found by seeking the Source of All Wisdom. But remember, wisdom only reveals itself to those who value and respect it! Those who seek it like a treasure find its treasure!

“WISDOM’S PROMISES”

Proverbs 3:21-26: “My son, let not them depart from thine eyes: keep sound wisdom and discretion: So shall they be life unto thy soul, and grace to thy neck. Then shalt thou walk in thy way safely, and thy foot shall not stumble. When thou liest down, thou shalt not be afraid: yea, thou shalt lie down, and thy sleep shall be sweet. Be not afraid of sudden fear, neither of the desolation of the wicked, when it cometh.”

Solomon instructs his son to remember to “keep” wisdom. In other words, he reminds his son never to let go of wisdom. He needed to have a lifelong commitment to wisdom. If he did, he would experience specific blessings due to it. Solomon experienced the fulfillment of wisdom’s promises.

Wisdom promises emotional well-being. It would give “life” to the “soul.” A fool’s life destroys positive emotions and feeds negative emotions! *The wise person will experience healthier emotional well-being.* The epidemic of emotional dysfunction and disease in our modern culture is directly related to a foolish lifestyle. Fear, anxiety, and depression are often related to living out the *instability* caused by rejecting divine wisdom.

Negative decisions have negative consequences. Negative decisions produce negative emotions. The endless combination of negative consequences and emotions drains the “life” out of the “soul!” The soul is our emotional center or being. Solomon promises his son that *if* he keeps living a lifestyle of wisdom, he’ll feed his “soul.” How? The opposite is true. Positive (wise) decisions produce positive consequences. Positive decisions produce positive emotions.

“WISDOM’S PROMISES”

Proverbs 3:21-26: “My son, let not them depart from thine eyes: keep sound Wisdom and discretion: So shall they be life unto thy soul, and grace to thy neck. Then shalt thou walk in thy way safely, and thy foot shall not stumble. When thou liest down, thou shalt not be afraid: yea, thou shalt lie down, and thy sleep shall be sweet. Be not afraid of sudden fear, neither of the desolation of the wicked, when it cometh.”

Wisdom promises progress in life. Solomon explains to his son that he will walk forward in life without stumbling or falling. Solomon wasn’t saying he’d be perfect, but he would make more progress without always having to recover from foolish decisions.

Wisdom allows us to “walk” safely—that is, without doing things that hurt us. It helps us avoid hurtful and harmful things, harmful people, and destructive situations.

Wisdom allows us to “walk” securely. It helps us avoid things that will cause us to fall. The world is full of things and people waiting to trip us up! They cause us to lose momentum in life. Progress is hindered or even halted. Many falls are also very painful. So, time is spent recovering instead of progressing.

So, Wisdom allows us to walk successfully through Life, but not perfectly. It will help us navigate life, steering us to blessings and away from danger.

“WISDOM’S PROMISES”

Proverbs 3:21-26: “My son, let not them depart from thine eyes: keep sound wisdom and discretion: So shall they be life unto thy soul, and grace to thy neck. Then shalt thou walk in thy way safely, and thy foot shall not stumble. When thou liest down, thou shalt not be afraid: yea, thou shalt lie down, and thy sleep shall be sweet. Be not afraid of sudden fear, neither of the desolation of the wicked, when it cometh.”

Wisdom promises peace of mind. Solomon was a man with enormous responsibilities. He knew that living a lifestyle of wisdom and leading in wisdom allowed him to sleep peacefully at night. Solomon found he could sleep peacefully at night because he walked securely through the day. He didn’t need to be anxious about “sudden fear” because he walked successfully during the day.

Peace of mind from a peaceful life in harmony with God reduces stress. It cannot eliminate every stress, but it will eliminate many. Further, choosing wisdom will create a sense of serenity and security from God. Solomon experienced this even as he ruled a nation and managed a vast fortune.

Many lack the peace of mind that wisdom creates because they ignore wisdom’s voice. They try *to* manage their lives based on their thoughts without seeking God’s wisdom and Intelligence. They walk foolishly during the day and lie awake at night with anxiety. *Sleep eludes them because peace eludes them.* They have a dominating feeling that something terrible will happen (“sudden fear”), creating restlessness, which we now call insomnia. In our culture, we medicate at night to cover up our lack of peace. A better plan is to walk wisely, which creates peace of mind.

“WISE PEOPLE ARE GENEROUS”

Proverbs 3:27-28: “Withhold not good from them to whom it is due, when it is in the power of thine hand to do it. Say not unto thy neighbour, Go, and come again, and tomorrow I will give; when thou hast it by thee.”

Even though Solomon was beyond wealthy and powerful, he taught his son that being generous and helpful to others was part of being wise. He knew that generosity and helpfulness fulfilled divine principles. He realized that being blessed came with a sacred *responsibility* to help those who needed help!

Notice the verses. Solomon teaches that if we can do something to help, we should. God never asks us to do what we cannot, but expects us to do what we can. That includes helping meet the needs of others. It is very spiritual to meet the physical, emotional, and financial needs of those around us. We are to open our *hearts* and *hands* to be a force for God and good whenever and wherever we can.

We are to be proactive in meeting the needs of those around us. We are not to procrastinate, but do it right then and there. It is not something to pray about to see if it is God’s will—it *is God’s will!* We are to be active as givers and ministers to their needs.

Solomon knew it was not only God’s business to meet the needs of others but also good business. Wise people know that when we give, we will be blessed in return!

“WISE PEOPLE LIVE PEACEFULLY TOWARD OTHERS”

Proverbs 3:29-30: “Devise not evil against thy neighbour, seeing he dwelleth securely by thee. Strive not with a man without cause, if he have done thee no harm.”

Solomon teaches his son that wise people live peacefully with those around them. *At least they don't initiate conflicts and problems.* As a Leader of a nation, there may have been times when war or conflict was necessary, but Solomon advises against unnecessary conflict. Solomon advises his son not to think about starting a conflict with his neighbor. He was not to start a fight out of negative emotion without a definite, actual, and necessary cause.

That is not just excellent advice for a nation's leader, but for us too. *Most of the personal conflicts we get into are so unnecessary.* We fight with people for trivial reasons, primarily created by negative emotions! Small things escalate into significant conflicts. People often get into huge fights and attack each other over hurt feelings. When I say attack, maybe not with an army, but with our weapons at our disposal. The weapon of choice is usually our mouths! We seek to hurt the other person somehow, which escalates to verbal and emotional warfare!

A wise person realizes conflict creates more conflict! The more conflicts we have, the less peace we will have. The more conflicts we have, the more likely we will be hindered in our success for God. We will lose focus and become dull to wisdom's voice. We will become driven by emotion and ego. That is a foolish way to live! *Solomon's advice is well-heeded. Avoid unnecessary conflicts! Avoid even thinking about it!*

“THE WISE HEAR THE SECRET OF GOD.”

Proverbs 3:31-32: “Envy thou not the oppressor, and choose none of his ways. For the froward is abomination to the LORD: but his secret is with the righteous.”

It was common among Kings in Solomon’s time to take what they wanted. Many would abuse or oppress those underneath them. They would also scheme in greed to take from other neighboring countries. Solomon discovered he could become the wealthiest person of his time by gaining wisdom, not taking from others.

He warned his son not to get jealous of those who seem to get away by harming others. It is easy to envy people who don’t seem to have to follow the same rules we do in following wisdom’s ways. *They don’t have to play by the rules and seem to get whatever they want.* But Solomon warned that behavior like that is an “abomination” to God. That is, it is something that displeases God. We shouldn’t oppress or abuse people to get what we want. We should go about it by following wisdom’s ways.

Then Solomon reveals the key to his success. It was God’s “secret.” *He found that God would whisper advice and counsel to him, which caused him to have everything his heart desired.* He received all his heart’s desires by listening to the Divine whisper speak to his spirit and mind. His kingdom, fortune, and fame grew peacefully, unlike those of other kings before him. *People gave to him! He didn’t have to take it!* Ships would come from all over, bringing him more wealth. *He had divine favor that created a divine fortune.* Wisdom was the key to his unparalleled success, not oppressing, cheating, or taking without regard for people!

God still whispers today, but only to those who trust His way is the Best! He still shares the secret but only with those devoted to listening!

“THE TWO SIDES OF LIFE”

Proverbs 3:33-35: “The curse of the LORD is in the house of the wicked: but he blesseth the habitation of the just. Surely he scorneth the scorners: but he giveth grace unto the lowly. The wise shall inherit glory: but shame shall be the promotion of fools.”

Solomon concluded this portion of his instruction to his son with three proverbs, pointing out the same overall lesson: There are two sides to life. One side is the lifestyle of a fool. The other side is the lifestyle of the wise. *Each path followed has its consequences.*

There *is* a blessing on the lifestyle of the wise (“just”) and a built-in curse on the lifestyle of the foolish (“wicked”). It is not that God is showing favoritism toward some and cursing others; instead, God set two paths before us, each with consequences. We can choose to live a life that is biased or choose to live a life that is cursed. *When we choose the path, we choose the consequences.*

Furthermore, the choice has consequences for our families. It is well known that a curse can be passed on from generation to generation. For example, addiction often follows generation after generation. Anger and abuse often follow from parent to child. Poverty, as do many diseases, often seems to pass from generation to generation. Conversely, success and wealth are also passed on to the next generation. Good habits also seem to be passed on to the next generation.

The obvious choice is which side of life we want to be on—the blessed or cursed side. Solomon was making a choice clear for his son, but his son would have to choose for himself, as do we! *Not only will our choice affect us, but it will most likely have powerful consequences for the next generation.*

“THE TWO SIDES OF LIFE 2”

Proverbs 3:33-35: “The curse of the LORD is in the house of the wicked: but he blesseth the habitation of the just. Surely he scorneth the scorners: but he giveth grace unto the lowly. The wise shall inherit glory: but shame shall be the promotion of fools.”

The second proverb Solomon uses to point out the two sides of life concerns a “scorner.” A scorner is someone who is hard-headed and becomes hard-hearted toward wisdom. Instead of learning from the hardships they experience, scorners become more blameful and disrespectful to any source of wisdom. They reject parents, pastors, and principles, much to their demise.

God backs off these types of people and leaves them to the consequences of their disrespectful attitudes. *He loves them*, but he knows they will only reject his voice or the voice of wisdom. He lets them live out the consequences of rejecting wisdom’s ways. Their lives are incredibly hard because their hearts are hardened. They experience pain without learning. They experience loss without recovery. They are miserable in life! They have anger at everyone except the one causing their problem: *themselves!*

The opposite is that God gives help or “grace” to the humble. Why does God give them help? *Because they are willing to receive it!* They are humble enough to see they need wisdom’s help. Their hearts are *receptive* and *respectful!* Their hearts are *soft* and *sensitive* to the divine whisper. As a result, their way is easier. They learn from pain. They recover from mistakes and desire better! They are teachable and trainable. They appreciate God’s blessings. They appreciate the sources of wisdom. They live humbly, believing they need God’s help, so they receive it!

The humble live on the better side of life! The scorner lives on the bitter side of life! Which do you desire?

“THE TWO SIDES OF LIFE 3”

Proverbs 3:33-35: “The curse of the LORD is in the house of the wicked: but he blesseth the habitation of the just. Surely he scorneth the scorners: but he giveth grace unto the lowly. The wise shall inherit glory: but shame shall be the promotion of fools.”

Solomon’s final proverb points out that the wise will “inherit glory” and the foolish will receive “shame.” *The two sides of life create different reputations.* On the wise side, they earn a reputation for honor and respect. On the foolish side, they are known for their shame. The wise are esteemed, and the foolish cause embarrassment.

So, it comes down to this point. Are we going to live our lives in a way that causes us to be a source of esteem for those around us? Or are we going to be a source of embarrassment to them? *What will be our ultimate reputation?* We all have embarrassing moments or seasons, but God forbid it becomes a lifetime. The wise find the way back on track, and can even turn shame into something of value. The fool continues embarrassing themselves and others with a moment of caring about it.

Is your path right now going to lead you to a place of honor or shame? Look down the road. Do you see it ending with esteem or embarrassment? *If people were speaking at your funeral today, would they be holding you up in honor or holding you back from speaking of your shame?* Will you be regarded for your wisdom or remembered for your foolishness? Now is the time to choose your final reputation while you can still make a choice and create change!

“LISTEN TO LEARN”

Proverbs 4:1-4: “Hear, ye children, the instruction of a father, and attend to know understanding. For I give you good doctrine, forsake ye not my law. For I was my father’s son, tender and only beloved in the sight of my mother. He taught me also, and said unto me, Let thine heart retain my words: keep my commandments, and live.”

Solomon reminds his son to listen and pay attention (“attend”) to the things he is being taught. He was instructing his son to “listen to learn.” Listen with the intent of gaining knowledge and wisdom. That is the way to gain wisdom and get understanding.

Listening with the intent of learning is a characteristic of the wise and separates them from the foolish. Some people hear but don’t hear. They hear with their ears but not with their minds. They listen to appease the other person. *They listen out of obligation but not to gain knowledge or get the point.*

The same can be said of reading. We read with our eyes and not with our minds. Many people read their Bibles out of routine without actually gaining wisdom. They may even know facts but miss the personal application. Many students read textbooks without getting the information. *The wise desire knowledge and wisdom, so they read with the intent to learn and grow, not just get through it.*

Make it a personal goal to follow Solomon’s advice and become a learner. Be resolved to listen and learn. Become obsessed with learning something from every sermon, seminar, or simple conversation. Make your mind engaged! It takes discipline and a desire to grow!

“LEADERS ARE LEARNERS”

Proverbs 4:1-4: “Hear, ye children, the instruction of a father, and attend to know understanding. For I give you good doctrine, forsake ye not my law. For I was my father’s son, tender and only beloved in the sight of my mother. He taught me also, and said unto me, Let thine heart retain my words: keep my commandments, and live.”

Solomon reminds his son that he wasn’t always the wealthy, wise king. He was once just a boy needing to be taught by his father. He had to decide to listen and learn, too. He had to choose to “retain” what his father, David, taught him. Before becoming a good father, he had to learn to be a good son. He had to be a good student before being a good teacher. He had to decide to be a good follower before becoming a good leader!

Solomon knew being a learner was the key to every success his son could achieve. *It would be essential for him to be a successful leader.* Leaders have to be like Solomon and be lifelong learners. He was a student of life for life. Solomon never stopped growing and gaining knowledge. He was *gifted* with divine wisdom, but continuously pursued wisdom and understanding! His journey of wisdom began with listening and learning at his father’s feet.

We need to model Solomon’s example of being a lifelong learner. Before we can teach others, we must model that we are teachable! Before we can be leaders, we must be learners! All our success will be because of what we learn. The way to get more success is to learn more! Knowledge and understanding are power and potential!

What have you learned recently? How are you learning on purpose? Whose feet are you sitting at for instruction and information? *Decide today to be a student first and foremost.* Leaders are learners, and learners become leaders!

“WISDOM IS THE MAIN THING”

Proverbs 4:5-9: “Get wisdom, get understanding: forget it not; neither decline from the words of my mouth. Forsake her not, and she shall preserve thee: love her, and she shall keep thee. Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding. Exalt her, and she shall promote thee: she shall bring thee to honour, when thou dost embrace her. She shall give to thine head an ornament of grace: a crown of glory shall she deliver to thee.”

In verse 7, Solomon clearly states that wisdom is the main thing. It was to be his son's main priority and pursuit. Also, through inspiration, God is saying the same thing to us. We need to make wisdom the *main priority* in our lives! If we do, we will improve in every area of our lives. We need to make getting wisdom our *main passion*! If we do, we will be better off in life.

Notice Solomon says, “get wisdom,” referring to the fact that it takes effort. Getting wisdom is a purposeful activity. Wisdom doesn't come accidentally. It is pursued with passion. It will only reveal itself to those who make it “the principal thing.” *Wisdom does not compete with other things.* It will be the main priority and will not be second. It has its rightful place or no place in our lives.

“Getting wisdom” *begins* with the understanding that it is the main thing! It is the most valuable thing we can get! It is the fundamental thing that does for us what nothing else can. It is the divine frequencies on which God whispers to those who qualify themselves. How do we qualify? By realizing that wisdom is the principal thing! By making wisdom our priority, passion, and primary pursuit!

We cannot expect to “get wisdom” with a half-hearted, haphazard attitude! Remember earlier, Solomon taught that it was the most valuable treasure. It was a divine commodity that had blessed him beyond measure or calculation. It had made him successful and sought after as a teacher, leader, and decision-maker! He knew it could do the same for his son, and God knows it can do the same for us!

“WISDOM IS THE MAIN THING 2”

Proverbs 4:5-9: “Get wisdom, get understanding: forget it not; neither decline from the words of my mouth. Forsake her not, and she shall preserve thee: love her, and she shall keep thee. Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding. Exalt her, and she shall promote thee: she shall bring thee to honour, when thou dost embrace her. She shall give to thine head an ornament of grace: a crown of glory shall she deliver to thee.”

Wisdom is the main thing because it will protect (“preserve”) and guard (“keep”) us. It will keep us from making those life-altering, adverse decisions. It will be a protective influence, sometimes protecting us from ourselves. It influences us for God and our good!

Wisdom is the main thing because it allows us to “get the understanding” to make good decisions. It allows us to make decisions based on wisdom, not just experience. Therefore, we experience more success and less heartache from learning things the hard way. It gives us discretion and discernment!

Wisdom is the main thing because it will bring out our greatness. It will “promote” us by bringing out our potential! It will cause us to experience success. It will allow us to be honored! It will allow us to be rewarded and recognized like receiving a “crown of glory”. No other force on earth can do for us what wisdom can because it is divine in its source. Solomon exemplified this!

However, Solomon again reminds us that these benefits are conditional and contingent. If we “exalt” and “embrace” wisdom, it (“she”) will promote and exalt us. Because Solomon is speaking to his son, he personifies wisdom as a woman. We are to be married to wisdom! Wisdom is to be our lifelong partner in all we do! If we love and respect “her,” she will bless us with incredible benefits!

“CHOOSE WHO INFLUENCES YOU”

Proverbs 4:10-17: “Hear, O my son, and receive my sayings; and the years of thy life shall be many. I have taught thee in the way of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths... Enter not into the path of the wicked, and go not in the way of evil men. Avoid it, pass not by it, turn from it, and pass away. For they sleep not, except they have done mischief; and their sleep is taken away, unless they cause some to fall. For they eat the bread of wickedness, and drink the wine of violence.”

Solomon pleads with his son to listen to his wise teaching and pleads for him to avoid “the path of the wicked.” Solomon says, “Let me influence you, not people who will lead you into trouble.” *Solomon, the wise, knew the question was not if others would influence his son but only if the influence would be helpful or hurtful.*

The same applies to us. We will be influenced by others. People who help us or hurt us will influence our real choices. The people who influence us are either positive influences or negative influences. They help us become wise or foolish.

We can choose the influencers in our lives, but once we do, they put us on a “path.” At the end of that path is a consequence. In the text, examples are “long life”, “wickedness”, and “violence”. The path of the foolish is causing hurt and pain to others. The path of the wise would be the opposite of that... helping others and eliminating pain.

Most people don’t consciously choose their influences. They just become products of their environment. They do what their friends do or what they see in their family structure. Solomon is pointing out to his son that he can choose his influences and should choose wisely. How? By looking down the path of those who will be their influencers, discerning if it is helpful or hurtful, and asking if it is positive or negative, will they help me become wiser or more foolish? Will they influence me to prosperity or poverty? Will they influence me toward God or away from God?

“HOW WE INFLUENCE OTHERS”

Proverbs 4:10-11: “Hear, O my son, and receive my sayings; and the years of thy life shall be many. I have taught thee in the way of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths”

It is vital to take note of what Solomon says in these verses. He asked his son to “receive” his teaching because he taught him what was right and “led” him in what was right. He was saying I’ve *instructed* you with *integrity*. We would say I’ve practiced what I preached.

The wise Solomon knew that he had a chance to influence someone. It was important that we both teach and then lead the way. People learn more from what we do than what we say! The voice of our example will always speak louder than the voice of our teaching. Solomon communicated that he was congruent in his actions, following his instructions.

Solomon knew his son would still have to choose which path to follow, but he could say with integrity, “Follow me.” He used all he could to influence his son by teaching and leading. Wise people will follow Solomon’s methods and use both the power of words and the power of leadership.

Teachers instruct, but leaders inspire. Teachers say how to live, but leaders show how to live. Teachers speak to the mind, but leaders speak to the heart. So with this knowledge, we need the power of both to influence others positively. We live in a world with many loud, foolish voices trying to influence people we care about. We cannot afford not to use both powers, teaching and leadership, to influence people we care about for the better. Influence is like money in the bank. We can’t use what we don’t have!

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Solomon teaches his son that his most important responsibility is to “keep” his heart. He was instructing his son to *manage his mind*. It was his responsibility to manage his mind. It was not an automatic process, but an essential one for sure. *In the text’s original language, this is the most critical charge above every other instruction Solomon had given him.* He would never be able to follow wisdom’s instructions if he didn’t manage his mind. He couldn’t avoid the temptations around him if he didn’t control his thoughts. He would never be able to respect, revere, and “fear” God unless his thoughts were correct. It all begins in the mind or “heart”!

Solomon, in all his divine wisdom, knew this was the essential truth.

We have revealed certain truths by giving him this charge to manage his mind. The first is that we can manage our minds! It is within our power. It is the only thing that God has given us dominion over. *Everything else is a by-product of this, including the power of choice.* We make choices based on how we are thinking at the moment. Even Adam and Eve reveal this as they explain their thoughts before making that life-altering choice. They allowed their minds to be influenced from the outside (the serpent and each other). That is, they didn’t “keep” their hearts. So, because they allowed the *Garden of their mind* to be corrupted, they corrupted the Garden.

We can manage our minds. We can keep our hearts. God never asks us what we cannot do. We can control our thoughts! Of course, we cannot control them *perfectly*, but we can control them *successfully*. We can be victims of our thoughts, or we can become victorious over our thoughts. Negative influences and thoughts can dominate us, or we can choose to dominate our thoughts! We may feel helpless in controlling our thoughts, but we create that feeling of helplessness through our thinking.

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 2”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Not only *can* we manage our minds or “keep” our hearts, but we must also manage our minds! It is the only way to live by *design* and not by *default*. If we don’t “keep” our hearts, others will deliberately influence us, and we will give in to any thought, emotion, or desire. We will be like a ship drifting at sea, driven by random winds, storms, or tides. We will be driven here and there, up and down, all without deliberate purpose or guiding principles. We must steer our minds in the direction God has proposed for us! If we aren’t in control of our minds, then we are out of control.

It is not God’s realm (will) to control our thoughts! If that were true, we wouldn’t be free moral agents or have the power of choice. He gave us the will to make the right and righteous choices. I have heard people *ask* God *to take thoughts away* from them, but the absolute truth is that God *wants us to give our thoughts up for Him*. He will not remove it because it is the realm in which he has given us responsibility. God will strengthen us, but we must use the power He has given us to manage our minds.

“Keep” is a continuous action. It is staying proactive and managing our thoughts. It is a 24/7 job. Solomon said to do it “with all diligence”! He expressed that he worked harder at managing your thoughts and mind than anything else you do! We cannot take a day off or even a moment. We must guard our minds at all times and all costs! Why? All of our life flows from the well of our hearts; if our minds are corrupted, the rest of our lives will be too. If our minds are negative, then our lives will be too! If we allow negative things to grow inside the *garden of our hearts*, it will not be long before the harvest of negative grows on the outside!

I have deliberately used the phrases *garden of our mind* or *garden of our heart* because that is the best metaphor for understanding how we are to “keep” our hearts. *A garden left unattended or neglected will destroy itself*. It will grow all the wrong things, like weeds and briars, choking anything producing positive fruit or life. So, the mind left unattended or unmanaged will produce weeds. With great ease, it will produce negative thoughts, emotions, habits, and ultimately, adverse outcomes. Because of our Adamic nature, our minds, like the soil, will grow useless

things faster and easier than productive, fruitful things. Having a positive, fruitful, spiritual mind takes more effort than a negative, dysfunctional one. Solomon knew this and said to his son, “Keep your heart with all your effort!

Another possibility is that someone else will tend to the garden in our laziness and plant what they want to grow in us. It happens all the time. In our culture, it happens more than we realize with all the media, marketing, and messages we are exposed to. Each one desires to plant a seed in your “heart” that influences you somehow. Our “friends” and associates also take advantage of our laziness as keepers of our minds, further influencing our beliefs and behaviors. *We would be surprised at how much that is growing in us and consequently out of us that had been planted by someone else.* Often, without our best or God’s interest in their planting!

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 3”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

As we continue to focus on our most significant responsibility of managing our minds or keeping the garden of our hearts, let’s amplify the verse a little. The word “keep” was divinely chosen to help us understand what to do or how to manage our minds. It has multiple meanings, but all are applicable.

“Keep” means to guard. It means constant vigilance, looking out for negative or unproductive thoughts, and alertly looking out for hurtful or harmful thoughts. The image is of a soldier standing guard, proactively looking for an attack from an enemy. They are on guard against covert or sneak attacks and full-on assaults. Similarly, we must always be on guard against outside, opposing forces attacking us through our thoughts.

“Keep” also means to inspect. Guarding means keeping outside things from coming in, and inspecting means continuously searching for harmful, dangerous, and unproductive things *already inside us*. How they got there or who planted them isn’t as important as finding and getting rid of them. It may never be known when it was planted, but taking action is essential to remove the contaminating thought or belief. Inspecting our mind is simply becoming aware of our thoughts, especially the ones that seem habitual. Most people never think about what they are thinking about. They are almost in a hypnotic state, following whatever suggestion or stimulus is given to them.

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 4”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.” (new page)

The second part of the verse further adds *importance* and *urgency* to managing our minds. Solomon instructed his son that his outer life would be directly related to his “heart.” That is, his outer world will become the physical manifestation of his thoughts. It didn’t matter if he was born into wealth; if he didn’t “keep” his heart, he would descend into poverty. It wasn’t enough to have the wisest father of all time instructing him because he would waste his father’s advice if he didn’t manage his mind.

Many Christians forget this is a divine principle and not some self-help teaching. *Even Jesus taught that our outer life is a reflection of the heart.* So, it would be wise to follow this principle! We need to remember we *are created in the image of God.* We are spiritual beings, so our thoughts and words transcend our bodies and brains. They have creative power. After the Adamic fall, this divine gift can be used to create things that are a blessing or a curse. We can create things from our minds that honor God or dishonor him. One thing for sure is that we can create!

We are constantly creating! Again, our thoughts are never neutral. Our thoughts create our feelings and attitudes. They create our beliefs and behaviors. They push away God’s blessing or attract it. They attract some people to us while repelling others. Thoughts become mental images that take on a life of their own. Only humankind can envision something and create it. *I said all that to say we have no idea how powerful our thoughts are!* Jesus said a thought is as good as a deed! He said if someone thinks about committing murder, God sees them as committing it. Why?

Because thoughts are the beginning of a cause set in motion, they are seeds with all the power and potential to make it a reality!

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 5”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Think of your mind (“heart”) this way. It is a valve that opens us up to God or shuts us off from God. God’s influence and power can flow through us if the right thoughts open the mind and focus. If the mind is closed by wrong thoughts, we are closed-minded to God, His power, and influence.

Matthew 13:38 said Jesus wouldn’t do many mighty works in his “home” because of their unbelief. Unbelief is how they were thinking about him. Notice I said He wouldn’t, not that He couldn’t! He had the power, but they closed their minds to the power of their negative thoughts about Him!

Similarly, even the Disciples who were converts or Christians already limited God’s power in their lives because of their unbelief. They couldn’t create results because their thoughts closed off the valve, so nothing divine could get through. Then, Jesus taught that if we have faith, we can do the impossible because of the divine power flowing through us. The process of thinking creates Faith! Matthew 17:28 It isn’t some mysterious force. It is *developed* or *destroyed* within the process of our thoughts!

In Matthew 9:19-22, we find another divine revelation about our thoughts, creating faith, thus opening us up to divine power. The Spirit points out that the woman seeking healing “said within herself.” What she thought became a reality! Jesus referred to her as he always did. He said, “Thy faith has made you whole. Jesus always referred to faith as something in our control or possession! He did the same with unbelief. Why? He knew we create both by how we think and what we think about! It is our responsibility!

“OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 6”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.” (new page)

Not only did Solomon, in his wisdom, teach the importance of managing our minds, but so did the Apostle Paul. Paul was probably the *wisest man* in the New Testament. *He admonished the believers to choose what they thought about.* They were not to dwell on negative things. They were to force and focus their minds on thinking positive, pure, and productive thoughts! He wrote the following with the Divine influence: “Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things” (Philippians 4:8).

He instructed that we should deliberately, consciously choose what we think about! In other words, we are to manage our minds. Notice he, too, implied that we are in charge of what we think. We must use the God-given power of choice to focus and force our minds to think about positive, productive things. It is our responsibility, even with the indwelling Spirit. We should not let our minds be undisciplined or wander onto negative things. Our minds should not be on automatic pilot, but we should remain at the helm, steering them in the right direction. We must remain diligent and alert!

Paul also realized that transformation was caused by “renewing” our minds (Romans 1:22). The mind thinking wrong thoughts will shut out God’s influence, thus limiting transformation. The mind thinking the right thoughts will be open to God’s influence and will continue the transformation process. Change and growth are created when we think about the right things in the right way. Change and growth will stop if we stop thinking about the right things in the right way. Further, new thoughts create new growth!

“THOUGHTS CREATE”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he:”

As we think, we behave. Solomon is teaching his son that a person’s heart will determine their action even if they say the opposite. The more important principle is that our behaviors aren’t random but are caused and created by our thoughts. My behavior is a reflection and a reaction to my thoughts. If I think fearfully, I will have fearful behaviors. People with phobias have complete physical and emotional reactions to imaginary stimuli. Their thoughts create the behaviors. If I think of faith and confidence, my behavior will also reflect that. Loving thoughts produce loving behavior, and mean thoughts produce mean behavior. To see what’s happening in a person’s mind, look at their behavior.

As we think, we believe. As we saw in our New Testament example and the teachings of Jesus, our faith is a product of our thinking. My genuine belief is not what I say I believe but what I think. Many say one thing but habitually think the contrary. For example, people would say God answers prayers. Yet, at the same time, their minds continuously think of thoughts of doubt. So, their real belief is that God doesn’t answer my prayers. We have beliefs on paper, but don’t always become actual personal beliefs. What we think creates what we believe. What we believe determines what we receive and achieve.

As we think, we become. As Paul taught, our mind is the key to transformation. However, that works in the negative too. King Saul started thinking thoughts of jealousy and went from a mighty leader to an insecure, psychotic mess of a man. Our thoughts can build us up to heights or tear us down to shocking levels. Our thoughts are the most significant determining factor in who we will become in the future. Our thoughts today are creating who we will become in the near future.

Our thoughts are creating feelings right now that are affecting our behavior right now. Our feelings aren’t random. They are self-produced. Even when others induce them, they continue because of our thinking. We give real life to what they sow. We could also dismiss their input and feel what we want to feel. Our thoughts are fueling our faith right now, or they are feeding our doubts. What we believe right now, positive or negative, is because of what we are thinking about

and how we are thinking. Right now, we are becoming better, or we are getting worse. We are becoming something! The question is, who are we becoming? What are we becoming? How will we behave? What beliefs are we creating?

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he...”

By now, we can understand the importance of managing our minds. However, its real power and potential for good or bad have just been touched. We are all on the elementary levels in our understanding of the divine function given exclusively to humankind, which is called thinking. This is certain: we become what we think about most of the time. *We will never be more spiritual than our thoughts.* We will only be as happy as our thoughts allow us to be. We will only have as much faith as we think we have. Our thoughts can limit us and also limit God’s work in our lives. Managing our minds is our most important responsibility.

How do we apply this divine truth to better ourselves and create a better future? It begins with our knowledge and continues with being diligent in being aware of our thoughts. This gets easier over time as we manage our minds consistently. The Spirit will help with this awareness until it is grieved. Here’s the thing about the mind: once it starts ignoring something, it becomes blind to it. Like the first time we notice something wrong in our house or car but dismiss it mentally, it’s not long before we no longer notice it. The same works against us if we see something negative in our thoughts or behaviors. It won’t be long before we stop being aware of it. By ignoring it, we are giving the harmful thing permission to grow in our minds and, consequently, our lives. If we see a weed and refuse to pull it, we give it the right to stay and produce.

God has given us the unique ability to be self-aware. We can “hear” ourselves think. We can “look” within ourselves. *This ability isn’t an accident but is given to us with Divine purpose as a tool to manage our minds.* We can be introspective or inspect ourselves for our thoughts. We have been given a spirit to shed light on our inner selves. Solomon wrote, “The spirit of man is the candle of the LORD, searching all the inward parts of the belly” (Proverbs 20:27). So, we can become aware of our thoughts. The issue is, will we take on *the responsibility*? Will we control our thoughts, or will our thoughts control us? Will we dominate our thoughts or allow our thoughts to dominate us? If we don’t dominate our thoughts, they will dominate us! We will feel helpless and hopeless in controlling feelings and behaviors, but that is only a self-created prophecy.

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 2”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he: ...”

Continuing to answer the question, how do we apply the divine truth of managing our mind, our most important responsibility? We need to do what Paul instructed: *start thinking on purpose*. If we don't direct our mind by focusing on specific things, it will give in to any stimulus, which is usually negative. The undirected mind will go toward its nature, thinking about negative things. It will become dominated by the power of negative emotions or become weakened by focusing on too many things. The mind, undirected, will be very active but not very productive!

Thinking on purpose is just like gardening. You decide what you want to plant in your space and then continuously eliminate anything else that tries to grow. So, thinking on purpose begins with a clear intent. You *must decide what fruit you want to grow within you!* It is hard to recognize what doesn't belong there until that happens. Your self-awareness will increase once you focus on the positive and productive things you want to grow with your heart. If you want love to grow, it will simultaneously allow you to spot the weed of hostility or hatred. Eliminating unproductive thoughts and beliefs will be essential to protect what you want to grow within.

We not only have to eliminate what we don't want to grow, but we also have to cultivate what we want to grow continuously. It is not enough to decide what we want to grow within us. We must also feed it, protect it, and nurture it. The decision and choice to grow a particular thing within is the planting. It begins with the power of intention but grows through the power of attention. It becomes our focus! When our minds wander to something contrary, we detect it, *immediately* directing our minds back to what we desire to grow within and produce without!

Focus is like fertilizer. It stimulates growth! Whatever we focus on grows while becoming stronger! If focused on long enough, the thought in focus will bear fruit and create new life. As stated before, negative things usually grow faster than positive and productive things. Therefore, *focusing* on the negatives will be

dangerous because they multiply. Also, because it takes energy and life away from the positive and productive things, we decided to grow within ourselves. Focus creates emotion, and emotion stimulates the growth of thoughts into reality faster than anything. Again, creating negative emotions with our thoughts seems easier and faster than creating intense positive emotions.

Exercise: Until the following devotion, try to *become aware of what you are fertilizing* and causing to grow with your focus. Primarily, be aware when your mind “wanders off” in thought.

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 3”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he...”

Again, as we think, we believe. To apply this principle to our beliefs and create positive, productive beliefs, we must think purposefully in this area, too! When I say our belief, I’m speaking of our theological statements or statements of faith, but what you believe about those things deep down in your heart. For example, our theology states God answers prayers, but our psychology can doubt God will answer our prayers on a personal, practical level. We can sing songs proclaiming our belief that God is good, but our hearts feel sad and poor. Then, within minutes, we start complaining about our lives. This incongruence between our theology and psychology leads to confusion, frustration, and doubt. We begin to realize our “faith” is not working as it should, and many start blaming God. However, the solution and problem aren’t on God’s end but in how we think.

My faith is a product of my thoughts. In Psalm 1, David said he meditates on God’s Law, day and night; because of that, he is stable, rooted, and fruitful. *He focused his thoughts purposefully on what was inspired and became inspired.* His meditation became his manifestation. He thought productively within and produced without. He is like a tree growing by a river with a water source independent from the rain that may or may not come. *He fed his faith by what he focused on.* He knew it would produce fruit if he kept doing that in time. He knew that he would prosper regardless of external circumstances because he was thinking right on the inside. *His belief grew within and produced without* because he focused his thoughts on what would *feed* his faith. Simultaneously, he was *starving* doubts that could’ve been caused by looking at outward circumstances. Psalms 1:2-3 “But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night. And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper.”

Remember, focus is a fertilizer. Whatever we focus on is strengthened, and the opposite is weakened. If we want to grow spiritually, we need to focus, as David did, on what is inspired and has spiritual life. If we want to increase our faith,

we need to think in ways that increase our faith. We can think about the promises given or experiences where our faith produced an outcome. We can imagine our prayers being answered or great things happening for us. However, most are like the disciples in the boat, imagining they will “perish” in the storm. Instead of seeing their faith manifesting the positive, they see their fear coming to pass. That, in turn, weakens their belief despite their theology! Genuine belief is what we experience, not what we express!

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 4”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he...”

Thinking to develop and strengthen our beliefs is a potent tool. It is a powerful thing to think on purpose. It allows the promises contained in the Bible to take root in our minds and produce fruit in our lives. It allows us to build up ourselves in our faith. (Jude 1:20) It enables the influence and illumination of the Spirit to help us grow.

On the other hand, if we think doubtful, anxious thoughts, it hinders and grieves the Spirit. Wrong thinking can and will destroy our faith and kill spiritual growth. Paul wrote, “For to be carnally minded is death, but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.” Romans 8:6 says that if we want spiritual power and progress, we must be spiritually minded. That is the process of thinking spiritual thoughts. Again, we will never be more spiritual than our thoughts. We will never have more faith than our thoughts allow us to have.

We must make our theological beliefs congruent with our psychological beliefs by thinking *purposefully*, *powerfully*, and *personally*. Here are a few examples: God can answer prayers, which becomes God is answering my prayers. God is love, which becomes God loves me and has proven it in my life. God is good, which becomes God is so good to me, and I am so blessed every day. Thinking in personal terms **will** create the belief that it is a reality in our lives!

To further *amplify your beliefs*, find a biblical promise to focus on. Fertilize that seed in your heart by focusing on it. *Meditate* on it. *Memorize* it. *Make* it yours. For example, “And all things, whatsoever ye shall ask in prayer, believing, ye shall receive.” Matthew 21:22 can be personalized and amplified by saying and thinking, “I ask all things believing, therefore, I will receive what I ask for,” or “I will receive because I believe.” Notice how thinking that will *create an expectation* while *stating positively* that you believe. It strengthens and *supports* your belief.

The following way to think so you can personalize and amplify your beliefs is to focus on times you saw or experienced the manifestation of the belief. To keep

with our example, think about a time when your prayer was answered, *review* it, and *relive* it.

Then rehearse the future experience. Use the power of creative thinking to experience the result in advance. Think about that prayer being answered! Think about how you will feel! Think about what would be said or done when it is answered. That is how to think powerfully and personalize your beliefs!

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 5”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he...”

As we think, we become a powerful principle to harness! It is purposefully using the divine power that God has granted us to become on purpose. In my experience, many people never pre-decide what and who they will become. It just happens as they go *through life*. A better way of living is deciding what and who we become based on purpose, allowing us to grow *through life*. We can choose to be more loving, have more faith, and be joyful. We can choose to become an encourager, a good finder. We can be whatever we want to be! We do not have to remain as we are and be victimized by our weaknesses. Some may be inherited weaknesses, natural dispositions, or weaknesses created by our environment, but believe this. We can become more, better, and different! God has given us all we need to become on purpose.

Most people live by *default*, not by *design*. They live by a subconscious default, letting what others say and think affect who and what they become. External influences program them, and many aren't positive. They allow past events to define who they are and will be. That leads to a feeling of helplessness and creates a victim *mentality that disables them*. They even close out the “voice” of God that whispers hope and offers help. They feel stuck, like the mold of their identity has been cast permanently. They settle for who they are when change, growth, and transformation are still possible!

Living by design means using the power of conscious choice to design and decide who we will become. Notice the thought of “will become” because that's what takes place; it is willing a change. God has given us that power to use, and He will not force change against our wills. However, if we change, God will help us in the process. He will bring teachers and resources to aid us. Living by design is your influence, not external things, unless they are within your design plan. Living by design is partnering with God in knowing He is helping you transform if your choices are positive and productive. It realizes the power is already granted to you to become what you choose to be and reinvent yourself for the better! Deciding

to *start* living by design *enables us!* It empowers us! It is time to use that power and to start living by deliberate design. It is time to *stop* giving your God-given power to others or things that are over!

“APPLYING OUR MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSIBILITY 6”

Proverbs 4:23: “Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”

Proverbs 23:7: “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he: ...”

Thinking deliberately to become deliberate is living by Design. It is how we harness the power God has granted us. It recognizes the power of our thoughts to create and cause consequences for us in the future. Wise people will prayerfully design their future selves and lives according to their divine purposes. Instead of letting life happen, they will make it happen by utilizing the principle of what we think we become.

How do we start designing our lives? We become the architects of our lives. God gives us life, but His Sovereignty allows us to build something wonderful or awful. He allows us to succeed or completely fail and waste it. God’s gift to you is your life. Your gift to Him is what you do with it! We can develop something beautiful or destroy our beautiful lives. One thing is sure, neither will be random. The outcome will be because of our Design or our default.

Becoming the Architect of your life begins with a *Design Concept*. A general picture or the architectural rendering of what the completed project would look like. It is designed with its function (purpose) in mind. Who and how do you want to be in the future? I always suggest we have a “to-be list” before we make a “to-do list” because even if you do it (your goal), you will only maintain it if it’s who you are! What do you want to achieve or accomplish in your future? How will you succeed at your purposes? What do you want to have in your life in the future? The answer to these questions will help you conceptualize your future. Please write it down as you imagine it. Try to sum it up in a few paragraphs.

Next is *Designing the Details*. That is where the sections are broken down into separate plans, such as foundation, structural, mechanical, electrical, etc. No details that are necessary and practical are left out. Divide your concept into compartments of you: personal, personal development, professional, ministry (contribution), things, and so on. An example of personal development could be: I will be incredibly fit. Then describe what the result would look like for you. As you think more and more about it and review it, you will fertilize it.

Then, it will be time to develop the Design. That is the time to divide it all into steps and stages. Construction starts in small ways, like getting permits, clearing property, etc. Begin each day with the end in mind—your design plan! Plan and prioritize each day to make progress toward the completion of the overall Design Concept.

Remember, God is your Senior Partner, so be sure to check with Him every step of the way!

“MOUTH MANAGEMENT”

Proverbs 4:24: “Put away from thee a froward mouth, and perverse lips put far from thee.”

Solomon taught his son the importance of managing his mind and *instructed him to manage his mouth*. That is the first of several verses or proverbs that Solomon teaches the Importance of purposefully choosing and using our words.

He is instructing his son not to use “forward” speech. We would say not to use double talk or deceptive speech. Then he was instructed not to waste his words in foolish talking. The word “perverse” means talking with no value or purpose; for example, useless chatter, gossip, and exaggerations of the truth.

Essentially, we are to speak with purpose. *We must realize our words are powerful because we are created in God’s image*. They are like our thoughts because they have creative power and evoke emotion. Talking to talk is dangerous for anyone, especially a leader. Solomon knew he had to be on guard about what he said almost as much as he thought.

Unlike most thoughts, most words have an immediate outward effect on the hearers. It may take a while for thoughts to manifest results, but words are like arrows going immediately from us to somewhere or someone. So, we are to aim them with purpose! We should never shoot random verbal arrows carelessly because they have consequences. *Jesus said we would give an account for every word*, so we are to mean what we say.

Start today by becoming aware of how much useless talk and chatter are happening with and around you. *Start noticing* how many people talk to talk. *See how* very little positive or productive communication occurs in our culture.

“MOUTH MANAGEMENT 2”

Proverbs 18:21: “Death and life are in the power of the tongue: and they that love it shall eat the fruit thereof.”

In another proverb, Solomon teaches the importance of *purposefully choosing and using our words* because they can *create life or cause death!* Our words can kill our relationship with people. They can kill our prayers. They can destroy our happiness or diminish our faith. Words can kill our dreams and hopes. Conversely, words can give life to our prayers and strengthen our faith. Words used correctly can keep relationships alive and growing. The tongue can give power to our dreams. Therefore, Solomon displays wisdom in teaching his son to practice mouth management.

Solomon says we will eat “fruit” from our words. If our words are *positive and productive, they produce life-giving fruit.* They will feed our faith and fuel our dreams. They can fortify our relationships. *The fruit will be poisonous if* our words are *harmful and destructive.* They will poison us or others as they are mentally ingested. The toxic effects may be rapid or gradual, depending on how often they are ingested and in what amounts. For example, it is usually not an occasional negative outburst that will kill a relationship, but rather a continuous flow of bad words that destroys a person’s heart. However, even the damaging, destructive occasion still has poisonous effects that must be overcome or healed. Generally, it takes seven positive inputs to overcome a negative one.

As wise people, we will want to recognize the power of the tongue and begin to harness it. We begin to know that words like our thoughts are never neutral! They are constantly creating fruit, which is either constructive or destructive. Our words are a source of health for the people who hear them, or they are a source of hurt. We are poisoning ourselves and others with our speech, or producing positive fruit in ourselves and others. So, it’s time to start taking responsibility for *what we* say and how we say it! That is how we begin to harness the power of our tongue to use it for good and God!

“MOUTH MANAGEMENT 3”

Proverbs 15:4: “A wholesome tongue is a tree of life: but perverseness therein is a breach in the spirit.”

As we begin to *practice managing our mouths*, we can practice *ministering with our mouths*. Here, Solomon teaches us that a healthy tongue will produce healing fruit. It is like a tree of life. *People who are healthy and healed can speak words that help produce health and even healing in others*. What a powerful ministry we all can share in! We can promote health and healing with our words! We can provide help and hope to others by saying the right things in the right way!

We can also hurt and crush people’s spirits when we say destructive or harmful things to them. Solomon makes it evident that *words can crush the will of people*. Words have such power that *they can break the human heart*. An unhealthy person (“perverseness”) will poison others with their words. Hurt people hurt people, especially with their words. The world is filled with negative communication because it’s full of unhealthy, hurting people. They spread their misery with their mouths. Then, destructive communication habits are passed from generation to generation, creating a dysfunctional cycle.

Many assume that because they don’t go into an angry tirade, they aren’t verbally destructive or abusive, but a great deal of hurt can be caused *without an angry voice*. It may be hidden in sarcasm or humor, but it still can destroy the spirit. It may be criticism, complaining, or an opinion, but negative produces negative. Things said from an unhealthy or hurting heart will be destructive, whether intended or not! Many adults are still living and may be trying to overcome the hurt or harm caused by their parents, who intended no harm.

Further, it is not just what we say that is destructive and hurts people; it is also *withholding constructive words*. People are starving for encouragement and edification! They need someone to speak life into their spirits! We all need people who minister to us with the healing power of words. Life-giving words are like oxygen for our souls!

“MOUTH MANAGEMENT 4”

Proverbs 15:1: “A soft answer turneth away wrath: but grievous words stir up anger.”

As stated before, our words can stimulate emotion. So “grievous words” stimulate anger or other negative emotions. They could trigger sadness, discouragement, grief, and so on. The truth is that negative words stimulate negative emotions. Angry words will stimulate and escalate anger with all of its negative behaviors. Ugly words stimulate ugly emotions, which escalate to ugly behavior. We all have had the experience of arguing over something minor. Suddenly, within moments, things escalate into a dramatic, uncharacteristic confrontation.

Why? When emotion is high, logic is low. When words stimulate our negative emotions, especially anger or hurt, it stirs up foolish behavior.

However, words said the right way could also de-escalate negative emotions. The foolish thing to do is to answer in kind. That will stimulate you and the other person more, escalating negative emotions. Our goal is to use the Law of Opposite Behavior to control ourselves while gaining control over the other person to a degree. If *you respond in kind, you pour gas on the emotional fire*. But if you respond oppositely, you pour water on the fire. Now it may not put out the fire instantly, but at least it keeps it from getting out of control. When our negative emotions catch fire, everyone involved will be burned, maybe even scarred for life, regardless of who started it.

When we learn to *manage our mouths*, we learn to *manage our emotions*. When we *manage our mouths*, we learn to *manage conflicts* and confrontations. When we learn the power of the Law of Opposite Behavior, we start putting out fires and gain freedom from self-control. We “turn away wrath” instead of feeding its flames. Remember, *like begets like*. So, learn to *respond in power*, not *react in emotion*. Responding is trying to de-escalate with the opposite, and reacting is speaking back with the same or similar negativity. Reacting to the stimulus means we have just lost our power and logic. It creates a negative cycle of negative words and behavior.

Responding differently will break the cycle of foolishness!

“MOUTH MANAGEMENT 5”

Proverbs 15:28: “The heart of the righteous studieth to answer: but the mouth of the wicked poureth out evil things.”

Since we have gained some insight into the power of our words, we can see the wisdom of this proverb from Solomon. We are to think before we speak. We must process and discern if what we are about to say is wise. *We must ask ourselves if this will build or tear them up.*

Will our words and responses stir up negative emotions or help soothe them? We should pause and ponder whether our words will be constructive or destructive. Is it from the spirit or flesh? If we sow in the spirit, we produce life; in the flesh, we produce death. (Galatians 6:8)

The foolish person allows things to pour out of their mouth. They could not care less if it blesses anyone or works evil in the hearer's life. *These people are selfish in what they say.* They do not discern what they say and don't consider the consequences. They speak out of uncontrolled emotion and say whatever they feel. They sow hurt, conflict, and destruction every day with the power God gave them to use for good. They want to “*give you a piece of their mind,*” “*speak the truth,*” “*tell it like it is,*” and “*get stuff off their chest,*” All *without* any discernment or desire to minister to others in the process.

We should think before we speak, not just speak what we think. We most likely make a mistake when we speak in emotion or haste. It is easier not to say something wrong than to try to make it right! Once the negative words are out, they cannot be removed, and the consequences may last. It is better to take a few moments to think and study what we are about to say than to deal with the consequences. A few thinking moments can save much time recovering from hurt feelings or emotional conflict.

When we are emotional, we should take extra time to think. If we are *weighed* heavily with negative emotions, we need time so we won't say negative things to others that have consequences. However, being highly charged with positive emotions can lead to mistakes, too. We tend to make commitments and say things that create obligations when we are on a high. So here, too, we must stop and think before speaking.

Develop the habit of saying, “I need time to think about that.” Or give me a moment. Check your emotions and motives before you speak. We can hit the pause button, but we can never rewind or delete! Pause and Ponder is a good form of mouth management!

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION”

Proverbs 15:2: “The tongue of the wise useth knowledge aright: but the mouth of fools poureth out foolishness.”

Proverbs 15:7: “The lips of the wise disperse knowledge: but the heart of the foolish doeth not so.”

After developing the *discipline of mouth management*, we can *develop the skill of constructive communication*. As mentioned, we can become purposeful, powerful ministers with our words. For some people, this seems to come easier than for others. However, we are all responsible for developing our skills as constructive communicators.

“The tongue of the wise useth knowledge aright” means the wise speak in an effective and appealing way to the hearer. *They learn to personalize their communications with the people they are talking to.* They don’t speak the same way to everyone. The wise communicator, coach, or counselor doesn’t use the same communication style for everyone. They learn to speak to the individual heart and mind! Parents can see the value in this wisdom.

Solomon points out that it is not enough to have “knowledge.” It is *useless* if it isn’t communicated in a way that the listener can find appealing. All of us probably have had Professors or Pastors who know but couldn’t communicate it to us in a way that engaged and enlightened us. It was painful to endure. On the other hand, we all have probably had someone teach us in a way that inspired us. It was a joy gaining knowledge at their “feet.” They made learning an enjoyable experience and encouraged us in the process. We felt like they were speaking our language.

We all have had the experience of someone saying something loving or complimentary to us that just impacted us. We *felt* what they were saying. That is constructive communication. It is using wisdom to disperse knowledge. To do this, we *must think about the listener*, not just *what we want to say*. Again, *the formula for constructive communication* is saying the right thing at the right time in the right way!

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION 2”

Proverbs 12:18: “There is that speaketh like the piercings of a sword: but the tongue of the wise is health.”

What a powerful contrast this proverb is by Solomon. He uses the *negative side of the power of communication* first. He says words can wound like being stabbed with a sword. They cut deep, hurt deep, and can even be fatal. Even if one recovers from a sword wound, one will be scarred for life.

Then on *the positive side*, he says words used wisely can and will produce health. If they can produce health, they can also help produce healing.

Again, we see that our communication can be destructive or constructive. In my observation, we seldom realize how powerful our words are. We only see part of the wound they create because we can't see all the damage below the surface. Also, we usually can't see how much they produce health inside a person because it may have positive benefits for the rest of their lives.

As I reflect on this proverb in my life, I admit I still occasionally think about hurtful things that were said long ago. I don't focus on them, but the fact that they still come to mind occasionally speaks to the power of negative, hurtful words. I also think of positive comments made to me and about me from decades ago. They are still influencing me and my beliefs. They are still producing health in my heart and mind. I can remember them like yesterday!

I want to point out that Solomon said they produce health, not just feel good. Sometimes words that produce health can be painful and healthy! *I said painful, not hurtful or harmful*. They are said in love and with the right motive, but they cause us to face a truth about ourselves that is painful but productive and constructive. Only the extremely wise communicator should do this! The difference is like the healing precision of a surgeon versus the brutal, traumatic force of a sword stabbing someone without any real motive to help or heal! Most people I know are emotionally and spiritually unqualified to do this kind of communication!

Years from now, will people remember our constructive words and still experience better health from them? Or will they remember our destructive words and still experience hurt from them? Are you scarring people for life or sowing seeds that will produce health for the rest of their lives?

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION 3”

Proverbs 10:20: “The tongue of the just is as choice silver: the heart of the wicked is little worth.”

In this proverb, Solomon teaches us that the “just” or wise have words that are like sterling silver. That means the words are refined and purified *before* they are spoken—the wise process what they say before they say it, while the foolish speak without any refinement at all.

To communicate constructively, we must refine and purify our words before speaking. That is the time to refine them because once they are out, they are already formed and fashioned into something of value or nothing of value. Once words are out, they are quickly cooled and formed. The time to shape and construct our words to have value and worth to the hearer is while they are in the molten, refining stage inside us. Process what you want purposefully and thoughtfully, and say it best! Refine it until it is pure in motive and meaning, then speak with precision and power.

Refining happens as we evaluate what we are saying and analyze why we are saying it. Am I saying this to make someone better or to make myself feel better? Am I trying to build them up or build myself up? Am I manipulating them or motivating them? Am I trying to help them or hurt them because they hurt me? My favorite question is, am I speaking in faith or reacting to fear?

We can further refine our words, making them more valuable by processing the best way to say what we say. Remember the formula for constructive communication: saying the right thing *right* at the right time. We need to *refine not only our motives* but also *our methods* of communication. Wise communicators will eliminate all the dross from communication and boil it down to only the things that have value to the hearer. It is helpful to take the negative emotions out. Refine the foolish and selfish part, and then our communication will have value. It will motivate and edify. It will inspire and illuminate the listener. It will be seen as pure and will be productive.

Solomon was a man whom people traveled the world to hear speak. The wise would come to hear his wisdom. He was a master communicator. Hundreds of people at a time waited to hear his wisdom or provide answers to their questions, so he had to learn to speak with power and precision. We can learn how to communicate constructively by applying his proverbs!

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION 4”

Proverbs 25:11: “A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in pictures of silver.”

Solomon teaches that saying the right thing at the right time (“fitly spoken”) is like a custom-designed work of art. It is something rare and unique. It takes something ordinary, everyday, like apples sitting on a table, and makes them golden apples on a silver platter. The ordinary becomes extraordinary. The everyday thing is transformed into something exquisite. That is the difference between saying something and saying the right thing in the right way! One is common, the other is a result of craftsmanship!

We are *to* be just that, craftsmen with our words! We are to form and fashion them. We are to shape them into something extraordinary, even artistic. We are to polish them. Externally, words are the most powerful thing we have access to, so why wouldn't we learn to use them with the skill of a craftsman? *We should put effort into becoming master wordsmiths.* The foolish wasted and misused this power, but the wise Solomon knew its value.

The wise person today will learn to refine their communication skills. No relationship wouldn't or couldn't benefit from enhancing our communication skills. No business wouldn't become more productive if we learned to communicate with greater skill. We could improve our lives dramatically if we prioritized becoming craftsmen with our communication. The people around us would be blessed immensely by *what* we say and *how* we say it. We would stimulate faith, love, and value within the hearts and minds of the listeners. We would inspire and influence for good and God! If we learn to become constructive communicators!

Every great craftsman or artist I've ever known or studied had a tremendous passion for their work. They paid attention to every detail! They would not allow it in the public realm until it was a masterpiece. *They develop their skills and develop the discipline with relentless passion.* They keep the item being constructed and crafted off-limits until it is ready. We should adopt the *passion* and *practices* of craftsmen in our communication! After all, we will give an account for our words!

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION 5”

Proverbs 10:22: “The lips of the righteous feed many: but fools die for want of wisdom.”

Solomon teaches two things here. First, the wise and righteous can feed people with their words. The other is that fools will not eat what the wise are offering, and they will starve—not because they have to, but because they choose to feed on foolishness instead! The foolish want to feed on what tastes good, not what is good for them!

The person who is right on the inside can and will produce words that become food for others who partake. They produce substantial communication and counsel! Their words have emotional and spiritual life in them. They produce strength and energy for those who partake of them. Their words may not always taste pleasurable, but they are always powerful! Their words may be hard to swallow, but will produce health and healing.

Notice the parody that many are being fed while, at the same time, others (“fools”) are starving because they aren’t getting the nourishment of wisdom. As constructive communicators, it is helpful to know that our best attempts to speak about life and health to people will sometimes fall on deaf ears and closed minds. We cannot force-feed people! Many would rather feed on junk food communication than healthy food communication.

The obvious question is, are we just providing junk for them to eat? Do they feel stronger because of what we say, or are we causing them to be sick with our foolishness? We should be communicators that others can turn to when hungry for good advice! We should be a resource for them to find encouragement when needed! We should be a refreshing fountain of faith in a desert of doubt! We should develop a reputation for people knowing they can trust our counsel because we will tell them what is good for them, not just what sounds good to them! When they leave our table, they feel nourished and ready to face the future! They should never feel run down, torn down, and beaten up when they leave from feeding on our communications!

“CONSTRUCTIVE COMMUNICATION 6”

Proverbs 16:24: “Pleasant words are as an honeycomb, sweet to the soul, and health to the bones.”

Solomon teaches here that words that positively affect emotion powerfully affect our health. Again, words stimulate emotion, so positive words positively stimulate the soul, stimulating health. Scientists and medical doctors are just beginning to realize what Solomon knew a few thousand years ago. A healthy soul helps create health. The prescription for a healthy soul is regular doses of positive, pleasant words.

Interestingly, Solomon chooses “bones” to represent the body. They are the body’s support system. Kind words strengthen, support, and build up the body. They fortify the body’s immune system and create energy. Pleasant words are a powerful force in maintaining a healthy mind, and a healthy mind produces a healthy body.

We all can be powerful forces by being kind, pleasant, and positive with our words. We can sow hope and health in the souls of others. We can support and strengthen with our kind words. We can positively affect people every day and everywhere we go by being kind and pleasant in our communication. The person who does this will make people feel better, and that produces health. It may seem silly to think that words have such power, but it is true!

We can make a difference by being positive and pleasant in our communication! We also must be purposeful and prayerful in finding the right thing to say at the right time. It is wise to develop the habit of speaking with kindness and positive intention to *everyone* we meet. The people who need it the most are the ones we want to be least pleasant to. Nevertheless, the habit must be continued! Being positive and kind is not easy when verbalizing how we feel for many people! So, it may be awkward initially for it to become a part of our personality. However, it will become more natural as we practice this proverb.

Also, we need to see that the opposite of this verse is true. Unkind words can cause bitterness to the human soul and psyche. They can diminish and even destroy a person’s health. Ultimately, the body will only be as healthy as the soul is! True health begins in the soul; we can directly minister to it by speaking kind, pleasant words. We can, with positive intentions, strengthen the psyche of a person! As we minister to others this way, we also positively feed our souls! This energy stimulates our well-being at the same time.

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATION”

Proverbs 18:8: “The words of a talebearer are as wounds, and they go down into the innermost parts of the belly.”

As we saw in the previous devotion, pleasant words can be like medicine to the soul and body. Kind words can help stimulate health in the heart and the body. However, it is vital to pause again to realize that words can also wound and poison the soul. Solomon said they go down to the very core of a person. These unpleasant words can be heartrending. Further, these words are destructive to the psyche and eventually cause physical illness.

Solomon’s clear words cause wounds and create internal illness. The systemic nature of our being will eventually cause the soul’s wounds to manifest in the body. It may take a while, but soul sickness will have physical consequences. When examined with an open mind, we see that most physical diseases have soul sickness at their genesis. It may be that a wound on the inside is self-medicated with a destructive habit that further creates a disease, but it goes back to a wound in the soul. Regardless, if we trace back far enough, we will find a trigger of destructive words or a lack of constructive words.

A “talebearer” is not just a person who lies but also spreads the negative truth! They spread negative news everywhere they go! It may be talking about a natural disaster or gossiping about a person, but it is always a negative topic of conversation. How lousy something or someone is will be a constant topic of their communication. They will tell any negative tale, whether it’s fiction or fact. They sow negativity and hurt virtually with every breath.

So, in the light of that illumination, are you a talebearer? Do you wound people with your unkind words? Are you a destructive force or a constructive force? *Analyze yourself honestly.* Are you known as someone who builds people up when you speak, or do people feel torn down? *Examine your topics of conversation.* Do they gravitate toward the negative or the positive? Ask your friends and family that same question!

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATIONS 2”

Proverbs 29:20: “Seest thou a man that is hasty in his words? there is more hope of a fool than of him.”

Solomon warns against being hasty with our words. He says the person with a mouth that speaks without engaging the mind is pretty hopeless. Why? It is because they will go from mess to mess created by their mouth. They create unnecessary conflict, hurt, and hostility with their mouth. They make rash decisions and commitments because they do not take the time to think before they speak. They have IMS: Irritable Mouth Syndrome!

We need to *develop discipline* in our communications. We must always avoid speaking what we feel, but *discipline ourselves to think our words through*. We develop the discipline not to think aloud unless it qualifies as something that edifies. Another wise man, the Apostle Paul, spoke of being disciplined when we speak. He wrote in Ephesians 4:29, “Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers.” That is not only written as advice but as a command to believers. It was not meant to be optional.

Also, we need to *develop discretion* about what we say. Discretion is the opposite of this proverb. Words are processed before they are let out! They are filtered and not allowed to flow. Consider discernment as a water filter that keeps the impurities from flowing further. They are stopped before they are consumed! That is the priority of the wise communicator. It is not that they won’t ever feel like saying something foolish! It is that they protect the hearer from hearing their foolish thoughts! They use their wisdom to discern whether or not something should be said. That is discretion!

How do we qualify our words and conversations? How do we develop discipline and discretion in our communications? We follow Paul’s rules for communicating. It must minister “good” and edify them. It must build them up and minister grace and not condemnation. Before saying it, we must analyze what we say: Does it *bless* them? Does it *benefit* them? Does it *build* them up?

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATION 3”

Proverbs 17:27: “He that hath knowledge spareth his words: and a man of understanding is of an excellent spirit.”

Solomon reminds us that wise people don't talk much. They develop the discipline to speak with purpose. The wise person controls their communication at all times. They learn to speak with precision. The wise have an “excellent spirit” or a calm, controlled attitude. They don't just allow words to pour out of them in foolishness driven by their feelings. They are controlled and calculate the consequences of what they say. They value what they say, so it makes what they say valuable!

Wise people sometimes realize the most constructive thing is what *isn't said*. The wise judiciously weigh their words and often spare people from them. The foolish person doesn't prejudge or qualify their words. *When we spare words, we often spare people's feelings!* We spare them the hurt and ourselves the hostility that foolish words create. Wise people avoid unnecessary conflicts and problems that waste valuable time. They avoid this by speaking less and thinking more!

So, when we spare words, we spare ourselves and others from frustration! We can then invest our communications in building and bettering people because we aren't wasting so much energy battling people. *Our emotions are kept low, so our logic remains high, and we can speak constructively and convincingly.* We are in control, which creates the posture of strength versus being out of control, reflecting inner weakness. We only take advice from people we respect, and people don't respect others who are out of control.

The wise learn to spare their words because they have learned not to waste them on people who will waste them! The wise don't talk to hear themselves talk, unlike the fool. They want to sow verbal seed on good ground that is soft and ready to produce. If the *heart* or the *head* is hard, they will spare their words because it is futile to sow seed on hard soil! Again, the wise value their words as essential commodities not to be squandered or scattered!

It is better to spare our words than to spread our foolishness! It is better to spare our wisdom than spill it on hard ground!

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATIONS 4”

Proverbs 10:19: “In the multitude of words there wanteth not sin: but he that refraineth his lips is wise.”

Again, sometimes the most constructive thing we can do is nothing! *The wise learn to refrain from speaking foolish things or to foolish people.* The wiser we become, the more we will learn to refrain from speaking! Not every question deserves an answer because people often don't want to hear the correct answer. They are hoping they will find agreement with their wrong. They seek permission to continue on their path, so a wise person will not play that game or, in general, waste time.

A wise person realizes that the more they speak, the more they increase the odds of making mistakes in their communication. The longer we talk, the less we focus on what we say. The wisest person will make mistakes communicating if they talk long enough. Verbal mishaps can create misunderstandings that can destroy relationships. Further, a verbal mistake can undermine all the positive things we have said up to that point. So wise people say what they deem necessary and then refrain from saying more. The longer we talk, the more likely we will go from constructive to destructive communication.

That is why wise people have learned not to debate or argue with foolish people. *They don't want to get stuck in a negative cycle generated by debating.* They realize this is foolish behavior that will lead to foolish consequences. The longer we talk, debate, or discuss, the more negative emotions we stimulate in ourselves and our counterparts. This escalating emotion will create a climate of foolishness. Debating is a complete waste of time. *A person whose mind is changed against their will still has the same opinion.*

Most discussions are best avoided, too! *A wise and foolish person discussing any subject will become an exercise in futility.* It is like trying to mix oil and water. You can stir things up for a while, but when they settle down, they will still be separated into two parts: oil and water. A wise person knows they may stir things up by discussing issues, but when it settles back down, the foolish will remain unconvinced, and the wise will remain the wiser. It is the wisest choice to avoid arguments, debates, and discussions as much as possible! Refraining from talking too much will allow us to avoid mistakes, mishaps, and misunderstandings!

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATION 5”

Proverbs 16:21: “The wise in heart shall be called prudent: and the sweetness of the lips increaseth learning.”

Solomon knew that great communicators learn to make what they say sweet to the hearer. They don’t just spout knowledge; they *make it appealing* to the listener. Solomon recognizes that a good communicator aims to increase learning, not just make a point. Good communicators want to be constructive and productive when they speak!

To make something sweet and appealing to the listener, we have to think like them, not ourselves! What is sweet to one person may not appeal to the next, so the wise person customizes their communications to the listener. Often, people with knowledge recite information and instruction without regard for the listener. The wise person is prudent enough to communicate with a goal in mind. That goal is to increase the knowledge of the listener. A wise person takes responsibility for what they say and *how they say it*. The goal is clear. It is to help the listener learn, not just hear.

The person who is arrogant in their knowledge or position doesn’t bother to make their communication sweet to the listener. Their approach is more like take it or leave it, get it or don’t. They can then blame the failure on the listener or the student. The wise person wants to make communication as appealing as possible, even fun. They may even be entertaining as they enlighten the listener. They appeal to their taste or their senses. They paint a picture, not just point out principles. They cast a vision, create value, and cause the listener to desire to learn.

Constructive communicators must appeal to the individual and their “taste.” Making the thing being communicated appealing is critical to the listener’s learning. The wise communicator will show them how it benefits or blesses them. Helping them see how to *avoid pain* and *problems* is another form of making the lesson appealing to the listener.

Taking responsibility for *what we say* and *how we say it* will allow us to be better communicators! We need to become *outcome-oriented* when we speak, not *output-oriented*. We must begin with the end in mind, or with the outcome we want to accomplish for the listeners! *We must customize our communications to that individual or group with the outcome in mind.* Then we become constructive and productive communicators!

“POSITIVE COMMUNICATIONS 6”

Proverbs 16:23: “The heart of the wise teacheth his mouth, and addeth learning to his lips.”

Solomon teaches us that good communicators have to develop their communication skills. They have to *teach their mouth* how to speak constructively and productively. They have developed wisdom, but now have to add *the ability to speak persuasively* with their wisdom. Wisdom only benefits others when it is communicated with skill!

The ability to think with wisdom is one thing, but if we desire to help people, we must communicate effectively. This power to speak persuasively allows our wisdom to solve people’s problems! In the ability to communicate, we *inspire* and *influence* people for God and good! When we develop the skill of being a good communicator, we move from just informing people to instructing them on applying the wisdom we share.

Our ability to be good communicators is an essential skill to develop. It will transform our personal and professional lives. It will allow us to minister to and motivate more people positively and productively! We will waste less time and increase our effectiveness! We will be better parents, leaders, and Influencers! We will be able not just to *know the way* but also to *show the way*!

The world is full of wise people who turn people off because they can’t communicate what they know in a way that impacts the listener! They are chopping a tree with a dull axe. They chop harder, shout louder, and get angry with the listener. They should back off and take the time to sharpen their axe until it is effective. We need to take the time to sharpen and hone our communication skills! We need to sharpen our skills continuously! This area of everyone’s life needs constant and continuous improvement.

If we genuinely desire to make a difference in the lives of others, we need to make becoming a great communicator a top priority. We must *develop our communication skills* before effectively developing *the people* around us. That is our divine responsibility because The Message rests upon its Means! We are God’s mouth, so we must use our ability to communicate thoughtfully!

“START DOING AND STOP TALKING”

Proverbs 14:23: “In all labour there is profit: but the talk of the lips tendeth only to penury.”

Sometimes Solomon’s wisdom is so simple yet profound. He observed that there is at least some profitability when people work toward an end. They make something valuable and productive happen. Then he observed that some people always talked about making something happen but never did more than talk. He said that was a sure path to poverty!

So, the simple advice is that talking alone is unprofitable. There must be a point where dreaming turns into doing! The talking is accompanied by action and works toward the dream. Massive talk will lead to poverty, but massive action will lead to progress!

It is more than just a fiscal proverb. He is illustrating a principle. Talk without the accompanying work is futile. It will not produce any result. It could be someone talking about losing weight constantly without acting to create change. It could also be a person talking about wanting a better relationship without taking the steps to help it happen. It even applies to people who always discuss what’s wrong without taking practical steps or putting forth any “labor” to improve it.

In the end, all talk is unproductive unless it fuels action. The world is full of people who spend their lives discussing what they will do “someday.” When they get older, the talk becomes what they should’ve done. It is talk!

Later, as Solomon was older and even wiser, he wrote this proverb and principle in Ecclesiastes. “For a dream cometh through the multitude of business; and a fool’s voice is known by multitude of words.” (Eccl. 5:3) He says dreams become a reality with much effort and work. The term means work and activity, which can be painful at times! It costs a lot to make dreams come true. It takes tremendous effort, even for a wise man. Solomon knew that talk was easy, so it was unproductive!

We can wisely divide people into the “Talkers” and the “Doers.” Which are you?

“BIG LESSONS FROM A LITTLE ANT”

Proverbs 6:6-11: “Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise: Which having no guide, overseer, or ruler, Provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest.”

Solomon was a wise teacher who used the ant as an object for a lesson. Ever since I first read this proverb, I have thought of it whenever I see an ant. It is a powerful lesson. Such big lessons come from considering the little ant!

The first lesson from the ant is *the lesson of being industrious*. He addresses a “sluggard” or a lazy person and tells them to observe an ant. That’s how we should be. He was telling them to get industrious. Being industrious is not just being busy; it is being busy with productive, essential things. Ants are active in their main business—getting food. They gather as much as possible, whenever it is possible. They are active with a purpose! Further, they are active with a future purpose! That is productivity! *There is a tremendous lesson there.*

To be industrious, we have to have daily activities that meet our needs and, in some way, produce something for the future! Our “to-do lists” need to be full of positive, industrious activities, but they must also include some activities *preparing* for our *future*. Make sure that your daily activities are aligned with your purpose every day. That will help ensure that we aren’t busy with the wrong things. More people are busy with the wrong things than we would think.

The ant is industrious! They are nonstop during their workday. They are pursuing their purpose with great energy and enthusiasm. They lift things much larger than they are. They are orderly and organized. They exercise great teamwork. They overcome obstacles! They don’t quit! They divide large items into small, manageable parts! They are exceptional in their diligence! We can learn so much from considering the ant!

“BIG LESSONS FROM A LITTLE ANT 2”

Proverbs 6:6-11: “Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise: Which having no guide, overseer, or ruler, Provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest.”

As we follow Solomon’s advice and consider the ant for wisdom, we find another big lesson from the ant. The second lesson from the ant is *the lesson of having initiative*. The ant has “no guide, overseer,” or manager. They manage themselves. They don’t need constant instruction. They do what they are supposed to do! They demonstrate initiative. They are nature’s example of what we now call being proactive.

The person who demonstrates initiative doesn’t need to be managed because they can manage themselves in a productive, positive way. They don’t need to be led because they have learned to lead themselves to do what they need to or should do. The person who demonstrates initiative manages themselves well and motivates themselves. They can motivate themselves to act.

Wise people will learn the lesson from the ant because it allows them to be productive at higher levels than those who must be managed constantly. *If we need to be managed, we will only be as productive as the person managing us*. However, if we can lead and manage ourselves, we can become as productive as we learn! We can continuously grow, thereby increasing our production level.

People who can motivate themselves to act will be more productive than the average person. They will be doing while the others wait for someone to come and tell them what to do. *They will do it while the others wait for someone to help them feel like doing what they should be*.

Those who can motivate themselves and initiate will be able to succeed independently because they are driven from within. Those who need to be motivated and managed will always depend on others for success. They need to be led because they aren’t driven from within!

The ability to be self-managed and motivated will bring tremendous rewards and recognition. It will give you favor with your boss or allow you to be the boss someday. The person who wants to lead others must learn to be like the ant and lead themselves!

“BIG LESSONS FROM A LITTLE ANT 3”

Proverbs 6:6-11: “Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise: Which having no guide, overseer, or ruler, Provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest.”

Lessons from the Ant include *being industrious, demonstrating initiative*, and developing investing habits. All of these characteristics take discipline. If you have watched ants work, they look like a little army. They march in a line, moving with purpose. They are models of discipline. They are so disciplined that they don't need a “guide, overseer, or ruler.”

The ability to rule and guide oneself is a powerful thing. *Self-discipline is the ability to get yourself to do the things that need or should be done when they need to be done.* For the Ant, it is instinctual to work in the summer to prepare for the winter. For us, it has to become a habit. It starts with our power to choose our actions and our God-given intelligence to have foresight. It is developing the daily habits that produce the immediate and future benefits we desire or discern.

Procrastination is a common trait in the “sluggard.” They put off what needs to be done, which becomes their ruin. The Ant is an example of being proactive, which was meant to illustrate the opposite of the “sluggard.” The ants are active at the right time and dormant or inactive at the right time. The “sluggard” is inactive when it should be active. They cannot manage themselves or motivate themselves to be busy with productive things. They put off what should and could be done today until “tomorrow.” They continue this procrastination process until they waste their days away. The “sluggard” will have a *bleak future* because they *blow the present!* They *give* their time away instead of *spending* and *investing* it wisely.

People with self-discipline can manage and motivate themselves to do wise, productive things now. They spend and invest in what they have in the present. They avoid banking on a “tomorrow.” They are present-minded! They want to get it done today, so they can do more tomorrow, not carry today's work into tomorrow. They manage themselves to be as efficient and effective as possible! They avoid and abhor excuses! They are all about executing, not excuses! They work wisely like the Ants!

“BIG LESSONS FROM A LITTLE ANT 4”

Proverbs 6:6-11: “Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise: Which having no guide, overseer, or ruler, Provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest.”

The third lesson from the ant is the *lesson of investing*. Take note of the proverb. The ant works to provide for today (“summer”) and prepares for tomorrow (“harvest”). They have a future focus on their daily activity. They save some food gathered each day for later days when it will no longer be gathering season. That means they do more than just enough each day to get by In the present. It means they do *extra work* to prepare for the future. They store up for their down or lean times, like the winter season, when no food is available.

Investing is more than just about finances. It is about having a future focus. *It is about doing more than just enough to get by today, but sowing some extra effort for a future benefit.* It is about planning and preparing for the future in our daily activities. It is about doing extra today so that we can have enough later! It understands there are seasons of a work year and our lives. It is making the most of the productive seasons to enjoy the down seasons.

We need to sow some effort and energy into something future-focused to exercise the wisdom from considering the ant. It could be saving money to invest in a future fund or business endeavor. Working on a project that will produce future reward or income could take an hour out of each day. It uses the time and energy resources we have to invest in our future. It is going the extra mile today to prepare for a down season.

The foolish person *will consume* everything they do and have “today” *without contributing* something forward. Most people are unlike the ant because they do the minimum to get by today without thinking, planning, or preparing for the future. Whereas we are warned not to panic or be anxious about the future, we are never told not to prepare for it with wisdom.

We can invest our intellectual and financial capital, physical resources, and energy into our future by doing something daily with a future focus. We can anticipate future needs and prepare in advance, as the ant does. We can plan, prepare, and pay forward for another season. *If we consume everything or do just the minimum today, then we will be without in the future!* The ant is a preparer!

“BIG LESSONS FROM A LITTLE ANT 5”

Proverbs 6:6-11: “Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise: Which having no guide, overseer, or ruler, Provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest.”

Lessons from the Ant include *being industrious, demonstrating initiative*, and developing investing habits. All of these characteristics take discipline. If you have watched ants work, they look like a little army. They march in a line, moving with purpose. They are models of discipline. They are so disciplined that they don't need a “guide, overseer, or ruler.”

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“CHARACTERISTICS OF A SLUGGARD”

Proverbs 20:4: “The sluggard will not plow by reason of the cold; therefore shall he beg in harvest, and have nothing.”

Solomon often addresses the habitually lazy person in Proverbs. The word “sluggard” is often translated as “sluggish,” referring to sluggish behavior. This person is inactive, and moving as little as possible could have reminded him of a slug. He warns his son about indulging *in laziness* because he was born into wealth, ease, and prosperity. He speaks truthfully and sternly to the “sluggard”! He points out their negative characteristics, hoping his son will be the opposite.

The above proverb shows a sluggard’s first and most dominant characteristic. The sluggard habitually makes excuses! Here, Solomon illustrates their excuse-making by saying he used the cold weather as an excuse not to prepare his fields for planting. He never got around to plowing, so he would not have anything positive or productive to show. He says that come harvest, he has “nothing.”

What is an excuse? It is a reason we choose to justify ourselves when we don’t want to do something. It is our way of *rationalizing*, putting off what we know could or should be done. The sluggard makes excuses continuously and habitually! Excuse-making is like any habit. The more we do it, the easier it becomes. We reinforce both the inactivity and the habit of making excuses simultaneously. We reinforce laziness by giving self-prescribed reasons for laziness in a given area.

An excuse is our way of talking ourselves out of doing something positive or productive. Suppose we dissect the anatomy of an excuse. We find at its heart two things. We find *the desire for ease* and *the dislike of effort*. In the proverb, the sluggard desired the ease and comfort of the warm house over putting forth the effort to get out and plow his field. The *immediate reward* of staying warm was more important to him than having a harvest down the road. Plowing in the cold *was more painful to him than the future consequences* of not having a harvest. The pain of having “nothing,” no food, no income source, was much more significant and longer than the temporary cold. He talked himself out of doing what was best while simultaneously forfeiting a better future. He avoided *short-term pain* only to *create more long-term pain* for himself, with far more significant consequences and discomfort.

“CHARACTERISTICS OF A SLUGGARD 2”

Proverbs 26: 16: “The sluggard is wiser in his own conceit than seven men that can render a reason.”

Another characteristic of the sluggard is that they will not listen to anyone. They are hard-headed and closed-minded. *They are not teachable because they think they are wise, even though all the evidence manifests their foolishness, even ignorance.* They are delusional in their self-concept and the reality of their life. They see the wise counsel of people as foolish. They wouldn't even take the advice of the wisest man ever, Solomon. Solomon had enormous wealth and success. He was sought after by kings, queens, and leaders worldwide, but the sluggard still thought he knew best.

The sluggard is unwilling to seek our advice and knowledge. They don't feel the need because, in their “conceit,” they know the answer. They think they know what's best, even when up against a proven expert or established wise person. They think they know more than a council of “seven” wise men.

They are arrogant in their delusion despite the counsel of others or their failures. What should be evidence to prove that they are in the wrong is quickly dismissed with an arrogant delusion. They are right, no matter what happens, and who says otherwise.

When we look at the lesson here, we can all admit we've had hard-headed moments. However, most probably haven't wasted a lifetime in this negative, self-defeating, self-destructive mode. Either the consequences and reality began to sink in, or a wiser person got through to us. Life itself is a good teacher if we are teachable. We can see what is working and what is not working. We can then alter our attitudes and actions to remedy the situation. The sluggard or conceited person will not alter the course because they are still right, no matter what the evidence presented to them is. God, life, or Solomon will not convince them to change.

We need to be the opposite of the sluggard. We need to be teachable. We need to seek out wisdom and not close out wisdom. We should get the lessons that God is teaching us through life.

“CHARACTERISTICS OF A SLUGGARD 3”

Proverbs 6:9: “How long wilt thou sleep, O sluggard? when wilt thou arise out of thy sleep?”

Another characteristic of the sluggard is that they are fatigued all the time. They seem to crave sleep and rest. They seem to be continuously tired. Their energy level is low, and their activity level is low. For some, sleep is almost a drug with addictive properties. It is a source of pleasure for them.

Rest is an essential form of recovery. The sluggard, inactive as possible, is drained by inactivity, not excessive activity. *It is a law of physics that things in motion stay in motion. Said another way, activity stimulates energy.* The opposite is true. Inactivity drains energy. That explains why the sluggard is always tired. Their inactivity drains them. The body and mind were divinely created to need kinetic energy. We are energized by activity and accomplishment. It charges our batteries, and when we don't move, our functions slow down to a minimal level. Like a kinetic watch that isn't charged by movement, it begins to run slower and slower.

It is a cycle for a sluggard. Their inactivity makes them feel drained, so they move and do as little as possible. The lack of activity further drains them. We all have had sick days or weekend days where we get more sleep and rest than usual. What happens? We wake up feeling sluggish and drained, right? We crave more sleep and feel tired all day. The sluggard lives this draining cycle. Also, boredom drains the body and mind, making us feel tired. Have you sat through a boring speaker? Felt so sleepy, but as soon as it was over, we were energized.

It may seem counterintuitive, but the prescription for the sluggish person is more activity, not rest. Activity stimulates the body and mind with positive, productive, purposeful activity! It is using sleep as a form of recovery, not escape. Think in these terms. Sleep and rest should be earned! Make sure sleep is used to enhance the next day's activities, not escape from them.

“CHARACTERISTICS OF A SLUGGARD 4”

Proverbs 13:4: “The soul of the sluggard desireth, and hath nothing: but the soul of the diligent shall be made fat.”

Another essential characteristic of a sluggard is that they have passive desires. Look at the proverb. They desire but have nothing to show for it because they do nothing to make it become a reality. The diligent are those who have an active desire. That is, their desire stimulates action toward what they desire. The diligent person's desires turn into discipline. *The sluggard's desire turns into wishing. That is a passive mental process!* It stimulates no action and provides no lasting motivation.

The result of passive desires is always the same: “nothing.” It creates no results, has no power behind it, and may create some delusion. Desire without diligence and discipline is dead! It brings about no real, lasting change. It is as dormant! It cannot produce life. However, an active desire is full of power and potential! It gives birth to dreams and desires because it manifests tangible action. Active desires produce an amazing work ethic!

Diligent people are doers. *They are self-motivated because of their desires.* They are *proactive* and *persistent!* They may fail, but not stop because their desire is on fire! They are filled with and fueled by *passion!* They have a consuming *purpose* that stimulates them to work at making their dreams and desires a reality. Setbacks, mistakes, and failures strengthen their desires! They are like Edison in the laboratory. They are seemingly tireless. They keep working at what they want to create until it happens!

Compare that to the sluggard, who is lethargic and lacks energy and drive. They lack lasting motivation and will use a minor thing as an excuse. They have no evident passion except for comfort and pleasure. When they act, it's half-hearted, and they will quit at the slightest sign of adversity or opposition. They aren't diligent at anything but avoiding work and productive activity. They waste their talents and their desires. They end up with “nothing” but the consequences of the excuses!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF A SLUGGARD 5”

Proverbs 10:26: “As vinegar to the teeth, and as smoke to the eyes, so is the sluggard to them that send him.”

Adding all the other characteristics of the sluggard, we see that they concluded this way. They make poor employees. They are a source of irritation to their employer or overseer. Like smoke irritates the eyes, the sluggard is a source of irritation to his manager or leader. The employer is burdened by the sluggard and not blessed by him.

Why is the sluggard type so irritating to the person over them? They have to be *constantly managed and motivated*. They must be babysat because they *show no initiative* and *are unwilling to think* for themselves. *They have to be watched* every step of the way. They do have to be micromanaged. Any time they are given responsibility or are delegated, they become a source of frustration. They require way too much energy from the leader to get what is a minimum effort from them. The process becomes a source of irritation and frustration for anyone who entrusts them with responsibility.

The sluggard type of person is irritating because they consistently make excuses. They have excuses for why they are continuously late. Excuses for why they didn't perform a task well or complete a project. Excuses for why they took so long on lunch or an errand. They have excuses for why others are outproducing them. *They are seldom, if ever, the problem.*

The sluggard type gives minimum effort toward a task or the workday. They want the easiest way possible. They are all about convenience. They are the least efficient part of any organization. Usually, the slowest moving until it's time to go to lunch or go home. They have little desire to improve themselves or their job performance. If asked, they have an overinflated opinion of their abilities and role. They are wise in their own “conceit.” They see themselves as a *gift to* the employer, but the employer sees them as a source of *grief!*

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL”

Proverbs 12:27: “The slothful man roasteth not that which he took in hunting; but the substance of a diligent man is precious.”

The twin brother of the sluggard is the slothful person. They have many overlapping characteristics because they are a family. In this proverb, we see two characteristics. The first characteristic we see is that the lazy person is a waster. They waste their food because they don't want to cook it and use it purposefully. The habit pattern of the slothful is to waste the things they are blessed with. The next characteristic seen in the proverb is that the slothful have no appreciation for what they have. They waste what they have because they don't appreciate what they have! Conversely, diligent people appreciate what they have, realizing it is “precious.”

The slothful are wasteful with their “substance” because their underlying attitude disrespects the gifts they are given. Diligent people respect what they have because they know the value of their possessions, property, and assets. Lazy people take the things and people in their lives for granted because they are self-centered. They do not see the value of the things they have in their life. If they did, they wouldn't waste them with such neglect. They have no appreciation for their “substance” or blessings. So, they don't see anything as “precious” or valuable.

The slothful person thinks that they will do better when they have better. *If they ever get better, they don't appreciate it.* They will neglect it, waste it, and let it go bad. Give some people a new home; it won't be long before they let it run down and make a mess of it. Give them a brand-new car, and they will fill it with trash and treat it like a cheap, used car. Give the slothful person a new pair of designer shoes, which will be worn down and unpolished before long. They will not appreciate or value the quality or the gift after the “new” wears off.

It is a sin to waste what we have been blessed with. We may say we appreciate it, but the lack of care speaks otherwise. The diligent work hard for what they have, so they value it! They show respect and responsibility for what they gather and are given!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 2”

Proverbs 18:9: “He also that is slothful in his work is brother to him that is a great waster.”

The slothful not only wastes their “substance,” but also wastes time and opportunities. So another characteristic of the lazy is that they give minimum effort and energy! *They try to do as little “work” as possible.* Solomon teaches that this is just another form of wasting. The slothful person isn’t concerned about excelling. Instead, they desire to get out of as much as possible. They waste their workday, health, and strength like every other blessing. They waste their time and talents. They waste their God-given abilities and God-given opportunities. They allow them to rot away because they don’t appreciate them! They won’t put forth the effort to develop and maximize what they have been granted!

To be wise, we must learn to maximize what we have been given. We need to maximize our “work” by giving our best effort. We are to work with energy and enthusiasm. Our goal should be to earn a reputation as the best at whatever we do! We should be highly motivated to do whatever “work” is in front of us with all the effort and energy we have!

We need to maximize our time. Good *time management is essential for living wisely.* To maximize our workday, we must learn to maximize our time. Successful people know the importance of managing their time effectively. They plan, prioritize, and organize their day to get the most done in the least amount of time. They desire to get more done than the average person.

They don’t think, “What’s the least I can do today?” They think, “What’s the most I can get done today?”

The slothful person goes through the day *avoiding work.* The successful person goes through the day *attacking their work.* The slothful person wants distractions. The successful person eliminates distractions. The lazy person is unmotivated, lacks enthusiasm, and energy. The successful person is motivated, enthusiastic, and has unbelievable energy compared to the slothful person. The lazy person is half-hearted in their endeavors. Successful people are wholehearted, even passionate, about their “work.”

Here’s some New Testament reinforcement: “Not slothful in business; fervent in spirit; serving the Lord,” Romans 12:11

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 3”

Proverbs 19:24: “A slothful man hideth his hand in his bosom and will not so much as bring it to his mouth again.”

Proverbs 26:15: “The slothful hideth his hand in his bosom; it grieveth him to bring it again to his mouth.”

The slothful also refuse to do what they can for themselves. Solomon exaggerated the above proverbs to point out the extremes of laziness. The lazy person eats, but having to put forth the effort to do the simplest things “grieves” them. If they could get someone to do it for them, they would.

The lazy person’s goal is to do as little as possible. Therefore, they will rely on others to do what they can or leave it undone. The slothful person is drained by having to put forth even the slightest effort. On the other side of the equation is the successful person, *energized* by putting forth effort. The thought of being productive exhilarates them!

Laziness is a learned helplessness. It gets worse, and the lazy get lazier with time. The lazy person finds it works for them on some level, so they continue. That could be like the kid who doesn’t clean their room even though the parent fusses. Eventually, she cleans it for the child because she’s sick of it. The kid just learned laziness works! That is just one illustration of how this works. It could be one worker doing the minimum because they realized another coworker would do what they won’t do for them.

Solomon’s exaggerations may not fit us, but we should examine ourselves for laziness and slothfulness. These tendencies may manifest in our bodies or our businesses. The quicker we can spot these tendencies, the easier to correct them! Like all habits, the earlier we catch them, the easier it is to reverse them!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 4”

Proverbs 24:30-34: “I went by the field of the slothful, and by the vineyard of the man void of understanding; And, lo, it was all grown over with thorns, and nettles had covered the face thereof, and the stone wall thereof was broken down. Then I saw, and considered it well: I looked upon it and received instruction. Yet a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep: So shall thy poverty come as one that travelleth; and thy want as an armed man.”

Solomon watched people so he could learn from their mistakes, thereby gaining wisdom at *their expense*. He says he “saw” and considered it well.” *Many people see a lesson, but not everyone gets the lesson as Solomon did.* We could learn a lot of wisdom from other people’s mistakes if we think about them, not just notice them. He uses a particular slothful person to teach multiple points about the dangers of slothfulness or laziness.

The slothful person in the proverb has a field and a vineyard. He has everything he needs to succeed, but refuses to do anything with it. So, another characteristic of the slothful is that the slothful mismanages their opportunities and assets. They blow the opportunities that they have when they have them. This guy is in “poverty” by choice. He could’ve planted crops. He could’ve tended his vineyard, but allowed the fruit to die and the weeds to grow. Solomon observes the property, and it is run down in such a way that it points out it has been more than one season of inactivity. A “stonewall” doesn’t break down in one winter. It was habitual mismanagement.

People lose opportunities because they require hard work to capitalize on them. People lose their assets because they don’t do *the daily things required to maintain them*. Like the man in this proverb, the slothful allows opportunities to rot on the vine. Like the man in the proverb, most people *already* have what they need to be successful! They slothfully waste their opportunities. On the other side of the proverb is a diligent person. The diligent make the best of what they have and where they are, ultimately ending up with what the slothful lose!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 5”

Proverbs 24:30-34: “I went by the field of the slothful, and by the vineyard of the man void of understanding; And, lo, it was all grown over with thorns, and nettles had covered the face thereof, and the stone wall thereof was broken down. Then I saw, and considered it well: I looked upon it, and received instruction. Yet a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep: So shall thy poverty come as one that travelleth; and thy want as an armed man.”

Another characteristic of the slothful in this proverb is that the slothful person is in the habit of neglecting important things. In the proverb, this man *neglected his fields, vineyards, and the wall* that kept out the animals that would destroy and the fruit they would produce. These things happened because of willful neglect. He didn’t do the daily things necessary to maintain his property and get it to produce what it could. This devastation to his farm and vineyard didn’t happen overnight. *It took time for the neglect to add up to such a mess.*

Neglect is dangerous because its negative effect usually takes time to manifest. Then, by the time the neglect accumulates to the point of being obvious, it’s usually such a big mess or a problem. At that stage, it is *overwhelming*. It will take so much to resolve the issues caused by neglect. It seems so big that people want to give up. Think of it like this, it would’ve been easier for this man to *pull a few weeds every day* than to try and *recapture a year’s worth of wild overgrowth*.

Our culture is full of willful neglect. We neglect our health, which results in obesity, heart disease, diabetes, etc. Often, by the time the neglect manifests enough to get our attention, it is overwhelming. It is better to do daily things to maintain health than to recover it. It is easier to lose two pounds to maintain our health than to lose 80 pounds after heart surgery. It is easier to maintain a *relationship* than to try to recapture the “love” and passion after it’s lost. Repairing a small problem is easier than rebuilding a bigger one after years of neglect. The longer we wait to stop neglecting, the more overwhelming any problem will become. Laziness and neglect do add up, even if it takes a while to see the results!

Remember this: It is easier to repair than to rebuild, and it is easier to do daily maintenance than to deal with the mess created by neglect!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 6”

Proverbs 24:30-34: “I went by the field of the slothful, and by the vineyard of the man void of understanding; And, lo, it was all grown over with thorns, and nettles had covered the face thereof, and the stone wall thereof was broken down. Then I saw, and considered it well: I looked upon it, and received instruction. Yet a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep: So shall thy poverty come as one that travelleth; and thy want as an armed man.”

Concluding this proverb, I see another characteristic of the slothful: They are often overwhelmed. *Neglect adds up, creating such an overwhelming problem or problems that it causes the already excuse-prone person to become emotionally paralyzed.* The small things add up to such a huge thing that it falsely appears impossible to resolve. It isn't impossible at this stage, but overcoming the price of neglect will take enormous effort and energy. In our example, the overgrowth became overwhelming.

Neglect is like debt; it adds up fast. It can start slowly, but while the neglectful person is neglecting productive things, they are also blind to the neglect as it is happening. They don't see the debt adding up until it's such a huge negative balance that it overwhelms them. They neglect the issue(s) even more when they should attack the issues.

The consequences of neglect can't be resolved in a day because they were not created in a day. However, beginning to reverse the neglect process *can* start in a single day. It takes drawing a line and saying to oneself, “The neglect stops now.” One realizes that the consequence can't be undone in a day, but the cause can be stopped in a day. The enormous, overwhelming task can be broken down into daily positive, proactive tasks that slow the negative momentum of neglect and start some positive momentum. Notice I said it slows and does not stop. It is essential to be aware that the negative effects of neglect will still grow for a while. Many people get discouraged by this, but it is part of the price to pay, so deal with it. If this man started pulling weeds in one area, the weeds in the other area would still grow. But he would have to *reclaim*. Recover his property from neglect one inch at a time. So, it may take a while to see any progress. That can be discouraging, so determination is essential.

The fact is, we need to take *responsibility* for what we've neglected. We can begin to reverse the result or recover it until we do. The longer we wait, the harder it will be and the longer it will take. So today is the best time to begin reversing neglect's consequences. Every day of hesitation will make it more challenging. Every day of procrastination will make it bigger, and you or I will feel smaller! Start today. Inch by inch!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 7”

Proverbs 24:30-34: “I went by the field of the slothful, and by the vineyard of the man void of understanding; And, lo, it was all grown over with thorns, and nettles had covered the face thereof, and the stone wall thereof was broken down. Then I saw, and considered it well: I looked upon it, and received instruction. Yet a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep: So shall thy poverty come as one that travelleth; and thy want as an armed man.”

Before I conclude this proverb, it's vital to realize that this man's “poverty” was created by his neglect and slothfulness. He wasn't born poor. He made his poverty. As I mentioned, this person had a property that had the potential to produce. He had *wealth as far as assets*, but *was poor in his attitude*. He wanted rewards without effort, but life doesn't work that way. The law of the farm essentially rules life. In other words, sowing and reaping. He reaped what he sowed, which was nothing. Well, nothing but neglect, which he got a massive crop of.

We can be *blessed with all potential*, but it will only be wasted and ruined if we neglect to develop it. We can be *blessed with relationships* only to have them broken like this man's wall. We can be *blessed with abundance* only to squander it through neglect and slothfulness. We can be like this man and *have the assets* and opportunities to end up impoverished. Many Americans are *born with healthy bodies* only to destroy them through habitual neglect.

Willful poverty begins with attitude. It is continued by neglecting the essential things. It is being slothful about things that matter most, the things we are blessed with. It is an attitude problem at the heart of the matter! It is a lack of responsibility for what we have been blessed with! It is also a lack of respect for God, who blessed us with these blessings.

The habit of neglect typically starts in one area of our lives. However, left uncorrected, it becomes systemic in other areas. Before we know it, life is out of control, and we are overwhelmed. So now would be a wise time to review our lives for the beginning stages of neglect. What important things are you neglecting?

“THE CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 8”

Proverbs 22:13: “The slothful man saith, There is a lion without, I shall be slain in the streets.”

Proverbs 26:13: “The slothful man saith, There is a lion in the way; a lion is in the streets.”

Like his twin brother, the sluggard, the slothful man is in the habit of making excuses. So, another characteristic of lazy people is their habit of making excuses. Sometimes the excuses have a seed of reason behind them, and other times the excuses are just pure fabrication. Solomon gives another extreme example to illustrate the absurdity of the lazy desire to get out of things. In this case, they are hindered by the unusual appearance of a lion in the middle of Israel. This lion was hundreds of miles away from the savannahs of Africa. Most likely, this was a wild exaggeration to get out of work.

When we don't want to do anything, one excuse is as good as the other. A lion is as good as being tired or sick. A kid who doesn't do their homework makes excuse after excuse until it gets more absurd as the dog eats it. Excuses are often white lies we tell to get out of things we should do but don't want to. They become habit-forming because we *think they are working for us, even though the reality is that they are working against us!*

Notice the second proverb is similar except for the phrase, “in the way.” Lazy, slothful people always have something standing in their way. Something or someone is always in the way of their success or progress. Some reason is always in their way of doing what they could or should. While they are saying *why they can't* do it, someone finds a *reason to do it. Successful people get things out of the way!*

What is keeping you from having and being what you want? I'm pretty sure it isn't God holding you or me back. We are looking for reasons not to do instead of reasons to do! Let's eliminate the excuses and elevate the execution!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 9”

Proverbs 15:19: “The way of the slothful man is as an hedge of thorns: but the way of the righteous is made plain.”

The slothful person makes life more challenging than it has to be! That is a common characteristic of the lazy. Considering the proverb, the slothful person's life is likened to trying to travel through a hedge of thorns. That is not easygoing at all. It will take them a long time to travel a small distance, and it will be a struggle every step of the way. Compare that to the way of the person who is “righteous” or does the right things. The person who does the right things their way is straighter, easier, and less likely to encounter *self-induced* problems. We would translate into our language that they are on a highway. They will travel further and faster in the same amount of time because their “way” is clear and direct.

The slothful often make their way harder than it should be because they complicate everything. *They struggle to do the relatively easy things because they frankly don't want to do them.* They *procrastinate* doing things that others do. They *put off* the important things until they become overwhelming, making them more challenging. They *neglect* things until they are almost impossible to fix or repair. They *ignore* the obvious things that must be done and must deal with the consequences. Even simple things get complicated at this stage.

Think of it this way: they see a small leak in their roof. They ignore and neglect it. They see signs of another leak. They still put off repairing both. The leaks get bigger until they eventually destroy the roof, the walls mold, and the contents of the house are ruined because the ceiling eventually comes crashing down. Now they have a vast, overwhelming mess that is so complicated and costly.

Further, because they are in the habit of neglect, other things they have neglected are also beginning to manifest. Many small things have turned into big, messy, complicated things. Their life is a mess because they are a mess! Their way is hard because they made it harder than it had to be!

One of the wisest things we can do is not make easy things difficult. Learning not to let small things pile up into big things is a wise decision. We must learn not to make life harder than it is by laziness, neglect, and procrastination! Forget the hard way and get on the highway! Let's make progress, not excuses!

“CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SLOTHFUL 10”

Proverbs 19:15: “Slothfulness casteth into a deep sleep; and an idle soul shall suffer hunger.”

Proverbs 26:14: “As the door turneth upon his hinges, so doth the slothful upon his bed.”

Again, the twin brothers, sluggard and slothful, have similar characteristics. They both crave sleep and are continuously tired. The slothful desire sleep and rest way beyond their level of activity. The lazy are almost addicted to their beds or places of leisure. Solomon says they keep turning over like a door on its hinges. We call them “couch potatoes.” They love to be as “idle” and inactive as possible. They would rather *get out of* something than *get out and* do something!

Solomon points out two consequences in the proverb. First, they go into a “deep sleep” or a trance. Their inactivity produces sedation, and they become sleepier the more they rest. They turn over and over, never feeling energized by all their sleep. Why? It is because too much sleep is counterproductive. After a certain point, it begins to have the opposite effect. Activity is the answer because it is God’s way of balancing out the sleep cycle, but the slothful person will never get this principle. *When we sleep and are too inactive, our minds and bodies get out of balance.*

The second consequence is that it affects the soul. Their soul suffers hunger. It means our psychology suffers or lacks when we choose to be lazy and inactive. God designed our self-esteem to be enhanced when we are active and productive. We feel better about ourselves when we give our best and do our best. We build our character and boost our self-esteem when we do what we were designed to do: work, produce, and be active.

It is well-known that an *active lifestyle* is healthier than an *inactive lifestyle*. Active people are happier and feel better about themselves, their lives, and their relationships. In other words, their souls are full, not hungry!

“THE PRIORITY OF PRIORITIZING”

Proverbs 24:27: “Prepare thy work without, and make it fit for thyself in the field; and afterwards build thine house.”

I’ve heard it said, “Organize or agonize.” But Solomon teaches us to *prioritize or agonize*. We can organize a mess, but it is still a mess. We can organize our leisure activities, but they are still leisure pursuits at the end of the day. *We must prioritize our lives, time, and energy to be productive and live positively*. Solomon knew this and was teaching it through this proverb.

Prioritizing will help us *find what* is most important. Here, Solomon advises prioritizing what generates income and substance over improving our living conditions. He is saying that business was a priority over comfort. It is obvious that, ultimately, the business was the means to the comfort of a new house. A new house wouldn’t pay the bills, but a productive crop could. He said to do the necessary thing first, not the fun or comfortable thing.

Prioritizing will help us *focus* on what is most important. It is easy to get distracted, especially when there is much to do. Solomon says it is best to focus on the most rewarding thing first. Focus on the things that will pay us the most significant amount back, or the time-sensitive things. In this case, the fields were both. He couldn’t plow and plant anytime; it was time-sensitive. Then the harvest would produce income and food for the future.

Prioritizing will help us *follow through* on what is most important. When we prioritize, it allows us to plan and “prepare” our daily activities. It continuously keeps us from distraction and getting off track. It creates a means of following through on what needs to be done, not what we want to do. We will be driven by purpose and kept aligned through daily prioritizing.

Prioritizing allows us to *pre-decide how we will spend our time, talents, energy, and resources based on a desired outcome*. It empowers us to do first things first. It will enable us to keep the main things the main things!

“THE PRODUCTION QUADRANT”

Proverbs 24:27: “Prepare thy work without, and make it fit for thyself in the field; and afterwards build thine house.”

In his wisdom, Solomon teaches us to prioritize the productive, important thing first. The slothful person wants to do the pleasurable first and prioritize it. In the proverb, Solomon’s advice was to do the productive thing first and leave the pleasurable or pleasing things until after the production.

We can divide our lives into the “Production Quadrant” and the “Pleasure Quadrant.” *Solomon has taught us in other proverbs that the lazy person and sluggard live life mainly in the pleasure quadrant.* They want to do the pleasurable or pleasing thing first and prioritize those types of activities. The wiser way to live is to invest most of the day in the production quadrant.

The production quadrant is more than just work-related. For example, a fitness routine is in the production quadrant because it has long-term benefits or rewards. The same can be said of making important relationships a priority, too. Things in the production quadrant benefit beyond the moment. Even rest can be productive, but too much can cause it to move to the pleasure quadrant.

When you and I review our daily schedules, we should see that most of our time and energy are invested in the production quadrant. Spending too much time in the pleasure quadrant will eventually negatively affect us physically, financially, and spiritually. We need to prioritize and plan our days to make sure the productive things are the main things and the pleasurable things remain minor. Not that the pleasurable is absent, but they don’t distract from the productive things. The truth is that the more time spent in the production quadrant, the more we can enjoy the pleasure quadrant later! It’s less like either-or, and more like now or later.

“DEVELOPING DILIGENCE”

Proverbs 12:24: “The hand of the diligent shall bear rule: but the slothful shall be under tribute.”

“Diligent” is “constant *effort in trying to accomplish something.*” Also, *being attentive and persistent in doing something.*” To paraphrase one definition, “*pursuing something with persistent, painstaking attention.*”

Diligence is “*constant and earnest effort to accomplish what is undertaken; persistent exertion of body and mind.*” It means giving maximum effort toward the task or goal at hand, passionately and persistently pursuing it. In many ways, it is the opposite of slothfulness. Solomon promotes the attitude and actions behind diligence as keys to success.

He points out that the diligent person will become a leader while the slothful will always be stuck “under tribute” or be a follower. The diligent will handle their business or someone else’s business with *meticulous effort* and *maximum energy*. They will give their best to every task in front of them, demonstrating they can handle responsibility. Therefore, they will be granted more responsibility with consequential rewards. Meanwhile, the non-diligent, slothful person will lose their responsibilities and be placed under the diligent person’s leadership.

A person with diligence will do whatever it takes to succeed or accomplish the task. They persevere and put in the time and energy needed to make progress. They take it personally! It matters to them! The lazy, non-diligent person gives in with the least resistance. They aren’t focused or attentive.

Meanwhile, the diligent person pays attention to the task at hand, focuses on accomplishing the goal or objective, works passionately, and moves with purpose. Their diligence will bring success!

“DEVELOPING DILIGENCE 2”

Proverbs 10:4: “He becometh poor that dealeth with a slack hand: but the hand of the diligent maketh rich.”

Solomon teaches that being a slacker leads to becoming “poor.” On the other hand, being diligent makes one “rich” or more prosperous. The principle is that slacking produces a decrease, while diligence produces an increase. Referring back to the definitions, we can see that sustained *and substantial attention and energy are components of being diligent*. Whatever we give maximum attention, energy, and effort to will increase. Therefore, diligence is the power to become “rich” or successful in whatever is undertaken.

It appears that God has created the universe to respond to diligence. *It does not reward lazy people or slackers. It doesn't reward the half-hearted or the weak-willed!* But let a person become relentless, resilient, and persistent, and suddenly things begin to change. Let a person refuse to take no for an answer, continue giving maximum effort daily, and then they find increased success and accomplishment. Find someone continually focused on accomplishing a goal despite setbacks or difficulties, and you'll find someone that heaven and earth move for!

The person who is absolutely passionate about increasing their business *will* find an increase. They may have to change or adapt, but it will increase if they diligently pursue their goal! Conversely, find a person who is slack in their business. You will see that they will experience a decrease. The inattentive and unfocused person will experience a decrease and decline. It seems like forces conspire for the diligent and conspire against the slacker.

The same holds for any goal or objective outside of business. *If one is diligent, focused, and gives their all, they experience an increase or success.* If one is half-hearted and weak-willed in any pursuit, one will not succeed. So, if we want divine forces to conspire with us in our endeavors, we must diligently pursue them! The harder we work, the more focused we become, the more we are blessed!

“DEVELOPING DILIGENCE 3”

Proverbs 13:4: “The soul of the sluggard desireth, and hath nothing: but the soul of the diligent shall be made fat.”

The contrast Solomon uses is striking to me. The sluggard and the diligent have inner desires (“soul”), but only the diligent person *uses the desire to drive them*. The diligent use their appetite to better drive them to what they desire. The sluggard’s desire only causes them to daydream or have delusions. They *won’t* do *what it takes* to get what they desire. However, the diligent person *will* do *whatever it takes* to make it happen, so they are prosperous (“fat”).

They both have a desire, but only the diligent are rewarded. *Desire minus diligence equals delusion*. It is not that the sluggard can’t have it; they won’t because of their lack of diligence and dedication to getting what they want. Many people *want*, but few *work* passionately and persistently to get what they want! Some people’s desires *fuel* them. Others have desires that only *frustrate* them!

It is important to note that the diligent person is not made “fat” from excess but from success! They are “fat” from prosperity, being overloaded with success, and not overweight from excessive pleasure. As we will see in later devotions, the diligent are disciplined managers of what they have. Their diligence causes prosperity and keeps it. Diligence requires disciplined focus.

What do you want or desire? Do you have an appetite for a better life? What are you craving? Whatever it is, you must realize it will be accomplished through diligence. It will take a relentless pursuit! It will cost! It will take tremendous exertion of all our physical and mental resources! Meticulous attention and nonstop action will be required! Do you still want it?!

“DEVELOPING DILIGENCE 4”

Proverbs 22:29: “Seest thou a man diligent in his business? he shall stand before kings; he shall not stand before mean men.”

It may take some time, but diligent people will be noticed and recognized. Every year, I think of this proverb when I see the World Series Champions or the Super Bowl winners at the White House being honored for their success. These athletes demonstrated diligence in the arena and gave their best in their endeavors. Diligence is not only rewarded; it *is recognized*.

That is no overnight process. This principle of diligence is being recognized. In the case of those athletes, many labored diligently at various levels way before they achieved recognized status. Many of them have excelled since they were kids. They got up earlier and stayed later than 99% of their peers. They paid a price way before they reaped any reward or recognition. They diligently pursued their goals and dreams years before they were recognized.

It doesn't matter what it is we do. If we are *the best* at it, recognition and reward will eventually show up for us. Notice Solomon says, “his business.” It might not be at the White House that you are recognized; it could be a promotion or an opportunity that is offered because your diligent effort is eventually seen. Solomon knows that the people who are already successful and in a position of power know the value of diligence. So it will eventually get their attention. They will not remain in obscurity. *Payday is someday, but it is not always the day we want.*

Sometimes people think, “When I get promoted, I'll work harder.” They tell themselves, “When I get paid more, I'll give more effort and energy.” But they seldom get the chance because the diligent are recognized and rewarded. God's way is for us to give our best at whatever task is at hand! *Like Joseph, who gave his best even in prison after being falsely accused.* He didn't labor with a bad attitude and worked half-heartedly because of his misfortune. He gave his best! He was diligent at whatever he was given and blessed because of it. Then one day, what seemed like circumstances worked for him. He was promoted to Pharaoh's right hand. He stayed diligent without being recognized until one day, he was recognized and rewarded. *If we aren't diligent now, we will not be diligent then!*

“DEVELOPING DILIGENCE IN LEADERSHIP”

Proverbs 27:23: “Be thou diligent to know the state of thy flocks, and look well to thy herds.”

Solomon was a man who had enormous wealth and assets. *With all his wealth came a tremendous amount of responsibilities.* He didn't shepherd his flocks but took responsibility for them. He was on top of his business, no matter its various forms. He *may have delegated*, but he *didn't abdicate* his responsibility. He wanted to know what was happening with his flocks, fortune, and followers. He knew that he had to manage what God had blessed him with. To manage what he had, he had to monitor what he had. He had to keep up with what was going on.

Wise business people and leader keep their finger on the pulse of all they are responsible for. They will maintain awareness of what is going on with their assets, business, and people. They will monitor every aspect of their business and organizations so they can act as soon as needed. *When a leader is too distant* from what is happening, it will most likely be too late when they realize something negative is happening. *When leaders are too distracted* from what is happening, they find problems growing and crises escalating because they are not keeping up with developments. A wise person will continuously monitor what and who they are responsible for so they can effectively manage these responsibilities.

The wise leader will not be absent or hands-off. They are diligent in knowing *what is* and *is not* going on. Permissiveness is neglecting one's duty to lead and manage. It will come back to a leader with negative consequences. Passiveness is also a form of neglect and will have negative consequences.

Further, it is seen as a form of weakness. Subordinates or competitors will see the weakness and use it to their advantage. Proactive, painstaking attention is required to succeed in any environment. Diligence is required when we have oversight. Ultimately, no one will care for and about your business or people like you will. God gave it to you to manage! No one can effectively manage what they don't monitor!

You may be like young David (Solomon's father), who only had a few sheep to manage, but he did it diligently. He gave his all, taking responsibility for those few sheep. God saw it. When He was looking for a new king, he knew David would be just as diligent as a king as a shepherd. Diligence is required to be an

effective manager or leader. Businesses and organizations of any type need a diligent person at the top who is actively aware of what is going on with all they are blessed with. They feel what is going on within the area of their responsibility. They are on top of everything they have oversight over. They are diligent in knowing the state of things!

“SOMEONE WE ALL NEED”

Proverbs 28:23: “He that rebuketh a man afterwards shall find more favour than he that flattereth with the tongue.”

We all need someone in our lives who will tell us what we need to hear and not what we want to hear. Having a true friend who cares enough to confront us is much *more productive* than having people who falsely flatter us. Most flattery is deceptive because it is either given by a non-credible or non-caring person who doesn't have our growth as their motive. However, a credible person who cares about our growth can speak with authority when confronting us!

A wise person will learn to “favor” or prefer *constructive confrontation* from a wise person over the flattery of a fool! *Flattery deceives, while honest, wise communication develops.* People who want to grow and improve will appreciate constructive communication's wisdom. They may not like it now, but they will appreciate the person and their perspective afterward. It may take a while because our first response is usually self-defense. We get on the defensive. Negative emotions usually rise first. We may get angry, embarrassed, or hurt, but we can appreciate the rebuke after the emotion dies down and logic reflects.

Flattery doesn't produce a reflection process. It does the opposite. It reinforces our weakness! It hinders growth and promotes further self-deception. It makes us feel better about ourselves. but sometimes we need to feel bad about ourselves to motivate us to make essential changes! That process allows us to grow. Unless we are occasionally challenged, we will get stuck *where we are* and *how we are*. A true ally is a person who wants us to be better and is willing to risk the status quo to make it happen.

Please know that Solomon makes a distinction between compliments and flattery. Flattery is designed to deceive or manipulate. Compliments are designed to develop and motivate. The person we need in our life is someone who balances their compliments toward us with constructive confrontation! That is a person we can trust what they say. They are developing us, not just trying to deceive us, to get from us! That type of person has way more credibility when they praise us than someone who only panders to us. We must value the person who tells us what we need to hear, not what we want to hear! We must value the person who desires our betterment over our continuous comfort! They will help free us from complacency, not feed our complacency!

“GOOD ADVICE WILL HELP YOUR SUCCESS”

Proverbs 11:14: “Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety.”

Solomon teaches that one reason people fall is that they don’t have good advice or good advisers. They lack the safety that comes from having wise people to provide guidance or leadership. Having trusted people to “bounce” ideas off is beneficial and healthy. Having access to the wise perspectives of counselors is an invaluable asset to anyone at any stage of life.

That is a two-way street. We need to have people to help us, but also, at the same time, we need to help guide others on their journey. People are falling all around us because they don’t have access to guidance and leadership. Some will not receive or want it, but for the few who desire help, we have a sacred responsibility to help them. People fail most often because they don’t know how to do what they want to do. They fall and fail because they weren’t shown the way to succeed. They make an attempt that is doomed before it starts because they don’t know how to plan and execute a plan.

Could you imagine trying to drive or ride a bike for the first time without ever seeing it done or having someone show you how? Many people have never been taught how to succeed at the things they want to succeed in. Many people haven’t had a successful example or instruction on living life successfully. They will end up faltering and failing, which leaves them frustrated. Before long, their frustration and disappointment led them to personalize the events and emotions to themselves. *They are a failure; they are stupid because they didn’t know how to succeed! Those aren’t true.* They lacked guidance!

Maybe you have failed and are frustrated. May it be that you lack the proper guidance in that area of your life? Living by the principles of prosperity is hard if you grew up in poverty. It is hard to live a fit lifestyle if you were never taught to be fit. If you were only exposed to doubt or the dogma of religion, it would be hard to live an authentic spiritual life. Do you see what I’m saying? If you have never seen a successful business model, it will be hard to produce one. There is hope! Find the right *model* and *mentor* in a given area to receive guidance. We live in a wonderful age where we can get virtual mentors, models, and leaders through books, audio assets, and online resources.

“USE ADVICE TO CHALLENGE YOUR PERSPECTIVE”

Proverbs 12:25: “The way of a fool is right in his own eyes: but he that hearkeneth unto counsel is wise.”

What separates and distinguishes a fool from a wise person in the proverb is that the wise listen to wise counsel, but the fool will not listen to wise advice. The fool is unwilling to entertain the thought that they are wrong. However, a wise person is willing to entertain advice from a wise person, even if it is not what they want to hear. The wise person will appreciate having their perspective challenged through the “counsel” process, whereas the fool wants to remain content in their conceit.

No one likes being told they are wrong or making a mistake. Yet, a wise person will put their ego aside to make the best decision. *The fool desires to feel they are right at all costs.* They avoid anyone or anything that challenges their perspective. They are closed-minded because they value being “right” over anything else. The more they isolate themselves in ignorance, the worse their conceit grows. They become dogmatic and defiant, insisting that they are right. On the other side is the wise person who values having their perspective challenged by counsel because they value wisdom over ego.

It should be a warning sign when we are afraid of wise counsel. The insecure are arrogant and closed-minded. The person of strength values having their perspective and plans challenged. The wise think, “two heads are better than one.” While the fool thinks they know what’s best, why bother asking for advice? They know it will challenge them, so they avoid that. To avoid that pain, they further deceive themselves into being right. It is how things look in their “own eyes.” A wise person wants to see from the “eyes” of others, so they seek “counsel.”

If we only look through our “own eyes,” we will deceive ourselves into thinking we are right. As we deceive ourselves, we increase our conceit, not our wisdom. We need the perspective of wise people to help us see things from different perspectives. This open-mindedness will help us eliminate mistakes and poor decisions and grow in wisdom.

“LOOK AT THE SOURCE OF THE ADVICE”

Proverbs 12:5: “The thoughts of the righteous are right: but the counsels of the wicked are deceit.”

The advice is only as good as its source. Here, Solomon brings up “the counsel of the wicked.” *We can't get wise advice from wicked counsel.* He mentions that the thoughts of the righteous are right. We get the right advice from people who think the right way. If the fountain's source is good, its water will be good. If the source is corrupt, the water will be corrupt. Contaminated, toxic people give toxic advice.

I often see people go to people who have the same problem as they do for advice. For example, someone with relationship problems will talk to their friend or coworker about the problem. The “counselor” will advise from their negative, jaded perspective. They will say, “leave the loser” after only hearing one side and having limited knowledge. Never seek advice from people who are emotionally attached to the problem. They will be biased and deliberately or unconsciously lead you according to their bias.

Remember, wise people seek advice from people who will challenge their perspective. They want to view the problem or challenge through the eyes of others. They realize they can deceive themselves incredibly when emotional. They use the *logic and wisdom* of *others* to help them *temper their emotion* and *challenge their thoughts*. This process is for our safety and stability.

We need counsel from people who want what is *best for us*, not *what is best for them*. We need counsel who *will strengthen our faith*, not *feed our fears*. We need counsel from people who think about *the consequences* of *our choices*, not the consequences *for them*. We must find people who will help us, not harm us. Advisors who want our success and do not promote their agenda. One way to help ensure we find these types of people is always to consider the source of the advice. Do they have what you want? Are they where you want to be? Are they credible in the given area?

“GETTING REAL KNOWLEDGE”

Proverbs 20:5: “Counsel in the heart of man is like deep water, but a man of understanding will draw it out.”

Good advice has to be drawn out. Bad advice is in abundance because it is poured out. The wiser the person, the less they disperse advice. It has to be drawn out. *The foolish and the arrogant are quick to give their advice, even when it is unsolicited.* They love to give their opinion on how to solve your problem. The irony is that they seldom take their advice or solve their problems.

Deep, cold water from a well is the best. It represents that the best advice is solicited from good sources. It is drawn out with purpose and persistence. It is not just being satisfied with the one-liner as advice. *It is digging deeper to get what you need to know, the “secret” of their success, digging for how-to and the way to success.* It is digging deep for their nugget of advice. The proverb says to let the bucket down as much as possible to get excellent counsel. It is not satisfied with the surface, shallow content.

The same principle is valid as a general communication principle. *If we want to get to know a person’s “heart,” we cannot be satisfied with surface-level communication.* We must go beyond the surface and below the shallow levels, going deep into a person’s heart. Like soliciting good advice, this takes persistence and purpose. Most people are content with surface-level communication. Listen to the conversations people have. They are about the weather, current events, or things that involve no heart or substance.

To gain knowledge of a person’s heart, we must go deep. We must go beyond where most stop and draw from deep within them. That is where the best counsel lies. That is where the authentic person dwells. Draw from their depths to get to know a person intimately. It takes longer, but the reward is worth the *persistence* and *patience*.

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION ”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

This passage has been interpreted in various ways, but I see the word “vision” as a divine, creative plan with a future focus. It does mean some form of revelation from God, whether The Word or a plan to fulfill His purpose. Vision is seeing something not yet a reality in its physical form. It is a mental concept born in the spirit. It may start as an idea or an image. *It is developed and designed inside a person’s mind, spirit, and heart.* That is where God reveals to us what can be or should be. This “vision” is how man creates. It is a divine process granted to humankind alone. It is also where God reveals what He wants to be done.

The consequences of not having a vision are clear: “people perish.” They perish because they don’t have a vision or their leaders do not have a vision of a better future. They perish because they are trapped by what is and can’t see what can be! Our lives or organizations without vision are like a pool of water with no inlet or outlet; they will stagnate and eventually dry up. The water and all that is in it will perish. People without the inlet of a vision and the outlet of fulfilling that vision will stagnate, dry up, and wither away. As their lives without vision dry up, the stagnation will become a breeding pool for disease, decay, and death.

People are perishing around us, not because they must, but because they lack a vision of a better life! *This stagnation breeds hopelessness, depression, and anxiety.* All they can visualize is what they see in fear and anxiety. They see things as hopeless and manifest that vision, thus perishing. Many people in the position of leaders, from parents to presidents, have no positive vision. *They are problem-conscious but have no vision of a better future.* People are perishing because so few people have a vision of a better, brighter future. That perpetuates the stagnation because there is no revelation! *Where there is no inspiration, there will be stagnation!*

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 2”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

Vision allows us to see that things can be better or something better can be created. It allows us to have hope beyond our current circumstances. Without this hope, we are left hopeless because we can’t “see” beyond what is to what can be! We *feel trapped*, which creates the feelings of just giving up and giving in to what is as if it is permanent. It is only permanent because we lack a vision of or for the better!

When people feel trapped, they begin to “perish.” That is, they start being resigned to the forces that be instead of the force they are. They lose perspective and power because they have no vision of a better day or way. “What it will always be” is how they think, so they no longer try for the better. They no longer try for better because they don’t expect better. They don’t expect better because they can’t “see” better. They have no vision!

If people who are sick can’t “see” themselves getting better, they will not get well. If people in poverty can’t create or capture a vision of themselves having prosperity, they will remain in that poverty. If people who have failed or made significant mistakes can’t “see” themselves overcoming that failure, they will live with it for the rest of their lives. They will close their minds to God’s revelation of better and lose all hope. They will perish despite the divine ability and resources granted to them.

Vision inspires hope. Hope inspires positive expectations. Positive expectation inspires positive action. It allows one to work hard with the expectation of a better future in some way. This visioning process pulls us out of where we are and pushes us to where we want to be. It activates divine forces in our lives that remain dormant if we choose to live without vision. It creates power and unlocks our potential. It liberates us from the prison of what it is to live in the freedom of what can be!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 3”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

“Vision is the art of ‘seeing’ things in our minds and spirits before they become a physical reality. *It is having a mental concept of something before it becomes actual.* It is a creative process given exclusively to humankind by the Creator. It is a spiritual activity. What people call an idea can be a form of divine revelation. That is an incredible process.

We all have thoughts that are the seeds of visions, but most people dismiss them due to a lack of faith. *Negative thoughts and a lack of faith kill the life out of these seeds.* For example, people in poverty may have thought of a better life, but then *destroy that thought before it can become a vision* by thinking, “That will never happen for me.” They think or say, “Things will never change,” and in the process, pull up the seed that could’ve turned into a vision. Further, that vision could have become the very thing that *pushed them out* of their circumstances and *pulled them* into a new, better actuality.

So that same person in our example will “perish” in poverty because of the lack of a vision for a better, different life. *They will remain stagnant because they refuse to have a voice of inspiration.* That means *their stagnation will become deterioration*, i.e., they “perish.” Without vision, *they will close their mind* to what can be and only “see” what is. Consequently, *they will close their mind* to any possible opportunities for betterment. They won’t “see” how it may work, so they develop a “why try” attitude. Their hopelessness turns into helplessness or heartlessness. They refuse any means of real help or turn cold, maybe criminal. All this is created because they have no vision of a better life or personal betterment.

Vision is essential for any positive change to take place. *If it cannot be conceptualized, it will never materialize.* Said another way, if we can’t create it within, we will not create it without. When we live in the negative, we turn off our creative nature. We become *victims* of what has been and of what is, the current reality. *We live in bondage* to the status quo. We become *enslaved* to circumstances and live in the prison of our environment. That has never been God’s plan for us!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 4”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

If vision is essential for any positive change, then learning to develop the art of creating a vision is vital. Everyone can *have vision*, but only a few have learned to cultivate the ability. Some people seem more predisposed to hear the voice of inspiration that causes them to conceptualize a better life or a better way. Others have more difficulty cultivating vision because their thought process constantly combats or destroys inspiring thoughts. The more negative the mental climate, the less likely any vision will take root.

As said before, we all have thoughts that come to us, revealing the possibilities. It may be an *idea* or *image*, but that is the genesis of a vision. The difference is that some *dismiss these thoughts* as foolish, while others *develop those thoughts*. They fertilize the seed by thinking about it positively. They begin to do just what any artist, architect, or designer does. They enhance the concept by thinking about it. They think of the idea, forming and fertilizing it with thoughts about it. They may brainstorm on paper or daydream about it. They may research it. Look at similar things to their vision. The young man in poverty may dream of a nice house and a car. He may look at magazines or daydream about what it would be like. What is he doing? He is conceptualizing the vision of something that is not yet a reality for him.

When we think positively about what we want to create or manifest, we develop the thought *into a vision*. It is forming and framing within the person. We can further develop the vision by writing it down. We can describe it or its purpose on paper. Every detail imagined or written develops the thought into a vision. It gives energy and life to the vision. We begin to pray about the vision, which further activates our faith. Our minds and spirits begin to feel connected with the Creator as we create. It is a divine process. It is a birthing process. It is creating and cultivating life. It is not a human life but a life of an idea. That is how we develop a vision!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 5”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

If we don't have something *positive and creative to focus on*, we will *default to focusing on the negative and circumstantial*. The “circumstantial” becomes our focus, which leaves us feeling like animals just surviving. We become like rats in a cage—a sad, redundant life based on survival. We develop a dependency mentality. However, when one lives with a vision, one goes beyond circumstantial. They become the source because they are connected to the Source. They become creators and move beyond the dependency mentality. They become creative and see possibilities beyond the cage of circumstances. That is the creative power God has granted to humankind.

When there is no vision, there is no compelling future. When one has a compelling future, one can imagine and conceptualize something that isn't a reality yet. In doing that, they harness a power that pushes them away from what is and pulls them to what can be. This internalization is the divine gift of imagination. It has creative power that is divine in its origin. When partnered with the spiritual power of faith, it can become an unstoppable force. It can create something from nothing. It can change circumstances and destinies and cause ordinary people to become extraordinary. It can change fortunes and change the future. It is limitless, which is a far superior way of living compared to feeling caged by circumstances or depending on others.

When one has a vision of a better way or day, it allows them to feel optimistic about the future. Without a vision of a compelling future, we will become pessimistic about the future. This pessimism about tomorrow makes today feel even worse. It is draining and demotivating. Conversely, when one has a vision, it is motivating. It gives energy to today because we sense and see a better day coming. It inspires us to act enthusiastically, giving us the strength to overcome and push forward! It fuels us with hope today while allowing us to focus on a better future. *It pushes and pulls us out of our circumstances while simultaneously creating the future.* So, visions create a compelling future!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 6”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

When we develop a vision and begin to create a compelling future, we create hope for ourselves. *We begin to think about possibilities*, putting us in the proper mindset to develop faith. Now we stop focusing on the borders of what is and always has been. We start focusing on what can be or should be. *We are expanding our minds, which expands our territory. As we expand our thoughts of what is possible, we are simultaneously enlarging our ability to believe.* Faith needs an outlet. Therefore, a vision of something to be created or constructed is essential. It gives our faith a focus.

We partner with God when we develop a vision focusing on our faith. *We have access to the assets of God.* We enter into the divine realm of creativity. We gain access to Divine power and provision. After cultivating the vision and focusing on our faith, it seems things align to bring the vision to pass. People show up to help. Doors open, and opportunities appear. Ask anyone who has ever brought a vision to reality; they will have some story to support the “Alignment Principle”. That, in turn, further strengthens our faith and ability to believe.

The opposite is true as well. When we live without vision, we deny ourselves access to divine assets. We don’t have the “Alignment Principle” working for us. When we live without a vision, things seem to conspire against us. Things going wrong seem to be perpetuated in our lives. It is a self-created phenomenon because we lack a compelling future and something to focus our faith on. *We close out God because of our doubts, fears, and negative focus.* We constrain our minds with a lack of vision instead of expanding them with a vision. We close doors and kill opportunities because we can’t see behind the borders of what is or has been. We limit our territory, not God! That makes our lives less than they could be because we refuse to cultivate a vision.

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 7”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

Not only does creating and cultivating a vision allow us to enter into a *divine partnership*, but it also allows us to access *divine provisions*. Where there is vision, there will always be provision! When there is scarcity or poverty, it is clear there is no vision. There is no vision to focus their faith. They may have faith, but it will be dormant because it has no outlet due to a lack of vision or a compelling future.

Show me any business, a ministry, or a man without a positive, specific vision. I will show you a business, a ministry, and a man lacking, suffering, and even on the verge of perishing. They can beg, plead, or guilt-trip as a motivation, but it will not bring prosperity and abundant provisions. *Heaven and hearts respond to vision*. Provision flows to those with a vision and away from those without. The provision goes to those who create something of value or a better future. The provision goes away from those who try to maintain the status quo.

When a business organization or ministry begins to maintain what they have and are, it won't be long before they experience a lack. *The status quo is only one step from perishing or dying a slow death*. A *maintenance mindset* is one step from a *dying mindset*. The only question is whether the organization or business will die slowly or rabidly. Their provision and prosperity dry up. The energy level gets lower and lower. The leader, business, and ministry begin to lose their resources and assets to those with a compelling vision. It is the beginning of a slow end.

The bigger and clearer their vision, the more abundant the provision will be! A winning vision attracts winners. A big vision attracts big thinkers who are generous in supporting that vision. At the same time, it repels small-minded people, which is positive because they will only hinder the vision without helping to support it. Miraculous things happen to people who have a positive vision. The “Alignment Principle” is activated, and the right people and provisions flow to that vision. There is Divine Provision!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 8”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

So, without vision, people perish, businesses, ministries, and even families perish. Vision creates prosperity and progress. It gives life to and sustains life in any human endeavor. When the vision stops, life begins to die out. Renewed vision renews life and energy for the individual or organization. That explains why once-thriving people or organizations begin to decay, decline, and die (“perish”).

Vision doesn't look at the past! It focuses on the future, a compelling future. Whenever people or organizations look longingly at the past, they give energy to what is dead. It doesn't matter how much energy or thought they put into it. The fact is, the past is dead. It is like trying to revive a dead body. It will not happen. What happens is that it takes energy and life away from the future. We kill the future by focusing on the past that is already dead. Vision looks into the future! It is a creative force with a creative future!

Vision doesn't require faith to reflect on what has already been done. Doing so *will diminish our faith because faith is a substance of things hoped for and gives evidence of things yet to be seen* (Hebrews 11: 1). It doesn't activate on things already seen, done, and over unless it is something impossible to believe by the natural mind, like the Resurrection itself.

It does take faith to create, cultivate, and carry out a vision. It takes faith to allow oneself to begin to think in terms of possibilities, especially when it is low in probability. It takes faith to concentrate and elaborate on something yet to happen or even be a reality. It takes faith to begin taking the steps to construct the vision. Faith is a force that is focused through the vision processed. Man's creative power is united with God's creative power when vision and faith are joined. Thoughts come to life and become their physical equivalent. Plans become real! Concepts become concrete! Man becomes a creator, fulfilling their purpose. The future is created!

We will never unleash this creative, life-giving force by focusing on the past! All we will do is create more despair and death because we keep aborting the future by trying to revive the past. We will become disappointed and

dysfunctional because we are trying to bring life back into something God wants to be buried, the past! We will look at everything through the misperception of *what was*, when God wants us to look forward with the perspective of *what can be*!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 9”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

Vision is God’s answer to stop perishing. Perishing can come in various forms. It can be an organization, a nation, or a community perishing. It may be a team, a business, a family, or an individual perishing. It could be a secular entity or ministry that is perishing. No matter what is perishing, the solution is a positive, creative, compelling vision. A vision that gives life and imparts energy activates faith. A vision that inspires hope and influences positive action from those involved.

Vision is the solution. It requires an *open mind to new possibilities* and an *open spirit to divine communication*. Vision is always solution-focused. It can be a creative solution to an existing challenge or a new concept altogether. Either way, it has a positive, productive focus and is solution-oriented. It will make a *better way* or *day*, but it will produce *something better*. If it doesn’t produce betterment, it is not a vision. It is merely a revision of something that is. No vision means no real solutions.

A lack of vision is also a problem. *When there is a lack of vision, there will be a lack of betterment*. Hope isn’t inspired. Hope is inhibited. Every hopeful thought will feel forced and draining. Why? There is no vision. There is no life. The individual or organization is sick and dying. The sick or perishing one may have some good days, but they are fewer and farther between.

Further, the “lows” begin to chart lower, and the “highs” begin to be less high. It won’t be long before the individual or organization flatlines or requires artificial support of some kind. The artificial support may be another company buying them out, a loan, a plea for help, or some gimmick that is a temporary fix. That will only prolong the inevitable perishing that will take place because there is no real vision!

The real solution will fail to manifest until a creative, compelling, inspiring vision is created. Everything tried may work briefly, but it is only delaying the inevitable. Without vision, there is only perishing. Without vision, there will be no real solutions, just temporary fixes that mask the pain of a “sick” patient. There will be no healing for the organization or individual; they will manage the illness. The illness is the lack of vision!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 10”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

If a vision is God’s solution to stop perishing, how do we know the difference between a vision and an idea, a thought? Based on visions in the Bible and observations of life, a vision has some distinct characteristics. There are more, but here are a few.

Vision points to the way. Said another way, a vision gives direction. It may give direction from a bad circumstance or to a new place. That place can be literal, like the promised land, or figurative. Either way, a vision provides clear direction. It says this is the way or direction we are headed as a business or organization. That is my life’s direction, so I plan and prioritize accordingly.

Vision provides the why. Vision says this is why we are doing this. It is why we are changing. It is why we are going to succeed or get “there.” It provides motivation. Vision is the motive for my actions. It says this is why we will create a better day or way. Why is the key to any transformation or reformation! If we examine it, the biblical God always reveals a why with the way. *If we have the why, we will find the way!* If we find the why to succeed, we will find the way!

Vision plans the what. Vision clarifies what steps or actions must be taken to make the vision a reality. Vision is a big picture, and the details are added in time. It is a process. The big picture, however, also provides clear beginning steps. The vision will reveal the steps as needed. The vision is useless if we know the way to go but don’t know how. What to do is revealed and becomes more apparent with each step of faith.

If our vision doesn’t provide a way and a why, it is only an idea. It isn’t a vision yet. *It isn’t a complete vision yet if there is no starting point or a “what” to do to get started.* Biblically, a prophecy would say what would happen without any steps because it depended on God. Vision is dependent on our actions. A vision always points the way, provides the why, and plans what to do because it depends on our actions!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 11”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

If we choose not to cultivate a vision of what can be, we perpetuate the existence of what is! Things don't just get better by accident. They get better because a positive vision says, “Better is possible.” Things get better when better is created by cultivating a compelling vision of what can be! It generates what can be new life that improves life by creating and cultivating a vision of what can be. Without a life-giving, energy-focusing vision, we default more to what is. God gives us all a garden. We can see it full of beautiful things and make it happen, or we just let it remain as it produces more weeds, things we don't want. Either way, the garden will grow something. More of what it is or what we want to cultivate on purpose!

If we choose not to cultivate a vision of what we desire, we perpetuate the existence of what we do not desire! That is perpetuated because we starve the better we desire by focusing by default on what we do not desire. That happens because we are not actively designing what we desire. *The negative grows even with passive attention.* The positive will only grow through purposeful attention. Vision is God's way of giving us purposeful attention and powerful intention.

If we choose not to cultivate a vision to generate something better, we will perpetuate the degeneration of what is currently good. Our lives are either in a state of generation or in a state of degeneration. *We are using our ability to create and produce positive things, or we are losing that ability and leaving our lives deteriorated.* Things may appear to stay the same, but that is a literal impossibility! The rate of degeneration and deterioration is happening slowly, but the results will manifest quickly. Before disease symptoms occur, healthy cells are degenerated. The symptoms may manifest quickly, but the cause was happening slowly, unnoticed. Before a business went out of business, its deterioration was happening so slowly that most didn't notice.

Our world is always in a state of change. Our bodies are always in a state of change. Our organizations, regardless of whether they are secular or spiritual in their pursuits and purpose, are always in a state of change. They are either what they can be because we have cultivated a vision, or they are full of the negative while slowly deteriorating. The question of this day is, are we in a state of creating

what can be or creating more of what already is? Are we or our “businesses” generating new life or in a state of degeneration? Are we cultivating our garden on purpose with a positive vision?

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 12”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

The ability to create, cultivate, and carry out a vision is God’s way of answering our problems. It is how we can tap into our divine creative resources and *the Divine Creative Source*. Think of it in these terms: every cure to a disease was found because someone had the vision for doing that. It didn’t yet exist in the physical world but was created from a thought. A thought was conceptualized until the cure materialized. Now think of everything that now exists in our world. The computer I’m using, the building I am in, and the car I drove all were once only thoughts that became visions and then a physical reality.

Everything I mentioned, and many others, were created by people who cultivated a vision even though what they desired to create seemed impossible or improbable to most. They tapped into a creative power that allowed them to overcome the odds and the mindset of the masses! They solved seemingly impossible problems and overcame improbable odds because they had a vision. They bought into their vision and believed in it with resolve and optimism. *Failures, setbacks, and the majority opinion of others couldn’t stop what they wanted to create*. Even the expert analyses that said “they couldn’t create what they had a vision for” didn’t stop them.

These visionaries so internalized their vision as a reality that it became a reality! Amazing, right?! That same power is available to any of us to create a better life for ourselves and others. We can create a divine solution to solve a human problem. We can create a thriving ministry that changes lives even as most perish. We can create or recreate a successful business even as many are failing. The person’s vision only limits the power of vision. *What do you want to create? What problem do you have a passion for solving?*

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 13”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

As mentioned, some people seem more naturally prone to cultivate the power of vision than others. However, we all can create and cultivate a vision. This divine ability was given to us by the Divine Creator. This ability or gift is like any other. It gets easier to do as it's used. If it is unused, a person's greatness is often underdeveloped. The power of vision is also the key to a person's potential. It is God's way of us recreating ourselves, transforming ourselves, and our “world.”

For those who have never created and cultivated a vision of their own, I suggest they buy into someone else's vision. They can find a leader creating and carrying out their God-given vision. *When you buy into a vision, you also get the benefits of that assumed vision!* Please note that you also assume the responsibilities of the vision in small measure compared to the leader. That is good because it lets you see visions don't just happen; there are risks and responsibilities with impending rewards.

The easiest way to learn how to conceptualize and materialize a vision is to be a part of one. *It allows one to see it is not hocus pocus but a matter of focus.* It is focusing energy and effort on a specific area. It focuses faith on the creation and causation of something predetermined. Participation will broaden our minds and expand our way of thinking. That is the genesis of creating the right mindset to create and cultivate your vision. That is the benefit of *internships* and *memberships* in an organization with a positive vision.

Further, on a personal level, that is where mentorships have value. Find a *personal leader for a specific area you want to create or recreate.* For example, if you want a fit body, find someone who can mentor you to create a similar result to what you want to achieve. You find someone who has already created the physical reality of your mental concept. If starting a business from home, find a mentor who has done just that. They will, with or without knowing it, be able to draw your vision out of you and show you how to develop it. These mentors can be paid or volunteer, but they will help you accomplish a personal vision of transforming your life. So, *buy into someone's vision* or *borrow their experience* to accomplish it.

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 14”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

As mentioned in the previous devotion, a person’s potential is tied to the power of their vision. *Circumstances, mistakes, or environments do not limit a person. They are limited by their vision or lack thereof.* The Bible is full of people who had a God-given vision and became extraordinary despite their poverty, past mistakes, or the attempts of others to destroy their dreams. Their vision allowed them to focus their faith so that they transformed their lives and positively influenced many people.

Until we have a positive God-given vision, it will be hard to transform into who we can be and do what God can enable us to do. When there is a vision, the transformation is astonishing! An old man becomes the father of a nation. A man accused of rape who was a slave becomes the CEO of a company and savior to his family. A murderer who becomes a runaway is transformed into a prophet and leader of millions. A shepherd boy who would rather write songs than fight becomes a giant killer, a war hero, and the king of a great nation. Later, a hater of Christianity becomes a hero of Christianity *despite his past*. He conspired to have innocent people murdered and tortured. So on and on, the Bible teaches how a God-given *vision can supersize the potential of people*.

The question is *never* if God has a vision for us. It is only what is God’s vision is for us. One may only presume God’s vision for oneself. It will not come written or spoken audibly, but will be planted as a persistent desire that contradicts current realities! *It will require faith to believe it and faith to achieve it!* It will seem bigger or better than what is probable. It will be big enough or better enough to inspire you and others later! It will require the vision conceiver to grow and stretch beyond what they think are their current limitations! It will create tension within.

That is where people hit their mental brakes when they feel the tension of something pulling them out of what has become their comfort zone! The “Egypt” they know seems more comfortable than the uncertainty of the unknown created and caused by the vision. Vision requires change, and people are so afraid of change, even if positive, that they will hit their mental brakes and kill their vision. In doing so, they also destroy their divine potential!

“THE NECESSITY OF VISION 15”

Proverbs 29:18: “Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he.”

I think of the steps of a vision as follows: Sense it. See it. Say it. Seize it. The stages flow into each other because they are spiritual and mental processes, so they don't have clear borders. However, they help recognize how a vision is developed and dispersed.

Sense it = The Internalization Stage. The vision is only something that is thought about. There is no action other than a desire fertilized by repetitive thoughts like “what if” and “How can.” That is where the vision holder begins to sense there is a possibility, even if it seems impossible. They sense within themselves that things can change for the positive. They sense a solution to a problem. They sense a better “day” or a better way. They hear a small voice within them that others are ignoring or don't hear.

See it = Conceptualization Stage. The vision begins to take on form. As mentioned previously, details are added to some degree. Maybe it is planned on paper or mentally processed, but it becomes more realistic to the vision holder. It intensifies as it is emotionalized in faith and positive emotions.

Say It = Manifestation Stage. The vision is now made known. It is cast to others by the vision holder, explaining the vision and why it is. That is a dangerous stage! If the vision holder does it prematurely, those it is shared with can sabotage it. They can sow seeds of doubt, so be sure it is firmly internalized and conceptualized. Most *vision holders get excited about what they are “Seeing” and Sensing, so they are eager to share it, but this can destroy the still-developing life.* It needs time to incubate before it is exposed to the negative influences of doubters.

Seize It = Materialization Stage. The vision is now beginning to become physical. Physical, tangible steps are being undertaken, no matter how small. If it requires a team, they are led to act. The “to-do” list is up, and the checking off begins. Action is being taken daily to turn what was once only sensed into a reality. Constructing what was once only a concept requires tremendous physical energy and effort. However, many do not realize that materializing the vision also takes tremendous mental and spiritual energy. Creative energy uses all our resources as creative beings, including our faith!

“OPEN A WISDOM SAVINGS ACCOUNT”

Proverbs 10:14: “Wise men lay up knowledge: but the mouth of the foolish is near destruction.”

My grandmother’s generation lived through the depression. That economic hardship caused her and many of her generation to *learn the importance of saving*. They created most of their “wealth” by saving for “hard times.” They always feared another impending hardship, like the depression era. They would borrow money from themselves and pay it back. That gave them a positive net worth and freedom to make wise decisions.

In our text, Solomon said wise people save up and treasure knowledge. *They collect and save knowledge like the valuable commodity it is*. Foolish people wait until they need knowledge and then seek it out. That is a *highly ineffective way to live* because a crisis is not the best time to learn the needed knowledge, because of the desperate emotion present. It is like trying to earn more money fast to handle a crisis. It just will not work. If there were a savings account that could be drawn from, *the crisis would be managed more effortlessly and more effectively*.

We need to follow Solomon’s advice and save up knowledge. What kind of knowledge? Collect and store any knowledge that has a positive value toward making our lives better or the lives of others. It has to have worth and value! *Some people collect junk, and wise and wealthy people collect assets*. An asset has value and worth beyond emotional sentiment. So, as a person saves or collects assets, their personal value also grows. That is the concept of net worth. Some people generate huge incomes but have no net worth. They have no savings and have not collected anything of value. They only need to miss two paychecks and are broke even on a huge salary. They have no real security! Compared to my grandmother, who never made over a few hundred dollars a week, they are broke.

If we want security in a changing world, we must become savers of knowledge. If we want to increase our value, we must increase positive knowledge. We must get into the habit of learning as much as possible. Seek out knowledge on purpose and save it like we desperately need it someday! We must save up knowledge *before we get the promotion*. We must save up knowledge *before the crisis* happens to apply what we already possess, because it will be too late to learn. Have you opened your wisdom savings account? Are you making small, daily deposits that add up for us over time?

“FUN VERSUS FOOLISHNESS”

Proverbs 10:23: “It is as sport to a fool to do mischief: but a man of understanding hath wisdom.”

If we want to follow a wise lifestyle, we must discern the difference between *fun* and *foolishness*. In the proverb, Solomon says foolish people make it a game of being foolish. It is a form of recreation and pleasure for them. Meanwhile, the wise person understands that finding “sport” in the wrong things, even if they are fun at the moment, can have costly long-term consequences.

There can be a fine line between something true and foolish. Many fun things turn to foolishness just by habitual participation or overindulgence. The line is that this pure fun has no real negative consequences. *It will not have a long-term price that is eventually painful*. It doesn't cloud our discernment or ability to make wise decisions. It does cause us to lose our self-control or lower our standards. It doesn't hinder our relationship with God or conflict with our priorities. It is healthy for us, not destructive.

When pursuing pleasure is our primary interest, we are headed toward foolishness. We lose our sense of purpose, leading to an “I just want to have fun” mentality. Our purpose, plans, and priorities begin to suffer. We stop being success-driven; positive relationships begin to have conflicts. We lack discernment and perspective. Good habits begin to be undermined by bad habits, which leads to more eventual negative consequences. That causes the pursuit of more foolishness to mask the pain. Thus, a vicious cycle is created.

When pleasure is pursued as the priority, all other priorities will be forfeited eventually because they can't compete with its instant gratification. It is addictive even if it is not a narcotic pursuit. Recreation as a purpose is addictive. It becomes a sport to see who can get the wildest, go the hardest, or do the most. They keep a score of the pursuits. And the temporary consequences are ignored and medicated by more pleasure until the pleasure is more painful than pleasurable.

Wisdom is having fun without becoming foolish. Wisdom understands that foolishness can be pleasurable and lead to painful consequences. Wise people choose fun, not foolishness. They guard their standards and their success. They know that when we make foolishness a sport, everyone loses in the end!

“THE DANGERS OF PRIDE”

Proverbs 11:2: “When pride cometh, then cometh shame: but with the lowly is wisdom.”

Pride is a dangerous form of emotion. It is more the result of negative emotion than the emotion itself. It is usually the manifestation of hurt feelings or insecurity. It is a form of arrogance and ego. Pride is manifested when negative emotions are high, so logic is low. That leads to embarrassing and shameful behavior. *It diminishes wisdom and increases foolishness.*

Pride occurs when we get into a seemingly innocent argument that turns into a foolish fight. Emotions get high, and words become hurtful. This further invokes pride, so it escalates. Behavior becomes shameful, and words do too. Pride manifests as the desire to be right or win in an unwinnable situation.

Pride has to get its way, be right, or be pacified, and compensate for wounded emotion or perceived weakness. To compensate, it tries to dominate or manifest some display of strength. The prideful one usually gets louder and more assertive. They will even say and do foolish things to display a false sense of strength and power, which usually leads to embarrassing behavior.

Pride is a combination of emotion and ego. *That combination is a recipe for unwise behavior.* It feeds the flesh and fights against the Spirit. Selfishness and self-assertion are the agenda of pride. It cares very little for the adverse effects it has on others. It will not listen to counsel or acknowledge wisdom. Pride sees others as wrong or stupid. So, it doesn't care what others think. That mentally further leads to shameful behavior.

On the other side of the proverb, we see that humility allows wisdom to prevail. Humility is the opposite of selfishness and self-assertion. *It is willing to be perceived as weak to show real strength. It is willing not to be perceived as right to maintain doing right.* It wants to de-escalate foolishness to retain wise behavior and the peace it produces. Humility is concerned with the actual character, not perception. It gives up its rights to fulfill its responsibilities. It doesn't produce shameful behavior.

“THE DANGERS OF PRIDE 2”

Proverbs 13:10: “Only by pride cometh contention: but with the well advised is wisdom.”

Pride causes contention. *It creates a negative mental climate that causes contention.* It creates stress and struggle because everyone involved is pridefully trying to get their way. It is about promoting self instead of seeking peace, which is better for the whole. Pride destroys unity and harmony. It divides over personal perspectives, hurts, or agendas. Contention will always be present when pride is the driving force.

Pride causes conflicts. It creates contention that may fester within, but it will not be long before it becomes a conflict. It becomes a contest of foolish wills driven by my foolish emotion. Conflicts will escalate as pride grows from a feeling of being wronged in some way and the desire for appeasement.

Pride creates such a climate of conflict that people often forget the original problem while deleting any acknowledgment of the other side's goodness. It is war. Win at all costs, including destroying the perceived opposition. It doesn't matter if the conflict is with someone who was once a friend, family member, or spouse. It becomes win the conflict at all **costs**. That usually means hurting them as much as possible in some way.

Pride causes consequences. *The contention escalates to conflict, which will eventually create negative consequences.* People are hurt. Relationships are destroyed. Families are divided and devastated. Churches are corrupted, and organizations are permanently destroyed. When pride takes over, the consequences are harsh and often irreparable. It permanently destroys the foundation of trust that must exist. The consequences of prideful conflicts are sad and sickening. The negativity and hostility it creates leave behind life-altering damage. It can be a hurricane of negative emotions that leaves behind a cataclysmic disaster.

The wise person is well advised to avoid the dangers of pride. They avoid or at least resolve contention before it escalates to conflict. They seek peace over personal injury. The wise person lets go of the wrong so they can stay right. Peace is a higher priority for them than pacifying their pride. A wise person will control their pride before it gets so powerful that it controls them.

‘THE DANGERS OF PRIDE 3’

Proverbs 29:23: “A man’s pride shall bring him low: but honour shall uphold the humble in spirit.”

Pride is a *very deceptive human quality* because *it feels positive in the moment*, but creates adverse consequences. It feels like it is lifting us now, but in reality, it is bringing us down. We sink to new lows every time pride takes control over our attitudes and actions.

Pride in the immediate feels like it empowers us to say and do things that make us feel some immediate gratification, but it disempowers us the whole time. We feel in control and powerful, even though we are out of control, which causes us to be brought “low” by our behavior. We are sabotaging ourselves when we are under the influence of pride. We act self-destructively even though we may not feel like it in the moment. But when the heat of pride is cooled, we see the evidence of what was burnt.

Pride will destroy our character because it can cause us to act uncharacteristically. A gentle person can become angry and aggressive. A kind person under pride’s influence can become cruel and vicious. A spiritual person can become debased and act carnally. It can happen to anyone. The Bible is full of people who acted out differently under the influence and deception of pride.

Pride will cause us to act dishonorably. It will cause us to dishonor God, ourselves, and what we love. A man of high standards can become “low” under the deceptive influence of pride. Pride seeks self-gratification at all costs. and that cost is usually one of lowering one’s standards and status.

Humility, on the other hand, allows one to retain honor. *Being humble and not giving in to pride’s influence usually feels negative.* It makes one feel “low,” but in reality, they empower themselves by not seeking the path of self-gratification. When the moment is passed and the emotion dies down, the humble person retains honor and character. They give up the right to be correct but keep their honor because they do not lower their standards!

“THE DANGERS OF PRIDE 4”

Proverbs 16:18: “Pride goeth before destruction, and an haughty spirit before a fall.”

Pride and arrogance (“haughty spirit”) are hard to separate. They have no clear dividing lines as individual dysfunctions. However, they have clear consequences, “destruction” and “fall” or ruin. The eventual, inevitable consequences may take a while to manifest, but this proverb’s principle will hold. Both the Bible and history have numerous examples of this truth.

The destruction and ruin from *perpetual pride* are a form of self-destruction. Others may be agents of destruction and ruin, but they can always be traced back to the path of perpetual pride. This perpetual pride produces an arrogant attitude that creates a false illusion of invincibility and a belief that the arrogant one is right, no matter who says otherwise. They stop listening to counsel and begin to harden their hearts more and more to any voice but their own. They make enemies of friends and become blinded by their arrogance.

This path of the proud and arrogant is self-destructive. They will destroy what they have built and lose what they have achieved. If they have been perpetually full of pride and arrogance since they were young, they will destroy themselves faster. They will forfeit and ruin their lives before they can achieve and accomplish anything. They will be self-indulgent, which will lead to self-destruction!

The wise believer will learn to walk in humility. They will learn to be sensitive to the Spirit’s speaking about the signs of pride and arrogance. They will *admit* and *acknowledge* their weaknesses, so they can deal with them and not be dominated by them. They will *seek peace* and reconciliation with those they have wronged and who have wronged them. They will be *forgiving* and *forbearing*. They will be *tenderhearted*, not allowing their heart to become hardened by pride. They will put the good of others ahead of their agendas and ambition. They will pray continuously to remain sensitive to God’s counsel and to correct it! That is the path of *perpetual peace*!

“DEALING WITH PRIDE”

Proverbs 18:12: “Before destruction the heart of man is haughty, and before honour is humility.”

The opposite of pride is humility. So, the way to *deal with pride* is to *develop humility*. Pride brings eventual dishonor, while humility brings honor. Pride unleashes the worst in us. It fuels our anger and feeds our desire for vengeance. Vengeance is not what many think. It also manifests as the desire to get even with those who hurt us, verbal vengeance or otherwise. Humility keeps the anger and other negative emotions contained because it doesn't allow them to be fueled or fed. Humility forgives, forbears, and forfeits the right to act in negative emotion.

Pride is selfish. Humility is selfless. Pride seeks to be pacified, while humility seeks peace. Pride gets offended easily and often. It has a chip on its shoulder. Humility isn't easily offended or wounded. It is a divine quality. Humility lets things go. Pride wants to make a show. It wants to express itself. Humility doesn't feel the need to express itself through anger, hurt, or complaining.

Humility doesn't carry the weight of an offense around. Pride carries offenses around as if it were a debt that must be paid somehow. Pride wants the right to be mad, speak its mind, and get what it perceives it deserves. Humility forfeits its felt rights to fulfill its responsibilities to God and those they serve. Pride feels like it deserves more and may demand it. If it doesn't demand it, it will pout and complain. Humility does more and allows God to honor and reward in His way and His day.

Humility seeks to be honorable, not honored. *It seeks to lift others, not promote itself*. It desires to give over getting. It seeks to bless, not burden. It lets go of ego to live a purposeful, peaceful life. God will honor and reward those who choose humility over pride. He will bless while *developing the character* that will produce far greater rewards than a promotion from the assertion of pride.

“BECOME A DOER, NOT A FOLLOWER”

Proverbs 12:11: “He that tilleth his land shall be satisfied with bread: but he that followeth vain persons is void of understanding.”

In this proverb, Solomon makes two distinctions: there are doers and followers. Those who do what they can to improve their lives are the tillers. Then, those who follow after others who make empty “vain” promises, like get-rich-quick schemes and scams, follow after them. These empty experts promise miraculous, easy results, but only create followers, not people who become successful.

People who lack understanding fall for these “teachers” who promise everything and anything. They promise you can turn nothing into something with a foolproof, guaranteed plan. Many charlatans were in the ancient world, just like today. The only difference is that they didn’t have an infomercial on television. They would hire actors to create the facade of results, just like many pseudo-experts do today. There have always been those who also misuse God for their own profit, promising things on God’s behalf. Foolish people buy into foolishness.

Many people are looking for a way *to* avoid the hard work of tilling their field, whatever that field is. They want an easy scheme, the pretense of a guarantee. They seek *anything to avoid doing the hard work they can do to improve their fields, finances, or future*. They want to follow a person who *feeds into their desire to avoid doing things the hard but proven way*. They want a product not to be personally productive. They want someone to show them an easier way that feeds into their foolishness. The world has always been full of pseudo-wise men, pretend miracle workers, soothsayers, fortune tellers, snake oil salesmen, etc.

The wise person will stop being a follower and start being a doer. They will do the hot, hard, necessary work they can do when it is time. *They will not go for the get-rich-quick schemes or become dependent on a pseudo-expert to produce some magical, miraculous result*. It is probably a scam if it sounds too good to be true. *Real experts* are already known and established. You can see the results of the experience and expertise. They can provide mentorship, but will not want you to be a blind follower. They will tell you to work hard and be a doer, not a follower. They will tell you the truth, there may be an easier way, but there is no easy way to succeed or achieve!

“TWO WAYS TO CREATE AN INCREASE”

Proverbs 12:14: “A man shall be satisfied with good by the fruit of his mouth: and the recompense of a man’s hands shall be rendered unto him.”

Solomon teaches us that humankind can produce in two ways: our words and our work. What we say will produce “fruit,” and what we do will produce a reward. Some people make a living by what they say, and others by what they do. The most successful people combine the power of the two. For example, a company leader uses his words to motivate and set the business plan into motion, but they must also take action to see that the visions are implemented. They use a combination of the power of words and the power of work.

Some people want to work. But this is limited. *We can only do so much, so our work will limit our rewards. However, if we use the power of words to influence others to work with us or for us, we will increase our output, thus creating more rewards.* The most effective leaders, managers, and coaches harness this power to create more rewards for themselves and others.

It is important to note that our words create fruit, which means we must eat. So, if our words are harmful and toxic, we must eat the bitter fruit they produce. Notice the proverb that a person is satisfied with good because the words are good. Negative words cannot produce positive fruit if we want to produce good fruit. We must take responsibility for our words. They will affect our success and our serenity. Our responsibility is to produce words that produce the fruit we want to eat.

People with decent work ethics are hindered because of their negative words. *They will hurt their productivity because the negative fruit of their words sluggishly fuels them.* They will work decently but not passionately because they are negative in their mindset and words. *They will probably complain or be critical, ultimately holding them back more than their lack of work.*

To get the maximum rewards in life, we need to be positive in our words and productive in our work. Combining the energy of positive words with the effort of work will increase reward and satisfaction.

“GIVING CREATES WEALTH.”

Proverbs 13:7: “There is that maketh himself rich, yet hath nothing: there is that maketh himself poor, yet hath great riches.”

Solomon was the wealthiest man of his time and probably of all time. He knew how to manage money better than anyone in a way that created tremendous wealth. He teaches us that giving away part of our wealth is essential for real success. See that there are two distinct and opposite types of “rich” people in this proverb. There is *the consumer*, and then there is *the contributor*.

The consumer is rich in finances but is poor in good deeds. The contributor is rich in finances but experiences true wealth from giving to those in need. The consumer keeps all their riches for themselves. The contributor shares their net worth to create true worth as a giver. The contributors voluntarily make themselves poorer to enrich the lives of others.

The contributor feels a responsibility to others who may have less, whereas the *consumer feels only a responsibility to keep or hoard what they have.* The contributor feels like they were blessed to be a blessing, whereas the consumer feels like they earned theirs and others should, too. The two attitudes toward their riches are in direct conflict with each other.

Solomon says the contributor in the proverb has “great riches.” The meaning is that the contributor’s wealth will be more than that of the consumers. Why? The contributor activates the spiritual principle of sowing and reaping. So, they are rewarded with the real wealth of making a difference, having significance, and increasing their net worth. Making a difference in the lives of others is a sound financial strategy advocated by the wealthiest man in history. Remember, principles are timeless. What worked for Solomon is still working today!

“THOSE WHO ARE BLESSED SHOULD BLESS OTHERS”

Proverbs 22:9: “He that hath a bountiful eye shall be blessed; for he giveth of his bread to the poor.”

The person who sees themselves as blessed will be a blessing to others. The person with a “bountiful eye” sees that they are blessed to have enough to share with those who have almost nothing. That phrase carries with it that these people are *generous* and *giving*. They have two powerful perspectives. *First, they recognize themselves as blessed. Second, they see or recognize the needs of others.* Both are essential for having a *healthy perspective*, as well as a *happy perspective*.

When we see ourselves as blessed, we are much more likely to be a blessing to others! *When we realize that there is a certain level of abundance in our lives, we can recognize that we can help relieve someone else’s need.* We don’t have to be a billionaire to help others; we simply need to share what we are blessed with. The person with extra food is blessed compared to the person with nothing.

People who don’t recognize themselves as blessed will feel in need so that they will close their eyes to people with more significant needs than themselves. They will feel poor regardless of how blessed they are compared to the less fortunate. This perspective of needs creates greed. It makes people hoard instead of helping! It causes selfishness and contains selflessness.

Generosity begins with *attitude* and then becomes an *action*. In the Old Testament Law, God instituted laws to help the poor and needy. Unfortunately, it is left to the power of choice in the New Testament economy. *Far too many believers are exercising their choice to hoard and not help.* Too many churches finance their organizations without significantly sharing with those in need. Whereas it is not the Church’s primary mission, it is a primary responsibility. The New Testament teaches this principle.

The way to feel blessed and be blessed is to be a blessing to those who are poorer than you. Doing so causes us to be mindful of our prosperity, and it contains our nature to be selfish. It is rewarding to us both mentally and financially. We activate *the principle of sowing and reaping*. We also improve our perspective by realizing we are blessed!

“WHAT IS YOUR ATTITUDE TOWARD THE POOR?”

Proverbs 17:5: “Whoso mocketh the poor reproacheth his Maker: and he that is glad at calamities shall not be unpunished.”

What is your attitude to the poor? What is mine? Is it one of arrogance toward them that thinks they get what they deserve because they are lazy, or some other reason? Is it one that says I got mine? So, they have to get theirs? Or is it thinking it is someone else’s responsibility to help them? We must learn from this proverb that the “poor” have a special connection to God.

God will hold us accountable for *our attitude* and *actions* toward the poor and those in need! Consider the following additional proverb from Solomon. “He that oppresseth the poor reproacheth his Maker: but he that honoureth him hath mercy on the poor” (Proverbs 14:31). We will look later at the principle, but for now, *see the connection* between God and the poor. It is straightforward that this connection comes with divine consequences. It is clear that if we misjudge or mistreat the poor, the consequences will be negative for us. *Conversely, if we treat the poor respectfully and act responsibly toward them, we will be blessed.*

“He that hath pity upon the poor lendeth unto the LORD; and that which he hath given will he pay him again” (Proverbs 19:17). When we help meet the needs of the poor, God sees it as us lending to Him. *He surely will reward and repay us for helping others on His behalf.* Again, we see the *divine connection* and *divine consequence*. In this case, the positive consequences of causing divine blessings to flow our way.

Solomon clearly states that we should be merciful and gracious toward those in need or poverty. *We are not to judge the why of their status but to ask ourselves what we can do to help them.* Judgment belongs to God, who knows the absolute truth of their circumstances. Our responsibility is to help them as agents and ambassadors of God!

“PROMISES FOR THOSE WHO HELP THE POOR”

Proverbs 19:17: “He that hath pity upon the poor lendeth unto the LORD; and that which he hath given will he pay him again.”

Proverbs 28:27: “He that giveth unto the poor shall not lack: but he that hideth his eyes shall have many a curse.”

As established in the last devotion, there is a divine connection between God and the poor. Further, that connection has divine consequences if we respond with compassion and negative consequences if we close our eyes to their needs. How we treat the poor is personal to God. He will bless us if we bless them, or allow a “curse” to be upon us if we ignore or insult them.

We don’t hear much of this in American Christianity. However, when we study the Bible, it is clear that we have a divine responsibility to those in need and that *divine responsibility comes with divine rewards* for those who act as agents of God. The two above proverbs contain divine promises if we act to help those in need. The first proverb says God will reward us financially. The second proverb says God will see that our needs are met, or we will not “lack.”

When the positive consequences are clear, why do so many of us not fulfill this sacred responsibility? The answer is found in the second part of Proverbs 28:7. We hide our eyes. We look away. We close our minds. There is no shortage of people living in poverty. Some created their circumstances, others were born into them, and others still were victims of someone else’s mistakes, but they are in their status regardless. We close our eyes because we don’t want to assume the responsibility to help them, *but* that’s precisely what God wants us to do.

We look away because we feel bad for them, or maybe we feel like we have enough problems to deal with. We may assume the worst about them or assume someone else will do something to help them. The fact is, more people are looking away, walking away, than helping in any way!

“DEFENDING AND PROTECTING THE POOR”

Proverbs 29:14: “The king that faithfully judgeth the poor, his throne shall be established forever.”

Proverbs 31:9: “Open thy mouth, judge righteously, and plead the cause of the poor and needy.”

As Solomon instructs his son, God instructs us to “plead the cause of the poor and needy.” We are not only to *aid them*, but we are to be *their advocate* as well. We are to help them and not act in a way that is hurtful or harmful to them. Further, those in a position of power and prosperity should treat them fairly and respectfully. The Leader is responsible for hearing the cause of the poor and helping the cause of the poor. Solomon saw this as a divine responsibility.

Many people dismiss the “needy” and “poor,” or worse. They take advantage of them through unfair business practices. *They prey on the poor and needy*, as a lion preys on the weak and helpless. “As a roaring lion, and a ranging bear; so is a wicked ruler over the poor people” (Proverbs 28:15). These predatory business and political leaders are happy to use the poor and needy for their profit, consume them, and discard them without compassion. They charge high-interest rates that take advantage of these poor people having few options and are usually desperate. “He that by usury and unjust gain increaseth his substance, he shall gather it for him that will pity the poor” (Proverbs 28:8).

The practice of preying on the poor and needy and taking advantage of their need is something that God despises. It is unfair to the poor from God’s perspective, regardless of the thought process used to justify it. God sees these practices as oppressing or enslaving, abusing people because of their “needy” circumstances. “He that oppresseth the poor to increase his riches, and he that giveth to the rich, shall surely come to want” (Proverbs 22:16). All these practices will end up destroying those already vulnerable and increasing their indebtedness to the point that they are hopeless and helpless. They become further enslaved and disabled from changing their status. God would have us lift people: enable them to break the bonds of poverty. Demonstrate to them the goodness of God through our kindness.

“THE VIRTUE OF HELPING THE POOR”

Proverbs 31:20: “She stretcheth out her hand to the poor; yea, she reacheth forth her hands to the needy.”

Many people are familiar with Proverbs 31, which describes a virtuous woman. One of the virtues the passage describes is helping the poor and needy. The young prince is told to look for this character trait when looking for a wife—someone who is beautiful-hearted, caring, and giving.

What is more attractive than someone generous and compassionate toward those less fortunate than they are? How we treat those who require help or are hurting says a lot about our virtue.

Notice she stretches herself to help the poor. She reaches out to them. If you read the whole chapter, this is a busy mother with *her own business* and *burdens to manage*. However, she isn’t wrapped up in herself and her world. She goes out of her way to make the time to make a difference in the lives of those in need. She doesn’t close her heart or her hand. She reaches out to help with what she can. She is compassionate and contributes to helping relieve the needs of others. “The righteous considereth the cause of the poor: but the wicked regardeth not to know it” (Proverbs 29:7).

If someone were writing an honest character description of you, would they describe you as one who reaches out to the poor? *Would they write about how you stretch yourself to help come to the aid of those in need?* Would they write about your beautiful heart and how it produces generosity to those who cannot benefit you anyway? These are good questions for us all! What virtues are we manifesting? Is it simply about our family and our businesses? Are we like the majority who are so focused on our burdens that we forget others have it worse than we do and need our help?

There is no question that after studying proverbs, God sees beauty in our help and kindness to those in need. *Reaching out to help those who need help is a beautiful act that creates a virtue with priceless value.* In a consumer-driven and self-asserting culture, compassion and contributing to meet the needs of others are rarer today than ever. As said of this woman, those types of people are treasured.

“COMMIT YOUR SUCCESS TO GOD”

Proverbs 16:3: “Commit thy works unto the LORD, and thy thoughts shall be established.”

Some people wrongly perceive this verse when I mention committing our success to God. It doesn't mean some magical, even miraculous process where God waves His Scepter and success appears. It means acknowledging God as the Source of future success and trusting Him to bless our plans. It means asking for and anticipating God to lead us in a way that causes the success we have committed to Him. Then, it means *acting in* that direction.

This process of committing and succeeding is not me making God agree with me, but instead me agreeing with His Direction of how the plan unfolds. *It requires sensitivity to Divine Leadership and Guidance.* It is sometimes the process of allowing Him to close some doors and open others. It requires an open mind to Divine Leadership. Our Commitment should be firm, but our plans should be flexible.

It is our plan conforming to His will. This process is ultimately one of trust. *We cannot say we know each step to take 100 percent, but if we commit our work to Him and trust that He will guide us, we will be successful.* We will be established in what we do, moving with a sense of confidence, even though it may all be new to us. It is committing each step of action to God for His blessing.

Believers need to commit their plans to God. We should commit daily to God, seeking His help, directing our steps, and blessing each step. Whether planning a new endeavor or our day, we should deliberately commit it to God. Then we can trust that He will help us succeed in what we do. *Then* we can walk with an overall sense of security because we trust that we are being blessed, guided, and directed. That allows us to proceed with peace and purpose.

“EVERY BLESSING HAS A BURDEN.”

Proverbs 14:4: “Where no oxen are, the crib is clean: but much increase is by the strength of the ox.”

This proverb may seem odd to some, but it is one of my favorite sayings because it *creates a healthy perspective*. It also reminds me that every blessing has a burden. In this case, there is enough wealth to own an ox to plow with and use for other productive purposes, but the downside is that the ox’s stall needs to be cleaned. That is no pleasant job cleaning up the waste of an Ox, but the *benefits and blessings* of having an Ox and the work it accomplishes *far exceed the burden* of cleaning out the stall.

This proverb reminds me that we can focus on *the negative created by the positive blessings* in our lives or on the blessings and all their benefits. At any moment, we can focus on the minor irritations and unpleasantness of the burdens caused by being blessed with something, or we can focus on the significant benefits of having that blessing as our responsibility. The danger is complaining so much about the negative byproduct of the blessing that we lose the perspective of how blessed we are to have that thing, person, or responsibility in our lives. I know this; if the farmer in this proverb lost his ox and the benefits it brought to his business and life, he would long for the days he had to clean the stalls.

What blessings in your life have you lost perspective on? In other words, what blessings have you started to see as only burdens? Many people get to the point where they only see the negative aspects of their jobs. Or lose the perspective that the job supplies them with many benefits through income, purpose, and esteem. They become so focused on the negatives that they lose consciousness of all the positives. Parents can get so focused on the dirty rooms, carpooling, and other stresses their children create that they forget the positive benefits of being a parent. We can get so focused on paying bills that we lose consciousness of the blessing each bill represents. The mortgage or rent means we are blessed with a place to live that is likely better than most of the world’s population. The electric bills mean we are heated and cooled, our food is stored cold, and so on.

It is so easy to become negative when cleaning our stalls and dealing with temporary discomforts that we become beyond the moment. Our responsibilities start robbing us of the rewards. Our *burdens begin to dominate our thoughts, and we*

become burdened conscious instead of blessing conscious. We lose perspective on how blessed we are and how many benefits come from our blessings. Remember this proverb when you are feeling burdened by your blessings.

“ARE YOU AN ASSET OR LIABILITY?”

Proverbs 14:35: “The king’s favour is toward a wise servant: but his wrath is against him that causeth shame.”

Solomon divided his servants or staff into two categories: those he favored and those who caused him shame or stress. The wise servant was a blessing, and the unwise servant was a burden. In other words, some servants were a true asset, and others were more of a liability, a source of embarrassment to him. He favored the servants or staff who acted wisely and prudently handled his business. He *dis-favored* those who were acting foolish and making messes. He’d have to clean up.

It is an excellent asset for any leader to have people in their organization who can be relied on to act wisely and are productive. These wise people are an asset because *they need little overseeing or managing*. They make things happen that are positive. They create value for their Leader and organization. They are in their place on time and doing what should be done to the best of their ability. They solve problems, not create them. They are dependable and productive. They are a tremendous asset because they don’t rob the Leader of their time correcting them or their mistakes.

The person who is a liability to a leader is the one who requires too much attention from the Leader because it takes the Leader’s focus from other things. If the Leader has to look after the servant or staff member continuously, they become a source of frustration for the Leader. The Leader will disfavor those who cause them frustration of any kind. It could be the lack of dependability or the lack of production. It could be that they are a source of negativity. Either way, they are a liability.

To be an asset, we need to be wise! We need to make wise decisions. Developing a reputation as a wise person will increase our value to those above and below us. People will trust us. They will depend on us. *They will favor us because we create value for them without robbing them of their time.* We solve problems for them without creating problems for them. All this earns their favor so that the blessings will flow from them to us! Even if you are working for yourself, those you do business with will favor you because you are an asset to them!

“WE ARE WHAT WE EAT”

Proverbs 15:14: “The heart of him that hath understanding seeketh knowledge: but the mouth of fools feedeth on foolishness.”

Notice the distinctions Solomon is making in the proverb. The wise person seeks more knowledge because it is what’s in his heart. In other words, he desires knowledge. That is practical knowledge that creates more wisdom or growth. The other side of the proverb is the fool who craves more foolishness. They hunger for gossip, not growth. They want entertainment, not enlightenment. They want to live on a mental diet of junk food. They avoid what is good for what tastes pleasurable to their foolish taste.

Just as our bodies become what we eat, our lives become a product of what we mentally consume. If we feed on dysfunction, we feed our dysfunction. We forfeit enlightenment or growth if we have a mental diet of mostly entertainment. We feed *the negative parts of our mental being* just like junk food feeds our fat cells. We simultaneously weaken and diminish the part of our mental being that allows us to grow, change, and transform. We weaken our will and starve our intellect. *This process so disables us that we can become powerless against minor changes!*

If we continuously feed on foolishness, we will lessen or lose our ability to become productive. Further, *we destroy our ability to be positive*. We starve our spiritual man, weakening our faith and ability to believe. We become spiritually and mentally flabby. Small mental and spiritual exercises become a struggle for us! We develop such a taste for the junk of life that we lose our sense of taste toward good and divine things. This creates an addiction to junk, so we crave it more and more.

If we look at our contemporary culture, we see that most of our population feeds on foolishness. *Entertainment is more accessible and popular than enlightenment or education*. We consume gross amounts of television, movies, and reality shows, including tragic life events that become the masses’ focus. We have video games and an abundance of fictional materials. Listen to the average conversation. It is pure foolishness. Meaning it doesn’t edify in any way. The masses feed themselves from waking up until they go to bed with social media, radio, television, and online items full of foolishness and lacking wisdom. So, it is no wonder depression and other mental illnesses are on the rise! In my opinion, we are mentally and spiritually weaker than ever because we have poor mental diets!

“TWO TRAITS OF A WISE PERSON”

Proverbs 15:32: “He that refuseth instruction despiseth his own soul: but he that heareth reproof getteth understanding.”

Two positive character traits of a wise person are that they will *receive instruction* and *respond to correction*. Notice that the *fool refuses instruction* while the *wise receive instruction*. The wise will also *get* something positive out of correction. The word “heareth” means they *listen with the intent of learning*. It is the exact opposite of the word “refuseth,” which implies close-mindedness.

We must adapt these two traits to separate ourselves from the foolish and develop wisdom. We need to receive instructions from wise people readily. A wise person never refuses a chance to get better or gain wisdom. They have an *open heart* that allows them to be *open-minded*; thus, they are *receptive to instruction* from those wiser than they are. They have such a hunger for growth and betterment that they will even receive things that are hard to swallow. Their goal is to be better and wiser, so they are receptive to wise instruction. Their receptiveness comes from their respect for wisdom. A fool disrespects wisdom, so they don’t see the value in instruction.

We also need to respond positively to correction. No one likes being corrected, but a wise person will *get over the short-term discomfort and get the long-term benefit* from the instruction. We need to be humble when instructed and not act with hostility! Hostility is for the foolish. Humility is for the wise person who sees the correction for what it is, an opportunity to grow and improve! This attitude is essential for continuous growth and gaining wisdom. “The fear of the LORD is the instruction of wisdom; and before honour is humility” (Proverbs 15:33).

Solomon makes a valuable point in our text. When we refuse to learn and grow, we hurt ourselves. He says it is like we hate (despise) ourselves.

We disrespect ourselves more than those trying to help us grow and improve! We are limiting our lives and creating more difficulties for ourselves than necessary. We will prosper if we become humble and wise enough to receive instruction and respond to correction!

“YOU ARE CREATED WITH DIVINE DESIGN”

Proverbs 16:4: “The LORD hath made all things for himself: yea, even the wicked for the day of evil.”

Solomon teaches us that we are ultimately made or created by God. *There is a divine design to everything.* Even evil people are things that somehow fit into purposes and plans. Whereas I may have a hard time understanding things like that because it is beyond my pay grade, I understand that we are part of a divine design. We are not random accidents but specifically designed with divine intent. We aren't here and alive to live without a higher purpose. We are made for God's Glory and by God's Greatness!

That means we are Divine Products. We are masterfully created, and any observation of the human being demonstrates that there is Divine Intelligence displayed in every cell of our anatomy. We are divine products “wonderfully” made! That is a life-changing concept when it is adopted into our thought process. There is something divinely significant and unique about each one of us. We aren't just alive; we are alive with divine energy and abilities. *There is no such thing as ordinary people or an ordinary life!* We were put here with Deliberate Divine Design, so we all are extraordinary as Divine Products!

That means we have Divine Purposes. We have meaningful purposes to God and for God. We are all created, called, and capable of doing great things that fit God's overall purpose. We are gifted with talents, creativity, and willpower to add value to this world and God's kingdom. He created nothing without a purpose or multiple purposes! The only difference is that humankind was given the freedom of choice. We can live with purpose, or we can live purposelessly. Many people never feel a sense of divine purpose because they never see themselves as divine products! When we *accept* that real life becomes extraordinary.

Then we are in a Divine Partnership. We realize we are here not to live aimlessly but with a divine purpose. We are not the end game but part of God's team to fulfill His specific, unique purpose for our lives. That gives us the answers to the questions pondered for centuries, “Why am I alive?” “Why am I here on Earth?” “What is the meaning of life?”

We will form a divine partnership when we believe we are here with a deliberate divine purpose! When we *believe we have a deliberate divine purpose*, we will *deliberately decide on a divine purpose!*

“A KEY TO EXPERIENCING PEACE”

Proverbs 16:7: “When a man’s ways please the LORD, he maketh even his enemies to be at peace with him.”

Solomon teaches us an essential principle for experiencing peace. When we seek to “please” God, we also have relational peace with others. That is partly true because when we deem pleasing God more important than pleasing people, we experience God’s aid in our relationships. It is also true because the attitude of humility is necessary to “please” God and eliminate the conflicts created by pride and ego. The term “please” God means living by His Principles versus living guided by my ego and emotion. Living guided by our ego and emotion will create conflict and undermine peace within and without.

When we live to please people, we think we are doing so to maintain or create peace, but it has the opposite effect on us. Why? we will never be able to please everyone with everything. If you notice people pleasers, even though they intend to maintain or create peace, they are the most disturbed among us. They naturally fail at the positive intent, so they feel *guilty* and *have a sense of failure*. They live under tremendous pressure, trying to keep the peace with everyone. In attempting to please everyone, they often prioritize pleasing people over pleasing God. They forfeit the only real source of peace that comes from God.

The better way of living is learning from Solomon, a king, when people went to war over any and everything. Yet, He maintained peace with those hostile toward him and even prospered financially because of living by this principle. He had unprecedented peace and prosperity because He made pleasing God or living by Divine Principles more important than pleasing the people around him.

When we live guided and guarded by Divine Principles, we will experience peace with others because we aren’t impulsive or irrational. We have *stability* and *serenity* because we make decisions and take actions filtered through this question, “Will this please God?” When we ask this simple question, it *rules out emotional decisions* and *reins in our* ego. Doing this will create more peace in our lives than ever before.

“THE TRUST FACTOR”

Proverbs 16:33: “The lot is cast into the lap; but the whole disposing thereof is of the LORD.”

My first inclination is usually to question this proverb. Then I step back and realize the author is Solomon, the wisest man who has lived, and was divinely inspired. The proverb is not teaching that God is involved with games of chance, but is the Master of Chance. It was common when people in this culture were trying to make a decision that they could cast lots. They would accept as God’s will whatever was chosen in this manner. They would trust that this is what was supposed to happen. Solomon points out that God ultimately ordered the choice even in what seemed like random events. They would trust that God had ordained the choice or circumstance and move on.

That is a powerful principle. When we learn to trust that God is working in what seems like random events of chance, this mentality brings us a sense of order. It gives order to things that could create chaos and confusion. Trusting that God is working His plan and purpose in events and circumstances is the better choice. It gives us a *powerful perspective* and a *belief that empowers us* to believe that God is working on our behalf and for our benefit, even when we can’t see the outcome yet. It allows us to trust beyond the limitations of the present perspective.

This whole concept is what I call the Trust Factor. It is *choosing* to trust that God is and will work on things for our benefit and His honor, even when we don’t understand. It is essential when we don’t understand. We are finite beings, so we are very limited by our ability to understand the bigger picture and perspective. We are clouded by our emotions and hindered by our lack of foresight. We interpret things based on our feelings, which is usually the worst time to evaluate any event or circumstance.

Further, the goal of understanding things will be an endless loop. It is an exercise in futility that leads to frustration, anger, or anxiety. The better method of living is to trust that there is a benefit. God will work it out for our good and move on.

Our goal in any event or circumstance should be peace, not understanding. When we don’t know, we trust and move on! Or we can keep rolling the dice, wondering each time if this is God’s will or the right thing to do. We can be paralyzed

by the things that happen by chance or at peace about events and circumstances. We can buy into the accident mentality, a thought process that will cause us to become disempowered, or trust in becoming empowered. We can add the Trust Factor to any event or circumstance and create peace and a positive perspective.

“TEACHING YOURSELF TO TALK”

Proverbs 16:23: “The heart of the wise teacheth his mouth, and addeth learning to his lips.”

Most people are blessed with and born with the ability to talk, but that doesn't mean they know how to talk. Solomon said what distinguishes the wise from the rest of the population is that they teach themselves how to talk. They add to their ability to speak with knowledge of how to speak. They add value to their words by adding learning to their minds. They have something worth saying and know how to say it effectively and efficiently.

Wise people want to do everything wisely, and communication is no different. They learn how to talk positively and productively. They make the most of their blessed ability and turn it into a skill. They enhance their worth by increasing the value of their communication skills. Solomon is teaching us that we must take responsibility to become better communicators.

How important is being an excellent communicator to you? How much time have you invested in teaching yourself to communicate with power? How often have you learned from your communication mistakes and gained the wisdom not to talk that way again? Most people make the same mistakes habitually when talking. They never learn or grow from their mistakes. Wise people will teach themselves how to talk positively and purposefully. They will gain more and more skills as communicators. *They will feed their minds to add value to what they say.* That will help them have credibility and confidence, essential for being a productive communicator!

The first step to being a better communicator is to realize that we must take responsibility to teach ourselves to become wiser communicators. It will not just happen. We must decide to become skilled; any skill takes time and effort to develop. Then the next step is to begin to learn from the way we are communicating now. *We need the wisdom to notice if what we say positively or negatively affects us.* We have to become *focused on the effect of our words on the hearer*, not just talking at people. *As we become aware of the results of what we are saying, we can correct what we say and how we say it to get a more productive result.* Finally, we must continuously add learning, knowledge, and skill to our lips. The more knowledge and skills we have, the more options we will have to use as communicators.

“ARE YOU A SPREADER OR A STOPPER?”

Proverbs 16:22-28: “An ungodly man diggeth up evil: and in his lips there is as a burning fire. A froward man soweth strife: and a whisperer separateth chief friends.”

Solomon is almost harsh in describing people who dig up dirt and those who love to cause problems by talking about people. He says they are “ungodly” and “forward,” meaning they are not acting anything like God and are perverse. They are perverse because they love sowing strife and causing trouble for others by talking about them. They destroy their friendships because they share people’s faults and secrets with others. They do it cowardly by whispering behind the person’s back. They love to disclose any negative information. They get pleasure in talking about people’s faults and failures without regard to the fact that it is hurtful and harmful.

Some people love to start fires with their mouths. It is incredible how fast negative news can spread. It spreads from foolish person to foolish person, increasing in size. There is no end to the people who will help the fire grow in intensity. The matter usually gets blown up to a new reality. People love to share negative information with or without factual substance. That is perverseness, whether it is realized or not. It is dysfunctional that we love the negative, hurtful, and harmful!

It is also perverse how many “spiritual” people like to keep the fire going and dig up dirt on everyone. *They disguise it as telling the truth.* In reality, they are fueling the fire that is hurting someone else! They are also not acting in love. Further, they aren’t edifying but helping to tear down another person. “Hatred stirreth up strifes: but love covereth all sins” (Proverbs 10:12). “He that covereth a transgression seeketh love; but he that repeateth a matter separateth very friends” (Proverbs 17:9). We are supposed to keep people’s sins contained, not share them. We are to stop the fire from spreading, not help it spread! The Christian community is as guilty as anyone else regarding spreading negative news. Suppose we had the same energy in sharing the Good News as the bad news. we would be difference-makers! Let us be stoppers, not spreaders of negative news about others!

“PRODUCTION OVER POSITION”

Proverbs 17:2: “A wise servant shall have rule over a son that causeth shame, and shall have part of the inheritance among the brethren.”

Solomon had many people underneath him. His sons and servants were given responsibilities, so he has a unique perspective on this proverb. He realized that having a title didn’t translate into productivity or wise business management. In other words, having a position didn’t mean a person or a prince would be productive. *He favored a servant who could act wisely over a son who acted foolishly.* Whether he was thinking about a personal experience or a contemporary one, the principle is valuable for us today.

A title or position doesn’t mean the person will have long-term success. People desire a position, but the actual asset to the employer or leader is the productive person. They handle their delegated responsibilities with wisdom. They are producers! The producers will always rise to the top of any organization. Solomon says a good servant will be treated like a son, eventually sharing the wealth. In fact, in time, they will have authority over the person with a title who is lazy or acting foolishly.

The advice we glean from this proverb is *simple but very significant*. The producers will overtake those who rest comfortably in their positions. The person at the very top will prefer a productive employee over a mediocre manager. Production will secure long-term success without a position. So, *our focus in any area of life should be on producing positive results*, not seeking position and promotion. If we are producers, the position, promotions, and prosperity will come to us in time!

Are you considered a producer by those above you? Are you acting wisely and becoming an asset to those above you, or are you causing trouble? Are you focusing on getting results or getting rewards? Get results. and the reward will come! Produce for the person in the position, and you will have the position before long!

Note: Being a producer will make the insecure person in a position above you feel threatened, but be a producer anyway. Do it *quietly*, and the person at the top will see even if there is jealousy.

“BAD BEHAVIOR CREATES BAD NEWS.”

Proverbs 17:11: “An evil man seeketh only rebellion: therefore a cruel messenger shall be sent against him.”

Solomon clearly states in this proverb that the man in the illustration receives terrible news because of his bad behavior. The message may take a while to reach him, but it will be a consequence of his behavior. The man’s rebellious attitude and actions have caused someone to act against him.

That reminds me of an acquaintance who asked rhetorically, “Why does all this bad stuff keep happening to me?” Referring to bad letters, personal drama, and the instability created by their behavior. They didn’t see a habitual correlation between their rebellious, selfish attitude and the actions being taken toward them. If one shows up for work habitually late and with a bad attitude, they shouldn’t be surprised when they get a termination notice. Yet, many are surprised and blame the mean boss, not their rebellious behavior, as the cause.

The wise person will not blame the messenger but look at their attitudes and actions. The foolish usually become more rebellious, while the wise will not focus on the messenger but on the cause of the message. The foolish person rants against the messenger and the offended party. They act like they are the victims when they are the victimizers. They will deny that their bad behavior has called for the bad news.

The opposite of the proverb is true. If we want to create good news, we must cause it with good behavior. The person excelling at their job will likely get a message that they are being promoted. The person treating others with kindness, appreciation, and respect will likely get good news that someone is doing something good for them. So, the obvious lesson is that we want to sow good behavior to reap eventual good news. Creating a harvest of good news may take a while, but it will come our way!

What is your behavior creating right now? If you have received bad news, ask yourself if you did anything to cause *it*. If so, learn from it!

“COMMITTED FRIENDS OR CONVENIENT FRIENDS”

Proverbs 17:17: “A friend loveth at all times, and a brother is born for adversity.”

Solomon teaches that a true friend is like a brother. They are committed to the relationship no matter what, especially when adversity or difficulty arises. A true friend stays with us when everyone else is running away. *There are convenient friends and committed friends. The difference is in how they react when you are facing adversity.*

Convenient friends are there *until something terrible happens*, and a committed friend is there *even though something wrong has happened*. I’ve observed that convenient type friends run to us initially because they are in the friendship for self-promoting reasons. *They feel important from consoling and being involved in the initial drama.* But after some time, the adversity is still there, and it requires real effort or sacrifice, they will be out of the picture. The quick “I’m here for you” or “Is there anything I can do?” is easy. Start trying to withdraw something from those promises, and you will see them disappear.

A committed friend is there regardless, like a brother. They draw closer when you are at your weakest so they can support you with whatever means they have. They are willing to see the uglier side of you, but remind you of the beauty they know in you. They *console* but also *confront* all with the foundational fact that they are your friend, no matter what. They will not debase their integrity, but won’t devalue your friendship. They will remind you of the better you all while loving, the baser you!

Circumstances will not destroy true friendships. They may change the dynamic, but not the friend’s determination. *What destroys convenient friendships will deepen committed friendships.* That may happen over time, but commitment is developed by adversity and sacrifice. That is a biblical principle modeled by Jesus!

Further, look at how he treated Peter even after Peter denied him when He needed Peter the most. He remained committed to Peter’s better self even when it was evident at the moment! In the process, Jesus salvaged a man and his potential! That’s commitment!

“YOUR FRIENDS: HELPING OR HINDERING?”

Proverbs 27:17: “Iron sharpeneth iron; so a man sharpeneth the countenance of his friend.”

Solomon reveals a *key to our success* and *well-being* in this proverb. The key is to have friends who make us better. He says a good friend will sharpen you, so the contrast is a bad friend dulls you. One makes you better as a person and in your purpose, while the other makes you worse and hinders your purpose.

The sharpening process makes something like a sword or a knife more effective. A good friend helps us be more effective in our lives. Wise people like Solomon know that the people who are our friends influence us. They help us or hinder us in what we were designed and assigned to do. Once we know that truth, we must choose friendships with the utmost *discretion* and *discernment*!

Everyone we are involved with in a relationship either dulls or sharpens us. The exact process does both, and the dynamic is created by similar things being applied together. Friction sharpens one piece of iron and dulls another. So, people who rub us in a nonproductive way, like with hostility or foolishness, will dull us and make us less effective. They can grind us down to the point where we cannot fulfill our purpose! But for the most part, the dull friendships make us less sharp, so we must work harder. We have to work at being happy and positive. We have to work harder to be productive. Everything is more challenging because they dull us until we are less effective, which means more effort is needed to do everything.

We want to find people who know how to sharpen us. They know how to push our buttons in a positive way. They get us. These people make us better and more effective! They make life easier for us because they know how to use the relationship dynamic to *shape* and *sharpen* us. *They positively use friction*. They may confront or challenge, but it is done so with care. We need to value these people because they create value for us by sharpening us so we can be more effective!

The pointed question now is: Are your friends helping or hindering you?

“A GOOD FRIEND MAKES LIFE SWEETER.”

Proverbs 27:9: “Ointment and perfume rejoice the heart: so doth the sweetness of a man’s friend by hearty counsel.”

A true friend speaks to us from the heart (“hearty counsel”), whereas a casual friend speaks to us from their head. The difference is in the “sweetness” and how it impacts our minds and mood. Just as ointment and perfume change the atmosphere, a true friend’s counsel will change our attitude.

Not everyone can positively affect our attitude. Most people we associate with have an adverse effect. Even when they try to be positive, they make us feel worse. That happens for various reasons. First, they may not be divinely designed for you. Ever noticed what smells appealing to one person doesn’t appeal to another? It may even be appalling to them. We may keep friends who don’t speak our language or get us, but we shouldn’t turn to them for comfort or counsel. *They will only end up making us feel worse!*

Another reason people who may mean to help hurt us is not about us, but them. They have stinky attitudes and sour beliefs. We cannot get sweet advice from a sour person. A negative person cannot positively influence us. Doubters will not be capable of building our faith. People who hate their lives will make us think our lives stink. They may say the right cliché, but because their attitude is sour, they cannot help us!

God designs us to respond to “hearty counsel,” so we need to find someone to help make us feel better. We are not to be codependent on this person, but we should know when to boost *our attitude*. They fit us like the right fragrance for our senses fits us. It just works. It is not always what is said that impacts us, but the attitude that comes from it. It helps and heals. It calms, comforts, and creates confidence to face the challenge or handle the change. It enhances our attitude and empowers us to believe, not doubt.

You are probably right if you think you don’t have that kind of friend in your life. If you did, you would know it! So, it is time to realize that you will never find that person by spending all your time around the current people in your life. They are repelling that type of person because of their sour, stinky attitudes. Move away from them to make room for a true friend who positively influences you!

“LOOSE LIPS SINK FRIENDSHIPS”

Proverbs 16:28: “A froward man soweth strife: and a whisperer separateth chief friends.”

Proverbs 17:9: “He that covereth a transgression seeketh love; but he that repeateth a matter separateth very friends.”

Solomon teaches that friendships are destroyed by gossip, breaking of confidence, and repeating things about our friends. *In other words, loose lips will sink any friendship.* It destroys the very foundation of any friendship, the foundation of trust. It will damage the friendship and/or relationship in a way that will never recover from. It may stay afloat but never have the same power and potential.

We, as Believers, should learn that we have a responsibility to keep our friends’ confidence and privacy. *We should see ourselves as confidants and counselors, requiring us to keep private matters private.* The time for openness is when we privately give our advice or counsel to our friends. We lay it on the line there, but then draw the line once we leave their presence.

We should also realize that if we are friends with people who talk to us about other people, we can count on them to talk about us to others. The principle is that if they talk to you about others, they will talk to others about you! *These people are not trustworthy.* They will eventually break your confidence. It is just a matter of time! We are creatures of habit, so if they gossip and reveal private truths, they will do it to you! You may think you are an exception, but it is a matter of time before they give in to the temptation. As the friendship is sinking, you will think, “I knew better.”

It is better to separate from these potentially destructive friendships by choice and not out of consequence. It is wiser to avoid the potential danger now than to deal with the damage in the future. Yes, it may hurt their feelings and feel awkward, but it is *preventative maintenance for your reputation.* It is like removing a potential health problem before it has the chance to do damage. It will take some recovery time, but it will be easier to recover from that than from the damage they will eventually cause! Separate by choice or consequence. Which is the wisest?

“DEVELOPING DISCERNMENT IN FRIENDSHIPS”

Proverbs 22:24: “Make no friendship with an angry man; and with a furious man thou shalt not go.”

Solomon teaches that part of being wise is learning to discern who we are friends with and the company we keep. We should be friendly with everyone. We shouldn't be friends with everyone. Here he teaches us to avoid friendships or going places with people who are hot-tempered or angry. Why? Their volatility will get them and those with them in trouble. Attitudes are contagious, so a wise person will avoid emotional friendships with unstable people. We want to avoid being around people who are toxic emotionally. Their attitudes will infect us, or their actions will affect us.

That is a complex principle for many people to get. We make excuses for our friends and justify their negativity to ourselves. *It is an area of weakness for most people. It is hindering us even if it hasn't hurt us yet.* We must develop discernment by honestly looking at each of our friendships as a potential liability or a positive asset. Each friendship will be dominant in one category or the other, a potential liability or positive asset. Now, because these people will not be perfect, we will see the dominant quality if we look at each friendship from the perspective of wisdom and not emotion.

Once we develop discernment in the area of friendship, we can develop discipline in the area of friendships. We learn not to “go” with everyone. We limit the relationship to casual and do not invest time with them by going with them. That protects us from being contaminated by their negative emotion. It also protects us from being caught up in their harmful actions and the drama they create. These people will rob us of our peace. Their drama will drain us and distract us from being our best. So, we must develop the discipline to keep from developing friendships with negative people! Again, we are friendly, but don't spend time with them in the context of being friends. We don't invest real time and energy into those types of friendships.

In short, we have to learn to say “no” and not “go.” That isn't always easy, but it will get easier as we focus on living a better life. When we are determined to eliminate as much potential liability as possible, we will be more comfortable saying “no.” When we understand we are to protect ourselves, we are responsible. We will develop more power to say “no” and choose not to “go” with negative people.

“TALK LESS SAY MORE”

Proverbs 17:27-28: “He that hath knowledge spareth his words: and a man of understanding is of an excellent spirit. Even a fool, when he holdeth his peace, is counted wise: and he that shutteth his lips is esteemed a man of understanding.”

Solomon teaches us that wise people are known for the quality of their words, not quantity. When we are people of actual knowledge and understanding, *we talk less but say more because we speak with purpose and precision*. Wise people don’t talk to get attention. They talk with intention. The foolish person talks to talk. It is a form of attention-seeking to them. They like being perceived as a source of entertainment. Conversely, the wise person desires to be a source of enlightenment or encouragement.

The wise person usually doesn’t seek out opportunities to talk. They are sought out. They aren’t in the habit of wasting their wisdom on people who want to talk. *Their understanding has taught them that most people want to talk, not listen*. They realize most people want entertainment, not enlightenment! So, they spare their words. They look for good ground to sow in. They don’t throw around words in meaningless conversations because they know their words have value.

Many people talk out of boredom. They have to be talking. It is an addiction. Watch people. The first thing they do is grab their phones and talk nonstop. I observed that 90% of their conversation is repetitive and without actual purpose. It is full of drama, complaining, and nonproductive chatter. Solomon sees that as a symptom of their foolishness and lack of understanding.

Wise people are comfortable with the silence of thought. They spare their words and reflect on what is happening, who is speaking, and whether this conversation is worthwhile. More often than not, they just shut up. They hold back from talking more often than they talk. They filter with their understanding when they speak and what they say. That allows them to speak less and say more. It increases the quality of their words and conversations while decreasing the number of conversations. Like anything, the less there is of it, the more valuable it becomes. *So, let’s talk less and say more!*

“WASTING TIME AND WORDS”

Proverbs 18:2: “A fool hath no delight in understanding, but that his heart may discover itself.”

Solomon knew that even all his wisdom couldn't reach some people. Talking to these types of people is a waste of our time and our words. These foolish people do not want to gain “understanding” but to tell you what they think. They talk to hear themselves talk. That is their goal: to let you know how they feel. They have no desire to understand or gain insight. They are content with just expressing their opinions.

As wise people, we must discern when we engage people who only want to express themselves. We cannot get through to them because they aren't in a mental state to gain understanding. They will usually repeat the phrase “I know” and the word “but” very often. Then they will continue with whatever they are saying. They hear, but they do not listen. If we let them rant long enough, they will feel a sense of accomplishment from their rant and tell us we've helped them, only to go right back to the same problems, pitfalls, and perceptions. We've wasted our time and words.

We can waste so much time with people without a desire for growth and understanding. We may do it as a challenge or a desire to help, but ultimately, we cannot teach people full of themselves. There must be a willingness to listen and learn. There must be a desire for understanding. There must be an open mind, not one full of its own opinions. The irony is that these types of people have no desire for understanding and will tell us we don't understand! We don't understand their life, problems, perspective, pain, and past.

It is not cold when we *stop wasting time and words with people close to growth. It simply means realizing that while wasting all that time and effort with them, we are not investing in people who will benefit from our time and words of wisdom.* Follow Solomon's advice and stop wasting what will bless and benefit someone else!

“CONFLICT AND CONTENTION”

Proverbs 18:6: “A fool’s lips enter into contention, and his mouth calleth for strokes.”

Solomon advises that some people create contention and conflict with how they talk. He has taught before that words create emotion. In this case, the negative words from a “fool’s lips” stimulate contention, which may lead to physical conflict. That is a reminder that words stimulate a physical response in the hearer, not a positive one in this example, but the principle is there.

Have you ever noticed how some people attract conflict and negativity? The truth is, they create it more than they attract it. They talk to people in a way that stimulates a negative response. Most of these types of people are oblivious to the fact that they are the cause of their chronic conflict and contention! They see others as the source of their problems.

However, it is important to realize that we all can create contention and conflict with our words. Words are a byproduct of our mental state and attitude! So, it’s not just the words, *but how they are said*, that stimulates negative emotion. It is as much of what we are emoting when we are speaking that stimulates something in the hearer. We have all had the experience of having a bad day. We are in a negative state, and the whole day is full of contentious conversations. We think, “Why is everyone taking what I say wrong?” We also take what is said to us negatively; it is a day full of conflicts and contentions. At that point, the best thing to do is to stop and analyze ourselves. If we are experiencing an unusual amount of conflict and contention with various people, we are most likely stimulating it.

The foolish person continuously stimulates conflict with others without seeing themselves as at least partly responsible. The wise person will stop and reflect on their behavior. If you are talking with a foolish person, the best thing is to walk away or deal with someone else who doesn’t stimulate you negatively. The longer you talk to someone who stimulates you, the more negativity they stimulate. That is dangerous because you can then act and speak foolishly. Avoid escalation by refusing to deal with these types of people.

“THE WAY WE TALK COULD BE THE PROBLEM”

Proverbs 18:7: “A fool’s mouth is his destruction, and his lips are the snare of his soul.”

Solomon discloses a powerful secret that wise people know and “fools” don’t: How we talk has a powerful effect on our lives! He summarizes that some people are self-destructive because of the way they talk. The way they use their mouth leads to destruction. Their lips keep them trapped in a negative lie. Now, we can *argue with Solomon’s lesson* or *accept it and learn a valuable lesson*.

When people talk about the changes they will make, you seldom hear someone say, “I need to change the way I talk.” Yet, the way we talk could be the problem. It certainly is part of the problem, so it has to be part of the solution for living a productive life and stopping self-destruction. It must be part of the solution for stopping self-defeating and self-sabotaging behavior! If the way we talk to others and our self-talk doesn’t change, we won’t retain any positive changes we attempt to make.

As we have learned throughout the book of Proverbs, *words stimulate emotion*. Words impact our perspective as well. If I say, “Life is so hard,” it will be my perception of life. Or if I say, “change is hard,” it will create a “snare” that will trap me into believing it. What if I said, “God is so good to me. Good things happen for me all the time.”? Would that *stimulate a positive expectation*? Of course, it would! What if I said, “It hasn’t happened yet, but it will?” Would that encourage my faith and relieve my doubts? Yes, it would!

To transform our lives, we have to change how we talk. *We need to stop talking ourselves into defeat and doubt!* If our lips create snares, then the opposite is true as well. The way we talk can set us free from bondage, too! If our mouth can be a destructive force, it can also be a constructive force. We can use it to build our faith instead of battling our faith. We can use how we talk to construct a better life for ourselves and build up those around us!

Change the way you talk and change the way you live!

“FACT FINDING BEFORE FAULT FINDING”

Proverbs 18:13: “He that answereth a matter before he heareth it, it is folly and shame unto him.”

Proverbs 18:17: “He that is first in his own cause seemeth just; but his neighbour cometh and searcheth him.”

Solomon acted as Judge and King, so people often came to him to get him to take their side in matters. He knew it was essential to hear all the facts to make a wise decision. Also, he knew that every story had more than one side. The first person to make their case always seems right until the other party comes (“neighbor”) and tells their side. The principle is never to judge until you know all the facts!

Whether personal or professional, we should never conclude or make judgments until we know all the facts. If we don't know the facts from all the parties involved, we need to withhold making any judgments. Indeed, *we need to fact-find before we find fault* or assign blame. Often, people hear one side of a matter and find fault, usually with the person not present. That is unwise and wrong toward the other person or parties.

Years of counseling and helping in conflict resolution have taught me two clear lessons. First, we all have a bias toward our cause. Second, there is always more to the story or matter than being disclosed. Often, people will become deceptive when telling you their side. Whether this is deliberate or not, they will tell partial truths, leave out relevant information, and exaggerate. Generally, they frame the matter to make it look how they want it to. Friends will be biased toward their friends. It is hard to know the truth, so we should seldom conclude about people and incidents!

Solomon's wisdom and my own experience have taught me to seldom actually find fault. Facts are withheld, distorted, and manipulated *to* mislead us as the Judger. *Time is the best revealer of reality, so we should use time and not emotions to make wise judgments.* If time isn't available to us and we are decision-makers, assume both parties are at fault. Then at least, we can be fair in the matter.

“STRONG SPIRIT-STRONG BODY”

Proverbs 18:14: “The spirit of a man will sustain his infirmity; but a wounded spirit who can bear?”

Two thousand three hundred years ago, Solomon, under divine influence, realized there was a mind-connection. Before it was accepted as a scientific fact, he knew that if the spirit is healthy and strong, it will overcome infirmities. He recognized that if the spirit is weak or wounded, it causes health decay and destroys happiness.

An important thing we can do for our health and happiness is to focus on keeping our spirit or inner man strong. It happens by developing and strengthening our will. When the will is weak, it makes the person more susceptible to illness, both physically and mentally. The will is strengthened when we act despite feelings and emotions! We use the will to do what we decide, not what we feel like doing. *When we give in to our feelings, negative emotions, or physical weakness, we weaken our will*, thereby increasing the power of the weakness. We can strengthen the spirit by forcing it to be strong through the power of choice. God created us with this unique ability.

We feed our spirit with positive thinking and positive information. The opposite is also true. *Negative thoughts weaken our spirit and induce physical and mental illness!* Remember, this isn't the Spirit of the New Testament that indwells this spirit or inner man that we all have. It is reflected in our attitude, personality, and body language. You can see and sense when someone's spirit is wounded. It shows on their face, body language, and attitude. They are weak and wounded in the spirit.

Some people have an incident that wounds their spirit. They are rejected, abused, or get bad news, but there is an *external trigger*. However, continuous thinking about the trigger keeps them from healing on the inside. When the inside is sick and wounded, it also affects everything on the outside. Having that knowledge should make us see the necessity of having a healthy spirit. *We must exercise our willpower* to overcome and not give in to our weaknesses! *We must feed our spirit* with positive thoughts and information! We, as believers, need to feed our spirit with the Inspired!

“OVERCOMING OFFENDING”

Proverbs 18:19: “A brother offended is harder to be won than a strong city: and their contentions are like the bars of a castle.”

The wiser we become, the more we see the value of preventative living. Here, Solomon reminds us that *avoiding offending or hurting someone is easier than trying to repair the relationship*. Wise people will learn that we can waste a tremendous amount of time, energy, and effort trying to overcome the damage we can cause by offending people.

Solomon illustrates what happens to people when we offend or hurt them in the text. He says they put up walls and bars like the fortification of a castle. They retreat inside because they feel that another attack is imminent. They essentially go into defense mode, protecting their selves. They put up a barrier between them and us. Intimacy is lost, and the bridge of trust is drawn in. It will take significant effort and time to overcome the “contentions.”

The wisest thing for us to do is to try to prevent the problem or offense in the first place. It is better to keep things from happening than to try to win a “brother” back. Assuming this is a person of some importance to us, we will have to work on overcoming an offense, which means our focus and energy are taken away from other things. If you have ever been in this position, you know it is distracting and draining. It is mentally and emotionally draining. We think about the situation constantly, which keeps us from thinking about other important things that need our attention.

If we can't prevent an offense or it has already occurred, we have to understand that the bridge of trust has been withdrawn, and the intimacy is lost, at least temporarily. We cannot expect the relationship dynamic to be the same! We can only persevere in our desire for reconciliation until they lower their defenses. Show up outside the walls daily and ask permission to come in. One day, different for each person and offense, the defenses will be lowered, and the bridge will be extended for you to return. Go in humbly and know it will not be the same for a while.

“DISCOVER YOUR GIFTEDNESS”

Proverbs 18:16: “A man’s gift maketh room for him, and bringeth him before great men.”

This verse has been interpreted in two ways. One is that bringing a gift to an important person will gain them an audience. I see some validity and value in that interpretation. However, I believe it means that our giftedness will open doors for us. It has a similar meaning because we bring something of value, our giftedness. That enables us to be helpful to successful people.

Everyone has a gift to offer! Some have never *discovered* or *developed* it, but we all are gifted in at least one area. The key is finding our unique giftedness and creating value for others. It didn’t matter the area of giftedness. If they were *the best*, they would get an audience and the opportunity to work for King Solomon. The best tailor, horse trainer, carpenter, or musician, their gift opened doors for them. The same holds true today. Wise and successful people are collectors of talents and giftedness. They want the best at anything available to them.

Many people *focus on the areas where they are not gifted, when their time would be better spent* discovering and developing what they are gifted at. You have a gift that is the key to your promotion and prosperity. It is the key to opening doors of opportunity for you! God has given you something that is your gift to someone or many people. You are the answer to someone’s problem. Your gift makes room for you! It gives you space in your life or business.

What is your giftedness? Many people *never discover it*, much less develop it, because we are too busy trying to be like everyone else. We focus on duplicating others and what they do, which dilutes our giftedness. By not developing our giftedness, we become lesser copies of someone else than our best. Successful people don’t want cheap imitations of something else or someone else. They want the unique original. They want you. They want you to be who God intended, not what He planned for someone else’s life. Discover and develop your giftedness, and doors will open for you!

“THE VALUE OF INTEGRITY”

Proverbs 19:1: “Better is the poor that walketh in his integrity, than he that is perverse in his lips, and is a fool.”

Solomon is not saying that being poor means one has integrity, but that a poor person with integrity is better off than a dishonest and deceptive person. The proverb defines integrity as when one’s walk is congruent with one’s talk. It is not just using our lips to say whatever is convenient, but *living with conviction in what we say*.

A person with integrity will be consistent in their behavior. *They are steadfast in their beliefs, so their behavior is steady and stable*. They aren’t given easily to outside influences because they have core convictions that guide their behavior. Their sense of conviction allows them to live from the inside out. They aren’t given to quick change or haphazard behavior.

The consistency brought about by integrity allows the person of integrity to be perceived as trustworthy. Why? It is because their behavior will back up their word. Further, their consistency of character means they don’t commit lightly or frivolously. They mean what they say and say what they mean. That gives weight or gravitas to what they say and do. That has tremendous value in any personal or business relationship.

Our focus should be on being individuals with integrity. This means we must be cautious in what we say and espouse to believe because we want our actions to be congruent with what we say. Maybe we should talk less and express our beliefs less until we can be congruent and consistent in these areas. Then our walk will display our integrity and not undermine it. It would be helpful for us all to look for areas where we lack integrity and prayerfully seek to gain integrity in these areas!

Integrity equals influence! We must *gain integrity before* we seek to influence. That is essential for all leaders, including parents.

“TWO WAYS TO SURELY FAIL”

Proverbs 19:2: “Also, that the soul be without knowledge, it is not good; and he that hasteth with his feet sinneth.”

When a man as wise as Solomon tells us something isn’t good, we must take his advice seriously. Further, when he tells us that a particular thing will cause us to make a mistake (“sinneth”), we need to remember the lesson permanently. He is telling us what to do by telling us what not to do!

The first lesson is that desiring something isn’t enough to ensure success. The word “soul” means to desire something deeply on the inside. Desire gives birth to dreams, goals, and accomplishments, but it will not keep them alive. *Knowledge keeps them alive and ensures success.* For example, the desire to get wealth may create the reality of wealth, but it will lead to failure and loss if one doesn’t know how to retain and manage wealth. Just think of how many lottery winners, athletes, and musicians *get their desire* for riches *only to lose them*. Many end up further in debt than ever before.

This proverb is lived out around us all the time. People desire relationships but never know how to be in a relationship successfully, so they fail. Many people start a business out of a desire but don’t develop the knowledge needed to operate a business and lead people, so they fail. People go on a diet and lose weight, but fail to learn how to eat healthy long term, so they fail without that knowledge. So many well-meaning people start ministries out of passion and desire, only to stop or quit them. Why? Very often, it is because they didn’t grow in the knowledge of leading people or managing the business.

Desire without knowledge will lead to failure. Desire is where we start, not where we stop. Desire must be balanced with knowing how to protect what it creates. *Desire is born while knowledge is a parent!* So, a wise person will gain as much knowledge as possible before the desire is born. Whatever success you desire, read and research as much as possible about it. Become a student of how others have achieved it, or something similar, successfully and long-term. That will keep your desire from turning into a failure!

“TWO WAYS TO SURELY FAIL 2”

Proverbs 19:2: “Also, that the soul be without knowledge, it is not good; and he that hasteth with his feet sinneth.”

Solomon tells us *not to* be hasty in our decisions and actions. He is clear that if we are hasty, we will make mistakes! Being hasty and giving in to impulsive decisions is a sure way to create mass failure in our lives and business. People wanting to live a lifestyle of wisdom will do themselves an excellent service by heeding Solomon’s advice seriously.

It is a well-known sales tactic to exploit people’s natural inclination to act impulsively. Salespeople do this by selling the “benefits” of something and then pressuring the victim to decide *right now*. They may even offer an incentive to entice a hasty decision. They don’t care about the long-term consequences to the victim’s budget. The wise person will see through that tactic and remember this principle. If it’s a hurried decision, it will usually be a mistake.

The wise person will learn to associate making mistakes with rash or rushed decisions. They will remember this principle when making any decision. If rushed and rash, it will most likely be a long-term mistake. If it’s immediate and emotional, it will most likely cause long-term pain. Of course, there are exceptions, but they are just exceptions and are usually clearly logical and divinely appointed.

Wise people constantly ask themselves, “What is the rush?” “Why am I feeling pressure to hurry?” Analyze any decision by asking yourself, “Is this an impulsive or emotional decision?” Most things that are bad for us, or people who want to take advantage of us, will try to make you rush to decide! That should always cause us to be cautious.

Two old expressions would be helpful to remember: “Haste makes waste” and “Measure twice, cut once.” We are often hurried and will waste a lot of time, money, or emotion recovering from that decision. *Hasteful equals wasteful!* Then it is easier to pause and recheck measurements than to start all over because we were in a hurry.

“PICK YOUR BATTLES”

Proverbs 19:11: “The discretion of a man deferreth his anger; and it is his glory to pass over a transgression.”

Solomon teaches that wise people should learn to pick their battles. We should use discretion about what we allow ourselves to be angry about. *We should sometimes defer our anger so we don't get angry about everything.* Anger is justified sometimes, but as a rule, we should defer our anger over most offenses and problems. We should sometimes take the high road and pass over people's “transgressions” and mistakes.

People who get angry over everything and seldom overlook anything are always angry, hurt, and constantly in conflict. They perpetually focus on someone's wrong or how someone has wronged them, which causes them to live in a negative state of mind and robs *them* of their peace and joy.

A wise person will defer their anger by letting it go. It is whatever the wrong is. *They live in a state of grace and reserve anger for serious offenses.* They confront people who have transgressed against them, but do so with discretion, so it is not habitual. Therefore, when they do confront, it has greater credibility because it is not normal. They have a more significant impact while maintaining their peace.

The wiser we become, the more stuff we will just let go of. We let go of the offense, and we let go of the need to be angry. We let go of the need to express hurt and hostility because someone transgressed against us somehow. That is a powerful way of living. It demonstrates self-control and humility. It allows us to live in a state of grace, not anger or wrath. We overlook offenses and things that would rob us of our focus, joy, and peace. We choose to live on the high road and refuse to stoop down to the level of pettiness.

Do yourself a favor and memorize this verse. Then start letting stuff go. *Forget it and move on.* You'll find it gives you incredible power and dignity!

“REPEAT OFFENDERS”

Proverbs 19:19: “A man of great wrath shall suffer punishment: for if thou deliver him, yet thou must do it again.”

Although Solomon is speaking specifically about someone with an anger problem, the principle can be broadened to include all forms of behavior resulting from a lack of self-control. When people have trouble habitually controlling themselves, they become repeat offenders, repeating the negative behavior.

If we “*deliver*” them, *they will do it again and want our help again*. The help doesn’t change *the real problem*, which is their lack of discipline and self-control. One may temporarily help relieve the negative consequences of their lack of self-control, but they will do the same thing that caused the problem. They will repeat. *An abuser* may be forgiven, but they will repeat the abuse because they lack self-control. *The overeater* may get a nutritionist to show them what to eat, but they will repeat it because they lack self-control. The same is true for the *over-spender*, *the addict*, and so on.

The list of types of behavior that fit into this principle is endless. *The over-sleeping* person who is perpetually late for work will continue making excuses daily if they are “delivered.” *The child who doesn’t clean* their room and the parents step in and finally do it for them will continuously rely on their parents to do it. Their lack of self-control will create a need for someone to “deliver” them.

What can we glean from this proverb? We need to address the real problem, not just the consequences. The real problem is a lack of self-control. Next, as people who want to live a lifestyle of wisdom, we will want to limit the number of people in our personal lives who lack self-control and perpetually need to be “delivered.” If we have too many of these types in our personal lives, they will consume our resources from those who will use them more productively. *Also, we will want to avoid business relationships with people who lack self-control*. They will require too much time and attention. They will create conflicts with those who have self-control. They will always be potential liabilities as well.

“BECOMING WISER AS WE GET OLDER”

Proverbs 19: 20: “Hear counsel, and receive instruction, that thou mayest be wise in thy latter end.”

Becoming wiser as we age isn't an automatic process. Plenty of old fools are making the same mistakes now that they made decades ago. Growing wiser is a choice. Solomon hopes his son will make that choice, so *he reveals* how to get wiser as he grows *older*.

The first thing to notice is that this process of becoming wiser is conditional. The second part of the proverb is conditional on the first part. The meaning is that if he didn't listen, “hear,” and learn (“receive instruction”) from being corrected, he wouldn't gain wisdom. That is what old fools do: repeat the same mistakes over their lifetime. Getting older is inevitable, but gaining wisdom is optional and conditional! If one is *hard-headed* and *closed-minded*, *one will not be able* to become wiser.

Listening to wise teachers is essential in gaining wisdom as we grow older. *The difference in whether we become wiser or not indeed is who we choose to listen to.* One can spend one's life listening to foolish people and gain no wisdom. Or, one can ignore good advice and live a life devoid of growth. The word “counsel” is used to indicate seeking advice. It has advisors and people who can coach you to become wiser as you grow older.

Learning from mistakes and subsequent correction is another essential ingredient in gaining wisdom as we age. Even with the best counsel, we will make mistakes because we are fallible. However, wise people will receive correction from life and their teachers. They will gain more than experience. They will grow from the experience, thus minimizing the chances of repeating the same mistake. Everyone experiences mistakes. Not everyone experiences growth from mistakes! *The wise person will receive* positively those who correct them! *The fool rejects* the people who correct them.

We can *go through life*... or we can *grow through life*! It is our choice!

“A LITTLE KINDNESS”

Proverbs 19:22: “The desire of a man is his kindness: and a poor man is better than a liar.”

What is desired as a primary characteristic in a man by the great Solomon? Is he looking for intelligence? Is he looking for strength? No, he looks for kindness. It is what he says is desired in a man. That is a powerful thought. It is insightful because if we think about it, a kind person has most of the other desirable character traits. They usually have humility, strength, and intelligence. They are comfortable and confident people who don't need to be rude, mean, and demeaning to others to cover their insecurities and inadequacies.

In Proverbs 31, when the virtuous woman is described with all her beauty and success, we are reminded that she also speaks with kindness. (See Prov. 31:26) Nothing is less attractive than a rude, mean, and demeaning person. Solomon knew kindness was a quality everyone appreciated, whether a King or a servant. We all appreciate it when people are kind to us. It makes them more attractive and causes us to want to reciprocate.

Kindness cultivates loyalty as well! As a king, Solomon knew that mean, rude, and hostile kings usually experienced *rebellions* and *revolutions*. Kind leaders ensured their well-being by treating their subjects and servants kindly. The same is true for us. If we want to earn people's loyalty and favor, we do so with kindness, not fear. That is even true for parents. Paul talked about parents provoking their children to rebellion. How? They provoke by being rude, mean, and demeaning to their children. No employee wants to work long-term in an unkind environment. An unkind boss will *not* inspire loyalty.

Some things in the Bible may seem complex and complicated, but this isn't one of them. We act with kindness. We treat people in the kindest way possible. We stop being short with people. We must stop the rudeness, demeaning attitudes, and words. We cultivate kindness by practicing kindness! A simple shift in our thinking creates *significant positive ramifications* for ourselves and others. We earn people's favor, loyalty, and respect by being kind to them! We become more attractive and desirable to people by being kind! We *eliminate* and *prevent* many future problems with people by being kind to them as much as possible. So be kind! Develop a reputation everywhere you go for being kind!

“BE A STOPPER, NOT A STIRRER”

Proverbs 20:3: “It is an honour for a man to cease from strife: but every fool will be meddling.”

Solomon’s advice in this proverb is powerful. He teaches that ceasing strife, arguments, and conflicts is honorable. He also teaches that it is foolish to meddle or keep stirring up conflict. In other words, the honorable and wise thing to do is to be the person who stops the conflicts. The easy thing to do is to keep the conflict going, but it is also foolish.

It is sometimes difficult to realize that it is honorable to stop the conflict or walk away from an argument because our *ego* gets involved. When the ego becomes dominant, we usually aren’t concerned with being honorable. We become more concerned with winning. This mentality leads to all kinds of foolish words and actions. The foolishness further escalates the strife.

Not only does the *ego* get involved by wanting to win, prove someone wrong, or be right, but our negative *emotions* dominate our thinking. Our emotions cloud our judgment and discernment, further escalating the strife. At this stage, honor isn’t a priority. Vindication or justification becomes the foolish objective. Not many honorable events will happen at this stage. Hurt will happen, but not honor.

We must understand that walking away and letting go of the strife is the best choice! It takes strength and humility to be the person who stops the strife. The win we achieve is not over another but over ourselves! In the process, we *protect ourselves* from *acting foolish* and *hurtful*! There is honor in just stopping the strife! Consequently, there is tremendous dishonor in stirring up strife and conflict.

“BUY INTO THE WALK, NOT THE TALK”

Proverbs 20:6: “Most men will proclaim every one his own goodness: but a faithful man who can find?”

Solomon observes that most people will promote themselves as good, loving, and kind. Still, it can only be determined over time when they demonstrate these characteristics faithfully. The comparison is that most people will talk up their virtues, but few faithfully live them out daily. What he is teaching is great wisdom!

Anyone can be kind and loving for a little while. Most will be, *especially when people want something from you*. However, when it comes to acting that way consistently, few people are faithful in that area. The idea of someone being faithful in demonstrating these qualities means it is part of who they are. They don't stop being that way after they get what they want.

Further, the person who faithfully demonstrates kindness and goodness doesn't discriminate in displaying these characteristics. The person who only treats some people this way and treats others poorly really isn't faithfully demonstrating these qualities. It is convenient for them, not part of their character.

Solomon was the King, Judge, and Wealthy man, so he was used to people acting kind and good to him because of his power, position, and prestige. He wouldn't buy into or believe what people said in a brief meeting. He wanted to see if they lived it out faithfully. That is something we all need to learn. *We should not buy into their talk but wait and watch their walk*. See how they live day after day. See how they treat people below them, not just people who can do something for them.

Most people will sell themselves and their virtues at the beginning of any relationship, personal or professional. They will treat us well. They will usually go overboard and be kind. *They will say and do the right thing to win us over to what they want*. We mustn't buy into the talk or their temporary display of kindness, goodness, or promotion. Take the time to watch their walk. See if they display these positive characteristics over time faithfully.

That will *save a lot of heartache and bad partnerships!*

“CULTIVATING OUR REPUTATION”

Proverbs 20:11: “Even a child is known by his doings, whether his work be pure, and whether it be right.”

Solomon points out that even children *gain their reputation based on their behavior*. We have probably heard comments like “she’s a quiet child” or “that kid is a terror.” What is that? It is when people remark about a child’s behavior. It becomes the child’s reputation until they consistently act differently. When they change their behavior over time, their reputation also changes; we’ve all known kids who were “terrors” and turned out to be sweet, polite, professional people.

We must realize that we are constantly creating our reputation, whether we are conscious of it or not. People will naturally *sum us up* by *what they see* in our behavior, which is impossible to escape or avoid. The wise person will use this to create the reputation we want to portray. We will demonstrate positive behavior to develop and maintain a good reputation. We will be faithful to our tasks to develop a reputation as a faithful person on whom others can depend.

People who complain develop reputations as complainers. Gossipers develop a reputation for gossiping, even to their friends. This principle is always working. The question becomes, *is it working for us or against us?* Is it hindering us or helping us? Have you considered that you lack influence because of your reputation? Have you considered that you’re not getting promoted because of your reputation? Maybe our reputation is keeping us from opportunities.

The wise person will investigate what their reputation is. Go to your friends, boss, and associates and ask, “What do people think about me?”, “Do people see me as a positive person?”, “What negative have you heard about me more than once?” That takes courage, but we cannot correct what we won’t confront, even in ourselves! Then the wise person will prayerfully and purposely cultivate a positive reputation. That is done by being conscious that people are watching us and summing us up by our behavior and the attitudes we portray.

“EMBRACING OUR BLESSINGS”

Proverbs 20:12: “The hearing ear, and the seeing eye, the LORD hath made even both of them.”

That may seem obvious from Solomon, who believed in creation. But in reality, what he is doing is reminding us of the miracle of being able to see and hear. A miracle? Yes! If we had a person born blind, but something transpired medically or miraculously so that they could see, they would proclaim, “It is a miracle!” The same as being able to hear! Or any physical function, for that matter.

Can you imagine the continuous awe someone who hadn’t been able to see or hear would have as they experience the sights or sounds we take for granted? Can you imagine how they would never get over seeing a sunset or hearing their loved one’s voice? Yet, most of the world is blessed with these miraculous abilities, and we take them for granted. We seldom say, “Thank you, God,” for the ability to see and hear. We seldom are just in awe of what we experience regularly.

If and when most express gratitude, it is usually for things or events. Like “thank you for my promotion” or “thank you for my house.” It is good to be thankful for everything, but remember we are walking, talking miracles! Our Bodies and their functions are gifts from God! They are irreplaceable and invaluable! So, let’s not just thank God for the food but also for the ability to eat and process it! The ability to talk and hear is such a fantastic gift! We are blessed with the ability to read and comprehend! The ability to get up and move is a huge blessing! The abilities to smell, taste, and feel are awesome gifts that most have been given!

This proverb reminds us to embrace our blessings today. *We are to live in gratitude and awe for what God has granted and given us!* Our physical and mental functions are priceless. Make it a habit to celebrate these abilities every day. Take time to be awed! Make time to express gratitude for the blessings!

“IT IS ALL SALES AND NEGOTIATION”

Proverbs 20:14: “It is naught, it is naught, saith the buyer: but when he is gone his way, then he boasteth.”

In Solomon’s day, almost everything was negotiated. *The merchant* would *talk up* the value of his product, and *the buyer* would try to *talk down* the product’s worth to get the best deal. The buyer and seller both want the best deal for themselves. Solomon isn’t saying it is wrong. He says a wise person knows this and doesn’t take what people say for granted. Behind their maneuvering, there is a personal agenda!

That is how everything operates. Everything is a form of sales and negotiation. The faster we realize this, the wiser we will operate within the context of our lives. Everyone, every business, even young children, has its agenda. The wise person will always try to recognize the agenda of the person we interact with. What are they trying to accomplish behind what they are saying? In the proverb, the “buyer” wants the best deal. He wants the product, but wants to pay as little as possible. In this example, the buyer’s happiness and success in this instant directly contradict the seller’s. He brags about how much he saved or kept from the seller.

We can increase our success and happiness based on how we sell ourselves and negotiate. People can only take advantage of you if you let them. People get taken advantage of or lose what they want for two reasons. *They fail to realize the other person (or business) has an agenda.* The salesperson never really wants to get you the best deal! They want to get you the worst deal: to increase their commission or move a product with a bonus. *The next reason we lose so much and often in negotiations is that we don’t have a clear agenda.* That allows us to focus and pre-decide what we *will* and *will not accept*.

Everyone you and I meet has an agenda. It can be a positive one, but still, they have an agenda of some kind. Personally, or professionally, we all want what we want. Sometimes we want it to be easy, so we put little effort into negotiating life. That means we are making others happy and successful, but not ourselves!

“GROW INTO SUCCESS”

Proverbs 20:21: “An inheritance may be gotten hastily at the beginning, but the end thereof shall not be blessed.”

Solomon realized that not everyone is ready to receive prosperity and success. He says a person receiving their inheritance before they are ready will eventually blow it. It may start as a positive, but it *will not “end” that way*. My mind immediately goes to the Prodigal Son every time I read this. He wasted all of his assets and money on partying. He ended up with nothing and lost what he should’ve lived off of for decades.

This proverb and the parable in Luke 15 remind me that some people aren’t ready for prosperity and abundance. They have no idea how to manage it and make it grow even more. They see only the fun they can have, not the discipline it takes to make it last and grow. They didn’t earn it slowly, so they didn’t realize how hard it was for someone to make and keep it. They *feel it is easy to come, but soon see it is easy to go!*

People need to grow into success and prosperity. *When they earn it, they value it!* They realize it is easier to keep money than to get more. It is easier to stay on top than get on top of any profession. Overnight successes happen, but they seldom retain their success. The dot.com boom became a bust. The “rapper” who had a hit and spent like crazy is now hitless and “penniless.” Some who learn business principles maintain their newfound prosperity, but only if they grow in their mentality. Athletes make enough to live without worries, yet end up broke. They stop growing as people and aren’t ready for long-term success.

Have you ever considered that maybe you aren’t ready for what you want? Maybe God is *protecting you from taking something that is supposed to be positive* and making it harmful. Too much, too soon, can be our downfall! Grow into the person who can successfully manage what “it” is that you want. Be willing to earn it so you can appreciate having it! If not, we will not make the most of what we are blessed with when we get it.

“THE FUTILITY OF DEFENDING YOURSELF”

Proverbs 20:22: “Say not thou, I will recompense evil; but wait on the LORD, and he shall save thee.”

We all naturally want to get *even* when people do something to us or say something about us. Solomon teaches that the wiser approach is not to defend ourselves but to let God deliver us. We are instructed not to get even but to let God deal with it. Of course, like all spiritual principles, this strategy contradicts our logic and conflicts with our ego. Therein lies the difficulty that produces spiritual growth if we do it God’s way.

We tend to want to hurt those who hurt us. This human tendency has many problems, including creating a vicious cycle of hurt. We hurt them back, so they hurt us back, and so on. What madness! And it usually causes an escalation in hurt and foolishness. Allowing God to deal with the person removes our emotions from the equation and adds His wisdom to do what is best for both parties.

Even defending ourselves against verbal attacks is futile because our replies will never convince those talking about us negatively. All we do is *add to our frustration and fuel the fire they started*. So, they usually exaggerate even more to overcome any attempt at defense, thus making things or us look worse. On the other hand, if we let go and let God defend us in time, we will be better off.

The worst thing that can happen is these hurtful people, whose agenda becomes our focus. When they become our focus, we stop focusing on God and what we want in life! That negative focus will do more to hurt us long term than them hurting us initially. The best solution is to let God reveal the truth about them and us over time! Commit your defense and deliverance to God! Trust that, eventually, He will illuminate the truth about *you* and *them*! See Psalms 37. Pray Psalms 37!

“SELF-DECEPTION”

Proverbs 21:2: “Every way of a man is right in his own eyes: but the LORD pondereth the hearts.”

Multiple proverbs deal with man’s ability to deceive himself. This one is powerful because it reveals why we are so good at it. Even if it is wrong, we must see it as “right” when deciding. Our conscience requires us to justify what we do, at least at the moment of decision. We see (perceive) what we are doing as right. We convince ourselves it is good or right to get ourselves to do it. We do this all the time, but often don’t realize it.

In this proverb, God looks at our motives. We can do the right things with the wrong motive. *God looks through our justification and explanation to the truth of why we did what we did or do what we do.* We cannot fool God or convince Him. Yet, amazingly, many do use God to justify their decisions and choices. God sees through that as well!

We must know that we are always convincing ourselves “it” is right. That awareness will help minimize self-deception. We will always convince ourselves “it” is right on some level. So, we need to do what God does and consider our motives. Is it purely selfish? Will it hurt others? Will it be good long-term?

Usually, even if we see something right in our minds, we can *still sense something isn’t right in our spirits*. Somewhere inside us, a little voice makes us uncomfortable about what we have convinced ourselves is right. That’s what we need to tune into. To make good decisions, our little voice needs to be listened to. It won’t deceive us because it is connected to the Spirit. We must line up our self-discussion and justification with that voice; that sensing. Not contradict it!

“WISE PEOPLE WILL GET THIS”

Proverbs 21:3: “To do justice and judgment is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice.”

Solomon clearly states that what we “do” is true worship, not a religious ritual. The words “justice” and “judgment” refer to how we treat people, which is an act of worship. How we treat people and what we “do” is “acceptable” to God, meaning it pleases God or doesn’t.

That is a contrarian perspective to what *we practice* in Christianity today. We may be less formal than the Old Testament rituals, but we still consider most worship inside a church building and with others. Authentic worship occurs outside the building and includes what we do to people and how we treat them. Do we treat them with loving, kind behavior? Do we treat them the way we want to be treated? Do we treat them fairly and without bias?

Our daily behaviors and attitudes are more important to God than our religious activity and service. This revelation will do amazing things for our attitude *if we get it*. If we *understand* that God doesn’t separate our behavior and say this is worship and this isn’t. It is all worship of God, like how we treat our coworkers. How we treat the waiter, how we treat the homeless person. How we conduct ourselves in business is worship. It is all a form of worship, or it is a form of disrespect!

I cannot disrespect people and respect God, too. I cannot walk around unkind, rude, and mean and then turn on a positive spirit to worship! I can do it, but it isn’t “acceptable” to God! Religious Activity will not compensate for a terrible attitude. Religious Activity will not compensate for treating people poorly. The songs we sing, our offerings, and our service on Sunday will not undo treating people wrongly on Monday! Get it!

“SUCCESSFUL PEOPLE THINK DIFFERENTLY”

Proverbs 21:5: “The thoughts of the diligent tend only to plenteousness; but of every one that is hasty only to want.”

First, I want us to notice that people who are “diligent” and have abundance *think differently*. They think “*only*” in terms of “plenteousness.” *They focus on* how to create plenty or be productive. They aren’t in a hurry because this is their mindset, not just a reaction to a problem. They don’t need to be “hasty” because they have a long-term outlook.

Successful people see the world as a place of abundance. *There is plenty for everyone if they do the right things.* Most other people see the world as a place of scarcity. Things are always running out for them, so they make hasty emotional decisions out of fear. Fear-based decisions produce what we don’t want. They produce the outcome they don’t want. On the other hand, the “thoughts” of the diligent are on producing abundance, so they get their outcome.

It is challenging for those who haven’t ever considered abundance and “plenteousness” to grasp that it is available. Further challenging is that they are in the habit of making “hasty” decisions. They have tremendous difficulty thinking long-term because they see more scarcity or lack when they do.

Their fear creates impatience that robs them of what they need to succeed—persistence. It also undermines their motivation, so they don’t work toward long-term goals. The consequence is a mindset of living from day to day, which will not be productive or positive.

The diligent focus on producing the outcome of “plenteousness,” *so they find what they are looking for!* If we look for ways to get by, we will find them too. Often that leads to creating more lack. That’s why Solomon said they would be in “want.” We see the world not as it is but as we are. *People with poor minds see only poverty. People with rich thinking see the world as a place of abundance and opportunity!*

“AVOID CRITICAL, COMBATIVE COMPANIONS”

Proverbs 21:9: “It is better to dwell in a corner of the housetop, than with a brawling woman in a wide house.”

Solomon uses a female in this proverb because he is instructing his son. However, the same principle would apply to the opposite genders. It can apply to any companionship or committed relationship, business or personal. We are better off alone on top of the roof, dealing with the harsh elements, than being inside, dealing with the harsh, combative, critical person. The elements can be endured, but a brawling person will tear us down beyond belief.

It is better to be alone than to be in a relationship with a fault-finding, fight-starting person! Even someone as powerful and wise as Solomon realized he was susceptible to this destruction. This type of person wears down those in the sphere of influence, be it their spouse, children, or business partners. They are non-stop finding fault and verbal attacks. Sometimes their attacks are *overt* in our faces, while others are more *covert*. They will use looks, tone of voice, attitude, and display of anger, all to let the other person know they are the problem. The critical, combative person doesn't see themselves as the problem or part of it. Their arrogance will not allow them to believe that.

Our companionships and partnerships must be entered into with tremendous discretion and discipline! These people will either build us up or completely tear us down. No one can succeed while continuously engaging in emotional and verbal brawls with those closest to us. We will not succeed in the public arena when we are exhausted from the combativeness of our private lives. That will create inevitable failure, reinforcing the negativity the critical companion has sown.

The best way to deal with these toxic relationships is never to get involved from the start. That is where the discipline comes in to wait for the right positive, edifying relationship. If we are emotionally or financially needy in our business relationships, we will have a nightmare. *It takes time to see how people are!* Many start relationships with their best persona, being kind and supportive. However, *time can reveal* that the *once positive* or *sweet person* is *critical and combative*. Wait to see their bad side! We all have one, but some live it as their lifestyle. As a wise rule, avoid critical, fault-finding people, even if it is directed at others, because eventually, they will turn on you!

“THE WISE CONSERVE-THE FOOLISH CONSUME”

Proverbs 21:20: “There is treasure to be desired and oil in the dwelling of the wise; but a foolish man spendeth it up.”

If you study Solomon’s wealth and lifestyle, you will see that he lived a lavish, opulent lifestyle. Yet, we also see that he amassed significant gold, silver, and building materials savings. He was a saver or a conserver. He always had way more than enough when he could easily consume all his resources. He was a wise man who believed in *the principle* and *discipline of saving!*

The foolish person “spendeth” it all up. They consume everything they get. Then they don’t have “oil” to light their lamps. They are undisciplined in the use of their resources. They eat and play without any thought for the future. They spend their full pay on the weekends partying and shopping. Or any other form of consumption. They overeat, spend too much, and save too little.

The language in the proverb means they are wasteful. They waste oil because they won’t bother to blow out the lamps. They have some treasure but refuse to take care of it, making it useless. They are getters, not protectors. They aren’t disciplined in caring for what they are blessed with, so they waste whatever they get. Notice the proverb didn’t say treasure in the house of the wealthy. It said in the house of the wise. They may not have the luxury like Solomon, but because they have lived wisely, they have treasure and abundance.

The comparison is a *discerning lifestyle* versus a *wasteful lifestyle*. It compares the discipline of conserving and caring for one’s resources versus consuming and neglecting one’s resources. The wise person exercises discipline while the foolish consumes in the now. Of the two, which is our American Culture?

“FIND A WAY-BE AN OVERCOMER”

Proverbs 21:22: “A wise man scalesh the city of the mighty, and casteth down the strength of the confidence thereof.”

A wise person looks at obstacles and asks, “How can I overcome this?” *They aren’t stopped by how things appear.* They are all about finding a solution to the problem and rising to the challenge. Wisdom has taught them that what looks impossible has a possible solution. So they proceed *intelligently*, not *irrationally*!

Proceeding with intelligence includes planning and preparation. Doubtless, this also included prayerfulness for a man of faith like Solomon. There must be a *strategy* or a tactical attack on the “thing” that must be overcome. Haphazard plans fail. The failure isn’t because of the obstacle but because of the poor strategy of the overcomer. This is where *wise people blame the strategy*, and *others* blame the obstacle as being too hard. The wise go back to the “drawing board.” Most others give up on overcoming the obstacle.

People fail to be overcomers not because they are unable, but because they have poor strategies. They usually *reinforce their failure* by trying to overcome the same obstacle using the *same strategy that failed in the first place*. A wise person would never try the same tactic that let them down the first time. To the wise, this is some form of insanity.

The way to overcome obstacles is seldom to try harder. *It is usually to get smarter! It is to become wiser! Think better. Develop a better plan. Think differently than before. Each obstacle requires new thought! What overcame City A will not work in City B. The same holds true for anything that we try to overcome.*

Sometimes, we must back off from attacking, think, pray, and learn from our failures. Doing the same thing that failed is not the answer! Bring in a wise person to help you strategize! Bring in a specialist to overcome that type of obstacle and develop a better plan of attack! It can be done! It can be overcome! The battle can be won!

“SUCCESS IS ALLOWED”

Proverbs 21:31: “The horse is prepared against the day of battle: but safety is of the LORD.”

Solomon, in all his wisdom, knew that Success and victory are ultimately allowed by God. He believed in planning and preparation, as seen in this proverb and others. But he knew that if God didn’t allow it to happen, it wouldn’t matter how much preparation was made. That is a wise perspective that causes humility.

Success can breed arrogance, and winning can feed the human ego. The person who goes from Success to Success can easily take it for granted and think they are the sole cause of their Success. Solomon reminded his son and us that Success comes from God. He allows it. He doesn’t necessarily cause it by divine intervention in every circumstance. But God could stop it by divine intervention anytime He wanted to. No amount of planning or show of strength could stop God if He wanted to halt the Success.

All Success is allowed by God. We need to win humbly and thank God for any Success! Every victory in our lives, personally and professionally, is ultimately allowed to happen. This perspective reminds us that we ultimately depend *upon God* for our successes and victories. We are not the sole reason for our Success. That keeps our egos in check and constrains our arrogance.

Acknowledging God for any and all Success is essential for a healthy spiritual *perspective*. *Asking* for God’s blessing on our plans is also essential. Then, after the victory is won, it is time to express *appreciation* to God for allowing it! That keeps us balanced emotionally and growing spiritually!

“CULTIVATING A GOOD REPUTATION AND FAVOR”

Proverbs 22:1: “A GOOD name is rather to be chosen than great riches, and loving favour rather than silver and gold.”

Solomon teaches that two things *have greater value than riches and treasure*. The first is a “good name,” and the next is “loving favour.” A good name refers to one’s reputation. “Loving Favour” refers to being liked. Notice that Solomon teaches that both these characteristics are chosen. We can choose to cultivate and influence how people think about us.

These two treasured characteristics are essential for our success. A good reputation allows us to be trusted, creates a positive image for our services, and helps overcome people’s hesitations toward us. It will do more for our professional lives than anything else, and its worth cannot be estimated! It is more valuable than any marketing campaign because a bad reputation can undermine any marketing attempt. A good reputation is essential for long-term success.

The next treasured characteristic is favor. Favor is likeability. People will go out of their way for people they like. We will be treated with favored status when we are liked. *Likability is also essential for long-term success.* People will not want to keep doing business with people they don’t like or with people who rub them the wrong way. We may do a great job, but they will not want to bless or help us if we are disliked. People don’t even want to invest time with people they don’t like, much less their money.

When people make a broad statement like, “I don’t care what people think about me,” it reveals a lack of wisdom. It shows a lack of wisdom about how the world operates. It was important in Solomon’s day to have a good reputation and be likable, which is still vital. We cannot have a positive reputation with everyone nor be liked by everyone. We must cultivate a good reputation with enough people. It is imperative that some people like us to have success and be happy.

“AVOIDANCE IS THE BEST POLICY”

Proverbs 22:3: “A prudent man foreseeth the evil, and hideth himself: but the simple pass on, and are punished.”

Solomon wants for his son what God wants for us. He wants him to avoid as much trouble (“evil”) as possible and not to be “punished” for getting involved in things he could avoid. The word “punished” means suffering. That type of suffering is primarily self-induced by not exercising good discernment and discretion.

One of the secrets of the wise is that they try to avoid as many mistakes as possible. They try to foresee potential *pitfalls* and *problems* and navigate away from them. They do not want to get trapped in things that can be avoided by choosing a different *path*. That is prudence in action.

The “simple” are those who go through life without thinking ahead. They deal with things after they happen, which usually causes great suffering. They make their life harder than it has to be. They avoid very little trouble because they live in the moment. They exercise no forethought about the *consequences* or *cost* involved! They aren’t on the lookout for potential pitfalls and traps. They plunder ahead and too often pay the price for it.

Avoidance is the best policy! It allows us to *minimize self-induced difficulties* and *maximize* our *pursuit of positive things*. We progress while others pull themselves out of traps that could’ve been avoided. An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure, and prevention is always less painful.

Avoidance will eliminate a lot of self-induced suffering. Life punishes those who don’t use *discretion*, *discernment*, and *disciplined decision-making*!

“AVOIDING THE HARDHEADED”

Proverbs 22: 5: “Thorns and snares are in the way of the froward: he that doth keep his soul shall be far from them.”

The word “forward” means *obstinate*, so we call them hard-headed. This type of person refuses to listen to instructions or advice. They refuse to learn from mistakes, and very often, their mistakes only *reinforce their negative disposition*. They are prideful, which prevents them from listening or learning.

The term “thorns” refers to getting caught up in painful things. Then there are the “snares” or traps they seem to get caught up in continuously. To the wise person observing this lifestyle, it seems like some form of insanity. But to them, it becomes the negative norm. Once they get free from one painful situation or pitfall, it is just a matter of time before they find another.

They refuse warnings and go forward as willfully as ever. The wise person would be humbled by their falling into a trap, but not the “forward.” They are hardened, not humbled. They become more prideful, plundering ahead with more arrogance and anger. The pain of the “thorns” only causes them more resentment and rebellion. It is a vicious cycle for them.

Solomon clearly states that a wise person will stay far from this type of person. They have a curse on them because of their hard-headedness. It isn’t created by God but by the *consequences of their disposition and decisions*. Their resentment and rebellious attitude cause trouble, and anyone closely associated with them will be caught up in their messes. *If we want to keep our “soul” from the anxiety caused by them, we will stay “far from them.”* We should not be closely associated with hard-headed and rebellious people.

“HELPING CHILDREN FIND THEIR WAY”

Proverbs 22: 6: “Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it.”

That is probably one of the most quoted verses from the Book of Proverbs. It contains a *promise* and a *principle* for parents. Understanding the principle would also be helpful for anyone in a leadership role. The phrase “way he should go” refers to a specific path for that child individually. It is based on their unique God-given bent, giftedness, passions, and talents.

So often, because parents fail at the principle part, they realize that the promise part has also failed. It wasn't that God didn't honor the promise. It is because they fail to fulfill the principle. The word “train” means more than teaching a moral code. It is developing the child to find and fulfill their purpose in life. It is helping them develop what God has entrusted to them in the way of their *passions* and *purposes*.

We fail our children when we try to turn them into copies of ourselves or others! We are to develop them to follow God's *plan* for their lives, *not our plans* for them. That isn't leadership. It is a dictatorship. *It leads them to frustration, failure, and even rebellion because they are on the wrong path for them.* Teaching principled living is important, but training them for purposeful living is essential for their success and happiness.

Many people are unhappy because they live as a copy of someone else and not as the unique expression of God's grace they are supposed to be. They are trying to live someone else's dream, not God's for them. *They are in a way that is uncomfortable for them and doesn't fit them.* We too often try to *impose our way* on those we influence instead of helping them *discover their way*, helping them find God's path to be their best by being themselves.

“HAVING A BOUNTIFUL EYE”

Proverbs 22: 9: “He that hath a bountiful eye shall be blessed; for he giveth of his bread to the poor.”

The person with a “bountiful eye” is *looking for opportunities to be blessed and to bless others*. They see that they have enough to share with someone who has less. They see the needs of people around them, while others see only their own needs, wants, or desires. In *the process of giving*, they are “blessed” in return.

God’s economy has always included those with any substance to share with those in need. “Bread” is more of an illustration in the proverb. We can have other things that help meet the needs of the people around us. There are physical needs, financial needs, and emotional needs. People are starving for hope just as much as they are for help.

If we don’t have a “bountiful eye,” we will not see or sense the needs of others around us. Consequently, people’s needs go unmet not because of God’s will but because we weren’t willing to see them. We will not know what we can do if we only focus on ourselves and our needs. When we start with the attitude that we are blessed, we will be much more likely to be a blessing.

In this proverb, notice that he is “blessed” because he “giveth.” It is the action of giving that produces the blessing. Good intentions *do not help* those in need nor *activate the principle of sowing and reaping*. God plans for us to participate in meeting the needs of those around us who lack what we have. God doesn’t expect us to share what we don’t have, but He does expect us to share out of what we do have. He will then bless us in return for *being* a blessing. Everyone is blessed!

“GET RID OF TROUBLEMAKERS”

Proverbs 22:10: “Cast out the scorner, and contention shall go out; yea, strife and reproach shall cease.”

Solomon’s advice is obvious: Get rid of the troublemakers, and the trouble will “cease.” Get rid of those *causing contention*; a *conflict* will end or “go out.” In other words, eliminate those starting fires within the group, and the contention will die.

Solomon recognizes that every leader must realize that there is usually an *instigator* and a *hostile leader* within a group, influencing others to think and act negatively. This person cannot be negotiated with or tolerated because they will affect and infect others negatively. They have no respect for the leader, so they cause “reproach” and “strife.” Confronting them may calm things down, but it will only be temporary. They haven’t changed their thought process about the leader, so it is just a matter of time before the same behavior manifests.

Most people involved in ministry or believers in business want to help people. Often, we think we can salvage the person, but the truth is they aren’t salvageable as they are. They have an attitude issue toward your authority—maybe all authority. Solomon calls them scorners, meaning they are disrespectful and disruptive. The only real remedy is to cast them out of the body, business, or team.

The leader must find the troublemaker and get rid of that person for the trouble to stop. This will establish the leader’s authority and cause others to think twice before joining in negativity, such as criticism, conflict, and contention. If this isn’t done before long, the negative influence will spread, and the leader will lose control of the group. A rebel will produce a rebellion if tolerated!

“GRACIOUS SPEECH WILL GET YOU ANYWHERE”

Proverbs 22:11: “He that loveth pureness of heart, for the grace of his lips the king shall be his friend.”

Solomon, as a king, could afford to pick and choose who he allowed to be his friends. He says he wanted to be friends with people who were gracious in their words. He didn’t want to be around people who were complaining and critical. He didn’t want to be exposed to gossipers or whiners. He wanted to have people around him who were pleasant and positive.

The last thing someone with significant responsibility needs is a critical or harsh-speaking person around them. They need people who can edify and encourage them. They need people who can brighten their day and lighten their load, not put more pressure on them. *The King and the leader alike hear complaints all day. They don’t want to hear more at the end of the day.* Who does, for that matter? They will welcome a pleasant and positive person into their lives. People who give to them somehow and do not drain them further emotionally!

If we want to be recognized and received into the lives of important people, or anyone’s lives, we need to be gracious with our speech and pleasant in our attitude. We want them to feel better because we are around, not feeling burdened by us. We want to be a source of encouragement, not another drain on them emotionally. We should be a source of pleasantness for them, not another problem.

The way we talk affects people. It may be a subconscious response, but people are attracted to or repelled by us by how we talk and our attitude. People who have power and position can be more discriminating about whom they are friends with. We should think of everyone as an important person with a lot to deal with, realizing the last thing anyone wants is to be around a negative person. Honestly, who wants that? Are you the type of person who brightens the room or the type of person who tolerates?

“SELF-DISCIPLINE OR SELF-DESTRUCTION”

Proverbs 23:21: “For the drunkard and the glutton shall come to poverty: and drowsiness shall clothe a man with rags.”

When we look at the three things mentioned in this proverb, they all have two things in common. *First, all three harm a person's life. Next, they are all a form of a lack of self-discipline.* The drunkard drinks too much. The glutton overeats, and the drowsy person sleeps too much. They all overindulge without any self-control. Consequently, their life is out of control, and they lose their ability to be productive.

Every form of habitual overindulgence robs us of something. It robs us of our wealth and or health. It robs us of our ability to be positive and productive. Pleasure-seeking is addictive. Whether it is the pleasure of sleeping too much or partying, it diminishes our productive capacity. Yes, some people with addictions have produced wealth, but it robs them of their health or relationships. It does have a negative consequence.

Solomon's son would have easy access to a life of pleasure and pampering, so Solomon advised him that *just because he can do something doesn't mean he should.* He wanted him to see beyond the pursuit of pleasure and realize the negative consequences it would produce. Solomon desired his son to live a disciplined life, not one of excess and indulgence. He wanted his son to have a life of power and purpose, not pleasure-seeking. God certainly wants the same for us.

The way to avoid self-destruction is by choosing a life of self-discipline. *Just because you can doesn't mean you should.* Overindulgence happens when we lose the ability to tell ourselves “no.” It is giving in to our desire and not learning the power of self-denial. Our bodies and emotions are like spoiled children. *If we don't tell them “no,” they will want more and more until we are out of control.* Then, when we are out of control, our lives become out of control. That is far from living a wise lifestyle! Self-discipline is the way to avoid self-destruction!

“DEBT IS SERVITUDE”

Proverbs 22:7: “The rich ruleth over the poor, and the borrower is servant to the lender.”

Debt is a form of voluntary servitude. *It involves surrendering a portion of our rights to the lender. While it may sometimes be necessary to incur debt, we should do so knowing* that we are giving someone else authority over us. We become their servants under whatever agreement is made during the loan.

Debt is also a form of slavery. We lose a certain amount of freedom and become burdened by the weight of the debt. If one has too many debts, one becomes enslaved by the chains created by the debts. At some point, the lender can take back the property, take income from the borrower, and create enormous hardships. That is a form of servitude.

Borrowing money and accepting debt should be done with tremendous discretion. The *wisest principle* is to avoid debt in general. The *next best principle* is to avoid depreciating debt. That means avoiding borrowing money for things that lose their value. An example of this is loans for cars or electronics. These debts have no chance of gaining value. An appreciating debt might be a smart mortgage on a property that will increase in value on its own. The borrower can sell the property and pay off the debt while making money on the appreciation. However, most overborrow on the property, meaning they accept more debt than it is worth.

In our contemporary world, we can see the dangers of debt. Many are in foreclosure because of the inflation of their debt on their house and properties. Banks consequently hold more debt on their balance sheets, so they don't lend. The world's governments are in crisis mode because they have borrowed too much from themselves. We are a culture of enslaved people and servants who feel oppressed by our debts and lenders. Freedom seems like a dream. The weight of our debts creates instability, insecurity, and irritability. Maybe we should learn from our mistakes!

“ADVERSITY IS A REVEALER”

Proverbs 24:10: “If thou faint in the day of adversity, thy strength is small.”

Solomon starts by describing “if” we faint in the day of adversity, meaning it is a possibility, not a must. Adversity is a revealer. *It will reveal how weak we are or how strong we are.* Two people can face similar adversity; one rises to the challenge, and the other is crushed. The difference is within the person, not the circumstances.

Adversity is part of life. The sooner we accept that there will be some difficulties, adverse, and hard days, the better prepared we will be to deal with them. Adversity is a part of progress. To grow, one must deal with adversity positively. One can have a victim mentality regarding adversity, thinking, “Why me?” Or one can *fight through it! Deal with it and* move forward. Adversity is life’s university. The school of hardships is where we get stronger and become better! We either graduate out or remain there in that grade of life.

We get through adversity by not fainting! That means we refuse to quit! It may be hard and hurt, but we never quit! We push on one breath at a time, one step forward, one day at a *time. Adversity always has the same goal...to make you “faint.”* It wants to push and keep you down and make you believe you aren’t strong enough. One will win over adversity and build greater strength if one keeps on.

Adversity reveals to us what we are on the inside. It reveals our willpower or lack of willpower. It reveals the strength or weakness of our character. Adversity can be our friend or foe, depending on how we view it. If we accept it as something that must be overcome and determine not to give up or give in, we will see it as a friend who taught us a great lesson. If we refuse to accept it positively and allow it to overcome us, we will see it as a foe that taught us how weak we were. The problem or potential is not in the adversity but within us.

“GETTING UP IS THE WAY TO GET OVER”

Proverbs 27:10: “For a just man falleth seven times, and riseth up again: but the wicked shall fall into mischief.”

Solomon, in his wisdom, knew that even good people make mistakes. The “just” is those trying to do right and make the best decisions. Even they will, at times, “fall.” They will make mistakes and make bad decisions that will have negative consequences. Solomon’s advice is that they get up over and over. They will not let their mistakes or failures keep them down.

When we fall, three things happen. First, there is the embarrassment of falling. It is humbling. Second, there is the hurt caused by the fall. The hurt is usually proportional to the extent of the fall. Some injuries or setbacks take longer to recover from. A bruised ego will heal faster than a broken heart. Thirdly, progress is stopped when one falls; many who fall never get beyond the fall.

The way to overcome any fall is to get up. This means refusing to accept the mistake, misstep, or failure as permanent. It means realizing it happened but not allowing it to define the future. Depending on the significance of the fall, there may be a recovery time, but it will not stop one from moving forward.

Rising or getting up means one gets up of their own volition. They aren’t waiting for a person or outside influence to coax them. They get up and get on with their journey. Solomon’s use of the number seven wasn’t accidental. It meant completing a cycle. This person falls repeatedly but refuses to give up or give in to the failures. They are *willing themselves* on despite setbacks, embarrassments, hurts, and loss of momentum. They keep getting up and getting on with their life positively and productively!

After one falls, there is always a choice. *The choice is to get up and get over it or stay down and wallow in pain, embarrassment, and failure.* Important: The same holds true if one is pushed down as well. There still must be a choice to get up and get over it!

“HOW TO FIND OUT A LOT ABOUT SOMEONE”

Proverbs 27: 21: “As the fining pot for silver, and the furnace for gold; so is a man to his praise.”

This proverb contains great wisdom from Solomon. He advises that if we want to learn much about a person, we should listen to what they praise and brag about. Their praise is a revelation of their heart. It can reveal the impurities of their thoughts, like the refining process reveals the dross of precious metal.

Think about how true this is. What we brag about and praise reveals a lot of information. It may not always be a bad revelation. We can see that people are proud of their children. We can see that a person gets pleasure from sporting events. We can learn people’s passions, priorities, and pursuits from what they praise or boast about.

Some people brag about partying, while others brag about their achievements. Both reveal the person’s heart. Some people praise things that are good and kind, while others praise foolish things. Some people brag about themselves, while others praise the people around them. The difference reveals whether a person is self-centered or interested in others. Some people boast about the past, revealing they live in it. They long for *what was*, not focusing on what *can be*.

As “believers,” what we brag about and praise reveals much about our relationship with God. If we actively talk about His Goodness and answered prayers, what we are thankful for can reveal a passionate relationship with God. However, praising or magnifying with our mouths all negative and wrong reveals that our heart is focused on everything but God’s goodness. Continuously talking about anything is a form of praise because it builds up whatever the topic is. *So, what we talk the most about reveals volumes about what’s happening inside us!*

“THE WISDOM OF LIVING IN THE DAY”

Proverbs 27:1: “Boast not thyself of tomorrow; for thou knowest not what a day may bring forth.”

Solomon admonishes that we don’t assume tomorrow as a fact. We aren’t guaranteed the next day or what will happen on that day. We should exercise the wisdom of living in this day. He isn’t saying we don’t plan the future. He has previously given explicit instructions about wisdom, planning, and preparing for the future. However, boasting means counting on it as a fact, a certainty. He is teaching us *not to depend on* doing things tomorrow. He is instructing us to maximize today and not to minimize today by counting on tomorrow!

We are to live presently. We are to live in this day with all of our *focus* and *fervor*. We shouldn’t be people who are putting off things until another day. If it is doable today, then it should be done, and we should not procrastinate because we assume there is a tomorrow. Living presently means experiencing this day and not allowing a future day that may or may not be a reality to rob us of the present. Tomorrow’s work and worry can distract us from what and who is present in our lives. We can be so future-focused that we miss the present.

We are to love immediately. We cannot be foolish by putting off the opportunity to express love to those in our lives until tomorrow. Each present moment is precious and valuable. The future has no real value because it may not ever happen. Loving immediately is the wisest way to live. Assuming there will be a tomorrow to express and experience love with those in our lives is a dangerous habit. It will ultimately lead to regret because it creates an emotional debt that cannot be paid when there is no longer a tomorrow with them.

We must learn to live in the present and love in the immediate. Doing that will make this day we have come to life. It will awaken us out of the habit of living for tomorrow. We aren’t supposed to live for tomorrow, but live today. That is all we have; our responsibility is to maximize the present. Here is the odd thing. If we maximize the present, we also maximize the future. However, if we maximize the future, we minimize the present and the future.

“SELF-PRAISE SHOULD STAY SILENT PRAISE”

Proverbs 27:2: “Let another man praise thee, and not thine own mouth; a stranger, and not thine own lips.”

In his wisdom, Solomon knew that when we *brag* or *boast* about ourselves, it negatively affects those who hear. Speaking our praise is usually seen as a sign of weakness, *not strength*. Self-praise usually hints at insecurity, not security, in one’s talents and abilities. So, he admonished that we should refrain from praising ourselves.

Solomon received tremendous praise from others. People came from faraway countries because of his reputation. However, his reputation was created by his actions and accomplishments, not self-propaganda. *He earned people’s respect and praise based on his conduct and affairs*. He was undoubtedly a man who could brag and boast of his accomplishments. He had unparalleled success and unequaled wealth. Yet, he refrained from self-praise.

The wisdom from the proverb and his example is clear. It seems it implied to me that false humility isn’t advised either. Whereas we shouldn’t lift ourselves, we shouldn’t put ourselves down either. That also harms those who hear it. It seems like a false humility. Silence is better than false humility or self-exaltation!

The truth is, if we are living our lives in a way worthy of praise, someone will notice. *If we are excellent in some area or arena, others will brag about us*. It is inevitable. If we are *the best at what* we do or *do our best*, “another” will praise us. We must praise ourselves when we aren’t doing enough to create it from others. That is the easy way out. We should earn the praise of others! If we aren’t being praised, we should take inventory of ourselves and raise our standards! In Proverbs 31, the virtuous woman’s family praised her because she earned it. She was an exceptional lady! *If we are exceptional, we will be praised by someone!*

“THE UNCONTROLLABILITY OF NEGATIVE EMOTION”

Proverbs 27:4: “Wrath is cruel, and anger is outrageous; but who is able to stand before envy?”

Solomon lists three forms of negative emotions: “wrath,” “anger,” and “envy.” “Wrath” is the expression of anger. It is active hostility. “Anger” is apparent. “Envy” is jealousy. All three forms of negative emotions are seen as uncontrollable and unpredictable! They are described in dramatic terms.

These negative emotions aren’t just *dramatic*, but they are also disastrous.

“Wrath” causes us to be cruel. When we are angry or hostile, we will turn into cruel people. *We will become mean, even vicious, in what we say, do, and think.* When we reach this point, we are unable and unwilling to control what we say, think, and do. Our normal personality is changed to one that is hurtful and unrestrained. We go for people’s weak spots because we want to hurt them. It is sad how we all can behave in a “wrath” state.

“Anger” causes us to be “outrageous.” That is so true. When people give in to anger and lose self-control, they act outrageously. They say outrageous things and do outrageous things that are out of character. It can be like the difference between night and day in a person. Even wise people usually can and will act foolishly when they give in to anger or other negative emotions.

“Envy” is described as unstoppable and unbearable. No one can stand in its way. It creates a tidal wave of negative emotion and behavior that wipes out anyone in its path. It creates a temporary form of insanity. It causes dysfunctional thinking. It sets the imagination wild with negative images and thoughts. It enhances every fear toward its focus. When jealousy is present, logic and reason will be absent. *Foolishness will be driven by fear and insecurity like never before.* The behavior will become absurd!

“HUNGRY HEART”

Proverbs 27:7: “The full soul loatheth an honeycomb; but to the hungry soul every bitter thing is sweet.”

This proverb has a literal meaning and a figurative application. When a person is hungry, their hunger causes them to lose discernment of taste. They are so *in need* of food that even *bitter things taste* good. The need for food becomes more important than taste.

When people have a “hungry soul,” they are so driven by their neediness that they lack discernment. They partake in things that others would find distasteful. They aren’t discerning or “picky.” They lower their standards because they have a “hungry soul.” They are driven by fulfilling their need because they are hungry.

People are hungry for different things. Some hunger for love, others for acceptance. Some people crave attention, and others affirmation. They are hungry on the inside, the “soul.” They often seek to fulfill this hunger in ways that lack discernment. *Some become abusers of substances; some become the types of people who people use.* Their craving for attention, affirmation, or love makes them prey to people who take advantage of them physically and emotionally. The people who use them don’t care about their well-being or betterment.

A “hungry soul” is dangerous because it causes dysfunction. Things that aren’t good seem to be good at the moment. People who aren’t good seem good, and those who are good seem less desirable. Spiritual things become distasteful, and foolish things are craved. If you have a “hungry soul,” you must learn not to trust your discernment and decision-making abilities. Find a trusted friend or counselor to help you make better decisions.

“MONITOR WHAT YOU MANAGE”

Proverbs 27:23: “Be thou diligent to know the state of thy flocks, and look well to thy herds.”

Solomon’s advice to his prince son may seem odd to some. Why would a king need to be aware of his flocks? Doesn’t he have more important things to take care of? I believe Solomon knew that no one would take responsibility for his property and business as he would. He knew he had to be diligent to know what was happening in every business area. *He is teaching the principle of diligence.*

Being diligent meant knowing what was happening in his flocks or other responsibilities. It meant taking the time to see for himself and not relying on a shepherd or a manager. Maintaining awareness of his flocks, herds, and other assets takes time, effort, and energy. Solomon knew being hands-on was essential to preventing the loss of part or all of his livestock. If he had advised this diligence on his livestock, one can rightly assume he also had watched over his treasures with diligence.

Solomon knew *we could not manage what we don’t monitor!* We have to take responsibility for our responsibilities! We shouldn’t entirely rely on others to manage what belongs to us. They will take advantage of our laziness or negligence. Relying too much on others to manage what belongs to us or is our responsibility will open the door for them to be haphazard or even steal from us. We must be diligent in knowing what is happening with the things and people we are responsible for!

Diligence is the opposite of negligence. It is maintaining awareness of what is happening and accepting responsibility for our affairs, businesses, and relationships. Permissiveness is a neglect of duty! Relying blindly on others neglects our responsibilities and will always hurt us. A wise leader will have their fingers on the pulse of their people and properties. *Good management requires constant, diligent monitoring!*

“THE CONFIDENCE FROM DOING RIGHT”

Proverbs 28: 1: “The wicked flee when no man pursueth: but the righteous are bold as a lion.”

When a person does wrong, they have *a sense of guilt, producing fears* about the consequences of their behavior. Even if they don't experience consequences for the behavior, they will undermine their confidence because they have a sense of fear. However, the person is doing right on the proverb's opposite side. Their righteousness produces boldness in them. They are free from the negative emotion that comes from doing wrong.

Many of us, as kids, had the experience of doing something wrong and then living with the fear that our parents would or had found out. We would want to avoid going home and avoiding our parents because we felt guilty. When they called us, we wondered if they had found out. We would be timid around them. In other words, we would lack confidence because we had done wrong. Whether or not they ever found out, we would feel like fleeing or avoiding them for a time.

More broadly, doing wrong produces guilt and fear, creating negative psychology. It causes us to look over our shoulders, wondering when or if we will be found out or face consequences. Guilt and fear can cause us to avoid people involved or authorities, diluting our confidence.

Doing right and being right develop confidence. It gives us the boldness to face accusers and authorities. It frees us from the weight of negative emotions. It gives us inner confidence instead of inner condemnation. That inner confidence produces boldness and strength!

“THE ADVANTAGE OF GENEROSITY”

Proverbs 28:8: “He that by usury and unjust gain increaseth his substance, he shall gather it for him that will pity the poor.”

That is an interesting proverb. I have to pause and remind myself that it comes from Solomon, the wealthiest and wisest person in history. He points out that there are two ways to increase our finances. The first is to take advantage of people. Taking advantage includes charging high interest rates and, in short, ripping people off. *The other way is to be kind and generous to those in need.* It is giving to them and not taking advantage of their need or desperation.

Solomon teaches that taking advantage of people is a short-term method. He teaches that, ultimately, their profit will end up in the hands of generous and kind people. The principle is that there is a divine blessing on those who are generous and kind. Then, there is a divine curse on those who take advantage of needy people.

There is an advantage to being generous! *It allows us to bless others and be blessed in the process.* It creates long-term prosperity and avoids the temptation of short-term gain at another person's expense. It constrains our greed and cultivates our goodness. It demonstrates our faith in God and divine principles, believing that God's ways are better than the way of greed.

Greed hurts both parties involved. *It diminishes the character of the “unjust” businessperson while also burdening the victim. The profit gained will not be blessed spiritually. The person who takes unfair advantage will not profit spiritually. On the other hand, the generous person will experience financial and spiritual growth and gain. Take advantage of the principle of generosity, not take advantage of people, especially those in need!*

“DEAL WITH IT”

Proverbs 28:13: “He that covereth his sins shall not prosper: but whoso confesseth and forsaketh them shall have mercy.”

The truth is, we are going to sin. We all make mistakes in judgment and behavior. So, Solomon advises us to deal with it! We aren't to ignore it or cover it up by ignoring it. We are to acknowledge and forsake it, meaning not to *do it again*.

Solomon teaches that we will not “prosper” or improve by ignoring or hiding from our mistakes. We can prosper despite them if we deal with them. Confessing is the opposite of denial. It is not just saying we are sorry, but also correcting the behavior by not doing it again. We learn from our mistakes and misbehavior, which allows us to prosper in the future.

If we don't deal with it, we will most likely repeat the mistake or misbehavior and, in the process, stop prospering in that area of our lives. The “sin” will become easier and likely habitual. *The mistakes and misbehavior will become harder to correct and forsake*. Denial will become more profound, thus making it less likely to be dealt with. Indeed, there will be no corrections and no growth in that area of life!

When we aren't prospering in any area of our lives, we should scan our lives for things we've covered up and didn't correct. We should scan for mistakes and misbehaviors that need to be corrected. Look for things that we need to *acknowledge* and *accept responsibility for*. Scan for things we need to *confess* and *correct*. Then we can move on and prosper in that area of our lives!

“EASY PROMISES BUT EFFORT PRODUCES”

Proverbs 28:19-20: “He that tilleth his land shall have plenty of bread: but he that followeth after vain persons shall have poverty enough. A faithful man shall abound with blessings: but he that maketh haste to be rich shall not be innocent.”

Even in Solomon’s day, people wanted to get rich quickly and find an easy way to succeed. In his days, as ours, plenty of teachers and salespeople were waiting to take advantage of people who wanted to take the easy route to wealth or success. People followed in vain the teachers who promised an easy way. The bottom line of these two proverbs is that “*easy*” promises never produce. Effort is what produces—a continuous, steady effort from a person who is faithful to do what it takes.

Looking for the easy or fast way shows a lack of commitment. It means we want something without paying the price to get it. We want to reap without sowing. The problem with that is that it is contrary to divine law. *Circumventing divine law will ultimately produce nothing of lasting value.* It only creates a false hope that produces disappointment and disillusionment.

Purposeful, persistent effort produces a person who “abounds with blessings.” When we stop looking for an easy way and start persistently putting forth the right effort, we activate divine law and will reap the reward. Wanting results or riches quickly and easily will always leave us empty-handed and empty-hearted. We will not get the personal growth that comes from faithfully putting forth effort toward a goal.

Easy. It only promises it, never actually produces. As wise people, when we hear easy or fast, we should discern to avoid *whatever* or *whoever* is promising it. They may look credible but aren’t because they go against divine law. They are trying to take advantage of us! Further, they take advantage of weak-willed people who lack wisdom.

“CONSTRUCTIVE FRIENDSHIPS”

Proverbs 27:6: “Faithful are the wounds of a friend; but the kisses of an enemy are deceitful.”

A constructive friendship will, at times, produce “wounds.” That means a friend who will tell us the hard truth is better than one who says what we want to hear. The truth may hurt, but it produces a positive result. The person who is an “enemy” is the one who says what *we want to hear* because they are deceptive.

Wise people will invest their time with people who care enough about them to be honest. They learn not to be deceived by flatterers. Wisdom will teach us *not* to give credibility to people who say what we want to hear. *We should want genuine praise and honest evaluations, not deceptive communications.* Kiss-ups don’t lift up. In actuality, they tear us down with false praise. They allow us to be deceived about ourselves and rob us of opportunities to improve and grow.

Being a constructive friend means we are honest with our evaluations, but not deliberately hurtful. We have a constructive intent behind any criticism and confrontation. We aren’t trying to hurt them. We intend to help them, but honest communication or evaluation may hurt them. However, the hurt is temporary, but it is not destructive. *It is better to hurt someone’s feelings than to hurt their future.*

We *deceive people* by only flattering them, and we destroy them by only criticizing them. Only flattering makes people think they are better than they are, and only criticizing makes people feel they are worse. A true friend will sincerely use both compliments and constructive criticism. Their intent for both is the edification and betterment of the other person!

“HOW TO PRODUCE REBELLION”

Proverbs 29: 1: “He, that being often reprov'd hardeneth his neck, shall suddenly be destroyed, and that without remedy.”

This proverb is essential to understand when *dealing with* and *developing people*. Constant correction and criticism have the opposite effect on those who are corrected. They harden their necks, meaning they become hard-headed. Constant reprov'g produces a spirit of rebellion, which leads to the destruction of the person we were attempting to help.

Many parents, pastors, and managers end up causing rebellion because they *keep fussing* and *finding fault with* the ones they are supposed to be developing. They become so focused on correcting the negative behavior that all their communication becomes negative. They push away the very ones they are attempting to teach by focusing only on what that person is doing wrong.

Leaders need to be balanced in their communication. There should be a balance of corrections and compliments. If it is out of balance, it should be on the praise side, not the correction or criticism side. Then, *the wound created from the correction has time to heal*. If there is continuous criticism and correction, it will cause the person to become callous and not compliant. It is feeding and fueling the natural tendency of rebellion.

The leader becomes so negatively focused that they become frustrated with the person they are supposed to be helping. They mentally delete the positive actions or qualities of the person they are correcting. Further, they usually distort the negatives about the person. *The person on the other end feels attacked and becomes frustrated as well*. The relationship becomes negative even though the correction was initially meant to be positive.

If this scenario seems familiar, then my advice is to back off from the correction! Pray for the person. Pray that God will send someone else with a *different voice* to help correct them with a positive result. Regain balance in the relationship with time and positive communication.

“WISDOM HOLDS BACK”

Proverbs 29: 1: “A fool uttereth all his mind: but a wise man keepeth it in till afterwards.”

Solomon teaches that wise people refrain from speaking everything they think, even when angry. They refrain from saying things in the heat of the moment, knowing it is best to wait until things calm down. Conversely, foolish people say whatever they think and feel at the moment.

There is great wisdom in refraining from speaking everything that comes to our minds, especially when we are angry. Wise people know it is better to keep our thoughts on the inside than to let them out and have to deal with the consequences of hurting or angering people unnecessarily. There will be a better way to say what we are thinking and at a better time.

Foolish people brag about speaking their minds. Wise people bridle themselves from speaking their minds. Foolish people hit the verbal accelerator when angry. Wise people brake. Foolish people speak as they think. Wise people think, then speak. Wise people discipline themselves not to speak everything that comes to their minds. That discipline produces discernment.

Our minds need to filter our words. That is difficult when we are angry, so it is better not to say anything than to say the wrong thing. Negative thoughts produce negative words that are better not said. Once we utter foolish words, we sow seeds that will produce problems and pain. Many problems and pain caused by speaking foolishly or emotionally could be avoided if we kept silent until the emotion dies.

Remember, we can always hit the pause button, but *never* hit the rewind button. There is no rewind!

“THINK IT THROUGH”

Proverbs 29:20: “Seest thou a man that is hasty in his words? there is more hope of a fool than of him.”

Solomon advises us not to be hasty with our words because it leads to trouble. He instructs that someone who is hasty in what they say will experience more trouble than a fool. They will continuously cause unnecessary problems and pressure because they don't think through what they say.

We are to think through what we say because words have consequences. Words impact and influence both the speaker and those who hear. They are never powerless but always have power. Words said in haste can create a lifetime of consequences. Words are so potent that they have to produce some consequence. The only question is, will the consequences of our words be productive or destructive? We will have to live up to our words or live them down, so we should think through what we say!

We are to think through what we say because words cause commitments. We are constantly entering into verbal commitments with people, whether we realize it or not. What we say creates expectations in people. They will hold us accountable for what we say, even if we don't mean it wholeheartedly. They will be disappointed if we don't follow through at the minimum. So, we need to be careful in what we say and think it through because it creates a commitment even if we don't mean to.

Often, we get overextended mentally, physically, and relationally because we are too quick to say yes when we should've taken the time to think it through. People will pressure us for a reply, but we need the wisdom to say, “Let me think about it.” We create pressure and problems for ourselves because we are hasty in replying. It is crucial that we become disciplined in thinking things through before we speak.

“FEAR FACTOR”

Proverbs 29:25: “The fear of man bringeth a snare: but whoso putteth his trust in the LORD shall be safe.”

This proverb shows the two dynamic forces we can choose from. Fear entraps a person, and faith creates stability. The two forces are the same in how they work, but produce entirely different results. Today, I would like to consider the fear factor.

Notice Solomon teaches that fear “bringeth.” It is responsible for creating or causing the “snare.” Fear is a creative force, just like faith. It is a power that causes things to happen. The thing feared continuously will produce a negative consequence. Fear, in particular, can produce a “snare” or a trap.

When we are afraid, we keep ourselves tied down in a type of bondage. *We limit our lives and our potential.* We limit God’s work in our lives. We can pray, for example, but if we are afraid that the prayer won’t be answered, then it will not be. If we try to do something but are afraid, we will fail. The negative outcome only serves to reinforce the fear itself. Even if the outcome is imagined, it creates a snare or bondage, like someone with a phobia.

Most people live far beneath their potential because they live in fear. *They avoid trying and doing because they are afraid of failing.* They are burdened by worry and anxiety. They think in terms of bad things happening. Consequently, they are brought to pass enough to make them feel like they will never break free of the life they are experiencing. They imagine life from a fear-based perspective and often create those consequences.

Remember, this is no self-help guru speaking. Solomon is speaking through inspiration. Fear is powerful! *It can disable us from being the confident people God wants us to be.* It can cause the very things feared to become a reality. At minimum, fear creates a negative, destructive mentality.

“WISDOM KNOWS IT DOESN’T KNOW IT ALL

Proverbs 30:3: “I neither learned wisdom, nor have the knowledge of the holy.”

The wise king demonstrates that wisdom knows we don’t know everything just because we know some things. After a lifetime of learning, he felt like he didn’t know anything. He knew he didn’t understand God. He understood that God is Infinite. Further, he had come to understand that wisdom itself is infinite. The more he knew, the more he realized there was so much he didn’t know.

When we begin gaining wisdom and knowledge, it should produce humility. So often, academic, scientific, and theological experts develop arrogance about them. Wise people are humble by what they know because they realize it is just a tiny portion of what could be known. Wise people are in awe of what is known, understood, or discovered. *That should be especially true in our pursuit of knowing God.* There is no room for arrogance when one realizes the more they know, the more there is to be known.

When we begin to gain wisdom and knowledge, it should produce a hunger in us. It should just make us hungry to learn, understand, and increase our wisdom. It should drive us to not only know more but also learn distinctions in how to apply the knowledge for our betterment and the betterment of others. Wise people hunger to gain more knowledge. They aren’t complacent, thinking they know enough or have arrived. They search and seek more. They are always trying to discover just a little more. *There is no room for arrogance when hungering for more insight and intelligence.* Indeed, God reveals Himself to those who “search with all their might.”

We become foolish when we feel like we have arrived intellectually or spiritually. We develop arrogance that keeps us from learning new things. That arrogance also starts to warp the knowledge we do possess. The Pharisees in Jesus’ time are good examples of this. That is also true of many “experts” around us today. Wisdom produces humility and hunger in the heart of the wise. If we have lost that, we must recognize we are on the path to foolishness, not wisdom. It is what we learn after we know it all that matters most.

“THE WISDOM OF NOT SPEAKING FOR GOD”

Proverbs 30:5 6: “Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar.”

God’s Word is never the problem. When we begin to speak for God, we enter into the realm of foolishness. When we input our *opinion* as *fact* and declare it God’s will, we get into a position of being found as a “liar.” The wise king had learned that God’s Word is Pure, but our elaborations and interpretations pollute it.

We can do much damage when we presume we are so right and spiritual that we speak for God. I once heard a pastor declare something “right” and “God’s will” for a person. That is a dangerous and unwise way of communicating, because if he was wrong about his counsel, and he was, that leaves the one seeking guidance doubting God and His Word. We should not declare things on God’s behalf when giving advice. What we should do is declare the truth without adding to it.

It is absurd for any human being to think they are so spiritual they can speak for God where God hasn’t spoken. We can say, “Here is what I think.” “This is my opinion.” “Here is how I interpret that.” Or say, “My best advice is.” When we act like we have some special connection to God, we overstep our roles as messengers, ministers, and ambassadors. *People will become disillusioned with God because of our arrogant representation of His Word or Will.* We are fallible in our thoughts, advice, and interpretations, but the Word itself is infallible.

We will be held accountable for misusing and misrepresenting God’s Word! I know I have been wrong enough about discerning God’s will and applying God’s Word in my life to know that I need to be cautious when teaching, advising, or counseling. I now try to let God’s Word and His Spirit speak. *My goal is not to pollute what is pure.* My role is not to represent speaking for God in such a way that I am found to be a “liar,” i.e., one lacking credibility. I want to keep my fallibility from causing the impression that God is fallible.

“FINDING BALANCE”

Proverbs 30:7-9: “Two things have I required of thee; deny me them not before I die: Remove far from me vanity and lies: give me neither poverty nor riches; feed me with food convenient for me: Lest I be full, and deny thee, and say, Who is the LORD? or lest I be poor, and steal, and take the name of my God in vain.”

These verses contain tremendous wisdom. The wise king has grown to realize that integrity and contentment are essential ingredients in a happy life. He has also learned the value of balance and avoiding extremes. Extreme poverty produces desperation, while extreme wealth could produce ego and independence from God.

In seeking balance in his life, he learned to avoid excess, like eating or consuming more than is needed. Excess and extremes create a mentality that makes us “deny” or ignore God. When our goal becomes pleasure and consumption, we lose touch with our spiritual selves. Enough is never enough. We have to have more and more. We become extreme people who act out of compulsion, not from a place of contentment. Living to fulfill physical needs becomes the dominant pursuit of life out of balance. Or when we are ego-driven, we get out of balance.

We must avoid extremes and excessive living to live a life of wisdom. *We should desire to remain grounded and grow spiritually, knowing that it is the key to contentment.* Acquiring more wealth or consuming more will not produce contentment. It will only cause more unhappiness and dysfunction. It will drive us to meet needs temporarily at the expense of contentment.

A balanced life is essential for contentment. Success can be achieved without excessiveness. Extremes should be avoided, knowing they are a symptom of a life out of balance. A life that is out of balance will cause us to be dysfunctional both spiritually and emotionally. The unrest from discontentment will make us more extreme or excessive, hoping to find happiness, but only leaving us wanting more. When a person feels discontent, they will not enjoy what they have. The person who is content will be able to enjoy what they have. Plus, they will be able to have a dynamic relationship with God, not a dysfunctional relationship.

‘THE POWER OF A WOMAN’

Proverbs 30:18-19: “There are three things which are too wonderful for me, yes, four which I do not understand: The way of an eagle in the air, the way of a serpent upon a rock, the way of a ship in the midst of the sea, and the way of a man with a maid.”

Even the wise king didn’t understand the dynamic relationship between a man and a woman. It was noticeably mysterious to him, and I’m sure it has been to every man since then. Even a person with power and prosperity, like Solomon, felt the dynamic that happens when a man is under the influence of a woman. There is no doubt that women have incredible power. It is up to them whether they use it wisely or destructively.

It is always puzzling how independent, solid men can become weakened and dependent on the power of a woman. They can become different people when the dynamic of a relationship with a woman kicks in. Depending on that dynamic, they can become much better or worse versions of themselves. They can become addicted or liberated. Previously sane men can become almost insane under the narcotic effects of a relationship with a woman. I’m confident the king observed that hard, warrior-type men become romantic “fools” in love. He probably had seen men who could face an opponent on the battlefield but not have the courage to talk to a girl he was attracted to. *He was mystified by the “way” a man behaves with a woman he is attracted to.*

I think most women have no clue about the power they yield. A dynamic happens when a woman walks into a room full of men. The atmosphere is changed for a moment. When a man meets a woman he is attracted to, there is a chemical reaction that has a narcotic effect. That can be a powerful tool to help him overcome his fears to pursue a future spouse, or it can be a tool used against him. *There is no doubt that a physical and psychological dynamic happens between a man and a woman.* The fact that men are more visual and impulsive makes them more reactionary to the dynamic.

The wise thing is for both men and women to be cautious and careful with women’s power over men. Men, especially, should recognize that they will lower their inhibitions when under the influence of attraction. Men should understand that they should make decisions carefully when influenced by attraction. The

dynamic works for women, too, but with men, they are, as a rule, more altered behaviorally at the moment while under the influence of attraction. Wise *men* will be respectful of the power of a woman over them. Wise *women* will be respectful of the power they have over men.

“WISDOM FROM CREATION”

Proverbs 30:24-28: “There be four things which are little upon the earth, but they are exceeding wise: The ants are a people not strong, yet they prepare their meat in the summer; The conies are but a feeble folk, yet make they their houses in the rocks; The locusts have no king, yet go they forth all of them by bands; The spider taketh hold with her hands, and is in kings’ palaces.”

Wisdom can be found in observing creation. God has planted principles to be learned in creation and *intelligence to be discovered*. Here, the wise king sees four creatures that can teach us principles to become wiser and more successful. These principles can make us more productive if we apply them. *No wisdom has personal value if it isn’t applied.*

First is the ant. Ants are models of the power of preparation. They are instinctual savers. They instinctively plan and prepare for the winter months by storing food for the future. They are as productive as possible whenever possible. Any lifestyle of wisdom must include the power of preparation. This is thinking beyond the moment and planning for the future. Our future success and security are based on what we do today.

Second is the conie. These little defenseless creatures manage to survive. They can run from predators because they live in the rocks. They are models of the power of adapting and improvising. They cannot overpower their natural enemies, but use their surrounding strength *to compensate for their weakness*. The rocks provide security for them, and their smallness is utilized to hide from larger predators. They use who they are to their advantage and where they are to their benefit. They overcome by adapting and improvising their resources. They make the best of who they are and where they are. People or businesses that can adapt and improvise will not only survive, but they will also thrive. Those who don’t adapt and improvise become victims!

“WISDOM FROM CREATION 2”

Proverbs 30:24-28: “There be four things which are little upon the earth, but they are exceeding wise: The ants are a people not strong, yet they prepare their meat in the summer; The conies are but a feeble folk, yet make they their houses in the rocks; The locusts have no king, yet go they forth all of them by bands; The spider taketh hold with her hands, and is in kings’ palaces”

The third creature that is used to teach wisdom is the locust. The locusts are models of powerful teamwork. They go “forth” in “bands”. That is, they band together to accomplish their purpose. Individually, a single locust does very little damage, but as a unit, they can destroy the agriculture of an entire region. Their power is in banding together and working together. They have destructive power. They become incredibly powerful by working together. As individuals, we all have limited power and potential. However, if we can harness the power of a team, we can increase our *potential* and *power* substantially.

The fourth is the spider. The spider is a model of the power of tenacity. They even exist in the king’s palace, not because they are welcome, but because they will not leave. They “take hold” of their spot and will not vacate it. You can knock down a spiderweb, and it will build back undaunted. They will build back as many times as you knock them down. They will not give up. That is the type of tenacity that produces results. Tenacity is to keep pursuing one objective undaunted by failures. Tenacity is persistence in achieving one’s goals despite setbacks and opposition. The tenacious person will persevere, undaunted and undiscouraged by setbacks, failures, and forces that may oppose them. *Tenacious people will succeed because they refuse to give up.*

That person who *truly believes* will be like the spider and have tenacity. They will persist in purpose and prayer. *They are driven from the inside, not by circumstances.* If their progress is knocked down, they will begin building again. They will not give up or give in to whatever opposes them. The tenacious person will outlast the opposition or the current setbacks.

“STOP THE BLEEDING”

Proverbs 30:32-33: “If thou hast done foolishly in lifting up thyself, or if thou hast thought evil, lay thine hand upon thy mouth. Surely the churning of milk bringeth forth butter, and the wringing of the nose bringeth forth blood: so the forcing of wrath bringeth forth strife.”

We all make mistakes. We say things we shouldn't. Think about things we shouldn't. We cause people to get angry. We hurt people unintentionally, sometimes when angry, even intentionally. The important thing at that point is to stop it as soon as possible. Stop the bleeding, not make it worse. Put your hand over your mouth to keep from saying more. Walking away and not causing more strife.

The faster we stop our wrong or foolish behavior, the better we will be. It sounds simple, but it can be challenging in moments of mistakes. Negativity usually escalates, not de-escalates, so that's where wisdom comes in. No one will be perfect, so wise they never make mistakes. However, we can be wise enough to avoid escalating the mistakes. We can stop the bleeding and try to remedy the matter.

We can also learn from our mistakes and gain *insight into ourselves*. We can see our areas of weakness and guard against them in the future. We can learn the triggers that set off negative or wrong behavior and become more cautious in the future. Wise people will not waste a mistake. They will learn from it.

We can also gain insight into those we have offended or wronged. We can observe what their triggers are and not do it again. *We can avoid pushing their buttons, so to speak, that hurt or anger them.* Wise people will gain insight from their relational mistakes to avoid them in the future. Foolish people repeat relational mistakes habitually.

“STRAIGHT TALK FROM A MOTHER”

Proverbs 31:3-5: “Give not thy strength unto women, nor thy ways to that which destroyeth kings. It is not for kings, O Lemuel, it is not for kings to drink wine; nor for princes strong drink.”

This wise mother gives her son, the king, some straight talk. She warns him to avoid two things that can destroy his life: certain types of women and the influence of alcohol. She knew in her wisdom that these two could be dangerous for a man. These two would be especially dangerous for one like him, who had position, power, and prosperity. She had seen the two destroy other kings.

Women know women. This wise mother knew certain types of women wanted what he had but did not necessarily love him. She knew some women would take his strength from him, making him weaker as a man. This mother wanted her son to have a woman who would make him a better king and not become a drain on him or a distraction.

Then she tells her son that “kings” should not be under the influence of alcohol. In verse 6, she tells him that *he must remain clear-headed to make wise decisions and good judgment*. People were counting on him to be at his best. It was essential for him not to be intoxicated because he had a responsibility to his people. Responsibility should cause him to set responsibly. The odds of him doing so would decrease dramatically if he were intoxicated.

When we are under the influence of the opposite sex or any intoxicating substance, we will lack wisdom and discernment. We lower our inhibitions, which can be very self-destructive. This mother has given sound advice. She is being protective not just of her son but of his future. Intoxicating things can also be addictive. Addiction is a habitual weakness. She wanted her son to remain strong and wise. She wanted him to retain his kingdom and reach his potential. Neither would be likely if he ignored her straight talk.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE”

Proverbs 31:8-9: “Open thy mouth for the dumb in the cause of all such as are appointed to destruction. Open thy mouth, judge righteously, and plead the cause of the poor and needy.”

After her straight talk, this wise mother begins to give her son advice. She tells him to speak up for those who cannot speak for themselves. She instructs him to defend those who can’t defend themselves. To defend those who are bound for “destruction” or defeat. He is to *advocate for* and *aid* the “poor and needy.” She is essentially instructing him to use his position, power, and prosperity to help people who are victimized by circumstances or hurt by people. He was to use his strength to help those weaker than he was. He was to use his fortune to help those who were less fortunate.

You can tell a lot about a person’s character by how they treat people who are weaker than they are. How a man treats people in need also reveals much about his character. A man’s attitude toward those defeated by life will reveal his character. How a person treats those in need when they themselves are blessed reveals how they view themselves and others. A person in a position of authority reveals his character by how he treats those below him.

This wise mother knew that how her son treated people would become essential to who he was. How we treat people *reveals our character and develops our character* when we treat people with kindness and use our strengths to help them. She knew that we were blessed to be a blessing. We are given strengths to help those who are struggling. We are given the position and power to lift people, not push them down. We are to speak up and stand up for those who are hurting or hurting! That is what this wise mother wanted of her son, and God desires of us!

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 2”

Proverbs 31:10: “Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies.”

The wise mother had advised her son on what type of woman to avoid, so now she invests time clarifying what type of woman he should look for. She takes time and effort to lay out the qualities of the type of woman who would make his life better and allow him to be a great king.

She starts by telling her son to *value virtue over everything else*. This wise mother knew he couldn’t make good decisions about people based on beauty. She says, “Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain” in Verse 30. She isn’t telling her son to be with someone he isn’t attracted to, but rather to not base his decisions solely on attraction. To have a happy home and heart, he needs to look for particular virtues, which she describes.

She says a person who possesses these virtues is invaluable. A person possessing these virtues will be someone he could build a relationship. The “virtuous woman” or man would be an asset, not a liability. The person she describes and desires for him will be dependable. *The person she describes will be a positive partner, not a negative influence*. He can focus on his responsibilities because relational dysfunction will not distract him.

This mother’s advice is tremendously wise. Our culture today seems to value beauty as a primary virtue. *We would be wise to value virtues and character above and beyond physical beauty. Good relationships of any kind can only be positive and productive when virtues are present that create long-term value.*

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 3”

Proverbs 31:11: “The heart of her husband doth safely trust in her, so that he shall have no need of spoil.”

The first and most foundational virtue the wise mother advises her son to look for is *trustworthiness*. She instructs her son to find a woman he can trust! He can have confidence in someone, which makes him not have questions or doubts, creating security and stability in his heart and home. A king or leader’s life is stressful enough without him dealing with relational dysfunction or being concerned about things on the home front.

Notice she uses the phrase “heart of her husband”, meaning she provides emotional security and “safety.” He is safe from the anxiety that comes from having a dysfunctional partner. *It is not just that she is faithful to him, but that she is to be a source of stability in his life, not a source of instability.* As the wise mother elaborates, he can trust that she is taking care of the family, the finances, and other matters left to her. He can focus elsewhere because she is trustworthy with her responsibilities. She is dependable in every way, providing him tremendous stability and security.

When someone causes instability or insecurity in our lives, they become a liability, not an asset. They become a drain and a distraction. They begin to affect our hearts and create doubt. Their irresponsibility breeds insecurity. When the foundation of trust is eroded, everything else will be weakened and worsened.

Trust is the primary virtue when looking for a partner in any relationship. Can you trust them? Will they provide security and stability or be a source of instability? In a personal relationship, the primary question is, can you trust them with your heart? Will they bring you security and stability emotionally or produce insecurity and instability? It takes time to find out whether someone is stable and trustworthy.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 4”

Proverbs 31:12: “She will do him good and not evil all the days of her life.”

The next virtue stated by the wise mother is harder to describe. She tells her son to find someone who will be positive in his life for all of his life, to look for someone who will *be good to him* and *be good for him*. She wants him to find someone who will help and not hurt him. She knew that the woman her son chose would either be a blessing or a burden to him. She wanted him to find someone to build him up, not tear him down.

The wise mother knew people play nice at the beginning of relationships. They show their good side and are in good behavior. However, that usually diminishes with time. She wanted her son to hold out for someone who would do good to him and be good for him all of his life. That person will indeed be an asset to him as a man and king. She wanted him to find someone good in their character, not just putting on a facade to get what they wanted.

As we consider this, we can see that we are either doing good to people or evil. We are a blessing to them, or we are a burden to them. *We are building them up, or we are tearing them down.* We all have moments when we are negative in people’s lives, but we should improve them and their lives. This mother wanted her son to have someone to influence his life, helping him be his best positively.

Our goal for everyone we are in any relationship with should be that we are positive in their lives. *We help them more than we hurt them.* We are good for them and good to them. We should add value to them on our side of the relationship. We certainly need to heed this mother’s advice and not be in relationships with people who do wrong to us or are bad for us. No one will be completely one way or the other. We are human, but the positive or good should be way more consistent and present than the negative.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 5”

Proverbs 31:13-15: “She seeketh wool, and flax, and worketh willingly with her hands. She is like the merchants’ ships; she bringeth her food from afar. She riseth also while it is yet night, and giveth meat to her household and a portion to her maidens.”

The wise mother tells her son to look for a woman with a *great work ethic*. This future wife would be a queen someday, but she shouldn’t want to be pampered; instead, she should be productive. She wanted him to find someone to contribute to him, not just consume his treasures. She envisioned her son being with a hard worker with good management skills.

This work ethic included the future woman in his life, who was willing to work with her hands. She could tell people what to do, but she would be willing to work with her hands, exercising her physical talents. She was a craftswoman.

Part of her work ethic included her being a prudent shopper. She brought food from far, meaning she had good taste in furnishing their table with exotic foods. She sought the highest quality wool and linen. She was the CEO of the Estate.

Her excellent work ethic caused her to get up early. She was the first one up, planning the day so she could delegate to her staff (“maidens”). She prepares breakfast for the “household.” She was no pampered princess. She is a productive person.

A great work ethic is crucial in any partnership or relationship. It assures that people will contribute and *allows for appreciation and admiration between the people in the relationship*. Without it, there is room for animosity. The wise mother wanted her son to be in a relationship with someone who would contribute dynamically. That way, kings and subordinates would admire the virtuous one.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 6”

Proverbs 31:16: “She considereth a field, and buyeth it: with the fruit of her hands she planteth a vineyard.”

The wise mother further advises her son to look for a woman with a *great business mind*. She is an entrepreneur in her own right. She is making her own business deals on behalf of the estate and is responsible for financial gain. She is far from a dependent trophy wife. She is a contributor.

When we consider part of the wise mother’s description, we see that she thinks things through. “She considereth a field” before she buys it. She is analytical, not impulsive. She thinks from a perspective of profitability, not emotionally. She wants to make prudent, profitable business decisions independently and has earned the trust to do so.

She invests with intelligence. She takes the profit from the field she purchased and plants a vineyard. The vineyard will provide residual income and produce for the estate. She is enlarging the estate while not letting her support for her husband suffer. She is a tremendous asset to her husband and the household in every way.

The original language’s structure is such that *she expands her influence and responsibilities without letting any of her other responsibilities or duties suffer*. She knows how to prioritize her time. She knows *how to* and *when to* seize opportunities. So, she is proactive but with prudence. She isn’t overextended! We all can learn great lessons from this virtuous woman described by the wise mother.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 7”

Proverbs 31:17: “She girdeth her loins with strength, and strengtheneth her arms.”

The wise mother advises her son to find a woman with the *virtues of strength and fitness*. She *chooses* to develop strength. She “girdeth” herself, meaning she develops her strength. She isn’t dependent emotionally on others. She also keeps herself strong physically. She exercises to strengthen her arms. The wise mother knew that a strong and fit woman could contribute to her son and not become a distraction or a drain.

One of the greatest gifts we can give those in relationships is the ability to strengthen ourselves. The knowledge and desire to encourage ourselves emotionally and edify spiritually are significant assets. That frees the other person to focus on developing themselves and fulfilling their responsibilities. Of course, we all have moments of weakness when the other person steps in to add strength, but it should be in times of abnormality, not normality.

When we continuously have to strengthen another person, it becomes a ministry, not a partnership. It drains our ability to strengthen ourselves, so the other person makes us weaker, not better. The wise mother wanted her son to avoid this for his sake and his role as king. Little can drain a person like a dysfunctional, needy relationship.

The virtue of fitness is also of tremendous value. That is one of the greatest gifts we can give to those we love and value. Maintaining our health and striving to be our best are priceless gifts. We reduce stress on them and are emotionally better when we are physically fit. Being our best and looking our best should be virtues that we all adopt. It shows we care about ourselves and those we care about!

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 8”

Proverbs 31:18: “She perceiveth that her merchandise is good: her candle goeth not out by night.”

The wise mother advises her son to find a woman with good self-esteem *or perception*. *She* perceives what she does positively. She values herself and her work and creations. She has confidence and feels she is competent. That is essential for a future queen, but an equally important virtue for anyone.

How someone perceives their work is usually tied to how they perceive themselves. If people are negative about themselves, they will usually be negative about how they perceive their work and every other area of their life. *This negative self-perception leads to insecurities and inferiorities, which drain relationships and leave room for jealousy and other dysfunctions.* The wise mother wanted her son to be free of the drama caused by insecurities and inferiorities so he could excel as a leader.

It is impossible to have a positive relationship with a negative person. It will be distracting and draining. No partnership can *thrive* when one person perceives themselves in a negative light. When one lacks confidence, one will lack competence. They will feel threatened easily. They will negatively compare themselves and what they do to others. They will talk negatively more than not, further dampening and darkening the partnership.

Notice this virtuous woman is also energetic. She keeps going long into the night. Positive esteem produces positive energy. She gets up energetic and keeps going with enthusiasm into the night. She is not lazy or lethargic. She is a doer. In previous verses, she is first to rise and last to bed. Positive esteem produces positive energy. The wise mother then advises her son away from a negative, self-critical, lethargic person with low self-esteem and no energy.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 9”

Proverbs 31:20: “She stretcheth out her hand to the poor; yea, she reacheth forth her hands to the needy.”

The wise mother advises her son to find a generous and kind woman. She wants her son to have a queen who wants to help those in need and those in poverty. She is active in her charity. Notice the words “stretcheth” and “reacheth” mean *she is proactive in helping people*. She is actively going out, intending to share what she is blessed with to relieve the needs of others. She isn’t blind to the needs of those who are hurting. She certainly isn’t self-centered.

She is a busy mother and businesswoman who makes time to help those in need. She actively seeks to contribute to people she doesn’t know. She isn’t living in an ivory tower, disassociated from people who are in need. She isn’t too busy because giving and helping are her priorities. *She is generous on the outside because she is kind and caring on the inside*. She is empathetic to those who are less fortunate than she is.

As I think about the qualities of this virtuous woman, I am reminded that people who are generous and kind are undoubtedly beautiful in the eyes of God. To me, few qualities are as beautiful as someone kind and giving. These are not only divine qualities but also attractive virtues. Nothing is unattractive than a selfish, self-centered, greedy person who couldn’t care less about people in need, hurting, or poverty. A cold-hearted person is unattractive regardless of physical appearance, status, or position.

When looking for a partner or relationship, we would be wise to look for kind, generous, and caring people. They will help us be better. They will remind us of our responsibility to help the hurting and those in need. They will help us not become self-centered or selfish as we become more successful. Frankly, they are just better people to be around. They treat people better and have better attitudes than unkind, selfish people.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 10”

Proverbs 31:21-22: “She is not afraid of the snow for her household: for all her household are clothed with scarlet. She maketh herself coverings of tapestry; her clothing is silk and purple.”

The wise mother advises her son to look for an elegant and tasteful woman. This virtuous woman doesn’t just clothe her family—she clothes them in the best material. She decorates her house with tremendous style and taste. She dresses like a queen in purple and silk. The purple represents royalty and priestly status, and the silk represents feminine clothing.

She is an exceptional woman who epitomizes being a lady. *She carries herself and dresses with elegance.* She is tasteful in everything she does. She wants to look her best and have her family look their best. She looks and acts like a woman to be respected.

The wise mother knew that just because a woman was beautiful didn’t mean she would be elegant and tasteful. Then, as now, there was an art to being elegant. Tastefulness couldn’t be bought with money. It had to come from the inside as a matter of personal character. That inner virtue manifested in how she dressed, decorated, and cared for her family.

There is something very queenly about a woman who is elegant in her appearance and attitude. It sets them apart without actually being royalty. *They want to be their best, which shows externally in their choices.* That is a quality that men and women should cultivate and admire.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 11”

Proverbs 31:23: “Her husband is known in the gates, when he sitteth among the elders of the land.”

The wise mother advises her son to find a supportive woman. Because of her support, he is known and respected by the “elders.” She complements his life, allowing him to excel in his leadership role. She doesn’t complicate his life. She handles her roles with excellence and supports him in every way.

A supportive person who complements our life is a tremendous asset. They allow us to function at our highest level because we can trust that they fulfill their responsibilities. They are emotionally supportive and allow us to operate free from the drain of drama. Therefore, they don’t complicate our lives with unnecessary relationship stress and strain. No one can function at their highest level with a partner of any type being a distraction.

The wise mother seemed to know that the adage, “behind every great man is a great woman,” is true. It didn’t mean he couldn’t be great without a wife, but if he was to have a wife, she needed to complement his life. She needed to be an asset and help, not a hindrance. She would either support and strengthen him or weaken him through a lack of support.

The wise mother wanted him to look for more than a pretty face. She wanted him to realize his wife would be his most significant source of support or trouble. She wanted him to choose based on the character traits or virtues he would need to complement his role as King.

There is great wisdom in looking for a spouse or business partner who does not complicate our lives! We need to think in terms of their virtues or assets they possess, not just a surface attraction or a matter of convenience.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 12”

Proverbs 31:25: “Strength and honour are her clothing, and she shall rejoice in time to come.”

The wise mother identifies three virtues in this proverb: strength, honor, and faith. When the wise mother says “strength and honor” are her clothing, she means they are what people see when they look at her. Her ability to rejoice in times to come means she lives from a faith perspective, not fear. She is optimistic about the future.

Strength in a spouse or partner is an asset because two strong people make each other better. A strong person and a weaker person lessen the stronger one. Two strong people add to a dynamic partnership. One weak and one strong person dilutes the strength of the strong, lessening the dynamic and increasing the dysfunction. The wise mother advises her son to find someone who is *noticeably* strong!

Honor here also means dignity. She wanted her son to find someone who acted like a queen before they became a queen. *The position doesn’t produce dignity. It is a matter of disposition.* The wise mother wanted her son to have an honorable and dignified wife. Few things hurt a relationship, and someone in leadership, like having a relationship with someone who is supposed to be an asset, becomes a liability by exhibiting embarrassing behavior.

Faith and optimism go together. The wise mother looks ahead and sees herself rejoicing, not regretting. She has prayed, planned, and prepared. She believes the future will be happy. The wise mother wanted her son in a constructive relationship, not a destructive one. She knew that a fearful, pessimistic person would be a distraction and a drain on him. She wanted his future bright, not clouded with pessimism and fear.

When looking for a spouse or any partnership, we would be wise to look for these three virtues. Especially look for the virtues of faith and optimism. They will bring us new energy instead of draining us of our energy. *They will make us stronger and more dynamic than we can be alone.*

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 13”

Proverbs 31:26: “She openeth her mouth with wisdom; and in her tongue is the law of kindness.”

The wise mother advises her son to look for a woman who is a *positive and pleasant communicator*. She knows the mouth reflects the mind, so he can tell what is inside a potential wife by listening to how she speaks. If she is wise in her heart, she will speak with wisdom. If she possesses the virtue of kindness, she will speak with kindness.

The phrase “she openeth her mouth with wisdom” means she communicates with skill and wisdom. She thinks before she speaks. She is governed by wisdom and doesn’t speak foolishly out of emotion. She speaks with discipline and discretion. She is capable of giving sound advice. She can be trusted not to hurt a King or embarrass him with what she says. She is self-governed by her wisdom.

Then “her tongue is the law of kindness.” The term law means she is ruled by kindness. She can’t say mean or hurtful things because it is against the law of kindness. She speaks with pleasantness. Looking at everything written about the virtuous woman, she even talks kindly to her servants. Her kindness dominates her. She is positive, pleasant, and peaceful when she speaks. She is the opposite of someone who causes hurt and hostility by what and how they speak.

One cannot have a dynamic, positive relationship with someone who speaks foolishly and harshly. If you want to see someone’s virtues or character, listen to how they speak to everyone, not just you. See how they speak to people under them or serve them somehow. See how they speak under stress. The way someone speaks reveals who they are on the inside.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 14”

Proverbs 31:27-28: “She looketh well to the ways of her household, and eateth not the bread of idleness. Her children arise up, and call her blessed; her husband also, and he praiseth her.”

The wise mother advises her son to look for a woman who would be *admired*. She is respected by those closest to her. She is praised and appreciated because she has earned it by fulfilling her roles and responsibilities. She is the person who gives her best to her family and fulfills her responsibilities, so she is “praised” and “blessed.” She is appreciated because she is admired.

That is a revealing passage because it reminds us that those closest to us see the real us. The public can admire based on a limited perspective. However, if we can earn respect and admiration from those closest to us, we are indeed the person we portray ourselves as. If we live behind closed doors in an admired and appreciated way, we have lived with integrity and congruence.

It is apparent that this virtuous woman gave her best and was at her best at home, in private, because it was who she was. There was no separation between who she was at home and in the marketplace. She excelled in her public and family lives. Praise is offered to her because she has earned it! Her family desires to express appreciation for her because she deserves it. She has earned it not by having the positions of mother and wife but by *her performance*.

This virtuous woman is a role model to us all. She reminds us that what those closest to us think of us is most important. To be admired most by those who know us best is true success!

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 15”

Proverbs 31:29: “Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all.”

The wise mother advises her son to look for a woman who is a *person of excellence*. She wanted her son to marry a woman with excellent character, work ethic, and heart. She wanted him to find a woman who would excel as a wife and mother. She wanted her son to find a woman who excelled personally and professionally in every area of her life. The woman described in this passage has excellent business and people skills. She excels at everything she does because she is a person of excellence.

Becoming a person of excellence is an inside-out process. *She had excellent virtues, manifested in living and fulfilling her responsibilities.* She cared deeply about doing her best for her family and herself. She wouldn’t at all tolerate mediocrity from herself. She had high standards for herself and her household. She sought out the best of everything and gave her best in everything she did. Excellence was her standard.

In our culture, we have become very comfortable with mediocrity. We accept less than our best and don’t expect it from others. As a culture, we have lowered our personal and professional standards. We can see the demonstration of a lack of character and virtues everywhere we look. We have so much negativity toward our work, lives, and responsibilities. It is very rare to find someone with an excellent attitude. It is the exception rather than the norm. We accept less than excellence from our homes to our schools, churches, and companies.

We must raise our standards, not lower them to the mediocre masses. We should strive to do everything we do with excellence. That is a virtue that, if adopted, will improve our lives. We will find that just like this virtuous woman, we will have people notice. Becoming a person of excellence is a way to let our light shine for others to see.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 16”

Proverbs 31:30: “Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain: but a woman that feareth the LORD, she shall be praised.”

The wise mother advised her son to find a woman who respected God. The term “fear” means to respect, revere, and respond to God. In other words, God was number one in her life. She didn’t want her son to have a wife with a pretend relationship, but a practical relationship with God. She practices following divine principles and prioritizing her life with God as her ultimate authority.

The wise mother wanted her son to have someone as his partner to strengthen him spiritually, not weaken him. She wanted him to avoid the mistake many kings had made. She knew he would be better off if he had a *spiritual partner* to help him as an asset to his faith, not someone who would be a liability.

The wise mother wasn’t telling him to avoid a beautiful, attractive woman as a potential wife. She was admonishing him not to base his decision solely on that criterion. She knew that a good relationship could not be based on physical beauty. He needed to look for other virtues to have a happy, stable home and kingdom.

Someone can be beautiful but not stable emotionally and spiritually. This wise mother knew someone might look attractive but not necessarily be positive in a relationship. She wanted her son not to be deceived by beauty alone but to look for someone who would be an asset to him. She wanted him to look for someone to make his life better, his faith stronger, and his home stable.

Looks can be deceptive, but virtue can be depended on. As the wise mother described, character traits could be a solid foundation for building a relationship. Beauty is nice, but it alone doesn’t produce a solid foundation for a relationship and marriage.

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 17”

Proverbs 31:31: “Give her of the fruit of her hands; and let her own works praise her in the gates.”

The wise mother advises her son to *recognize* and *reward* the virtuous woman. She wants him to remember not to take her for granted and to be the person who lifts people, especially his future wife. The word “give” is active. It means recognizing and rewarding her on purpose with effort and energy. The wise mother wants him to show appreciation for the virtuous woman’s contribution to his life.

That may seem an odd way to end this collection of proverbs. However, I see great wisdom in it because it is easy to take people for granted. It is especially easy to take for granted those closest to us. Further, when someone is so dependable and performs their roles and responsibilities with such excellence and dependability, it is easy to count on them. The virtuous woman excelled in her roles and responsibilities as a matter of her character. She didn’t do it to be rewarded or appreciated. It was who and how she was. Yet, she deserved appreciation even if she didn’t desire it as her motivation.

One of life’s oddities is that people who deserve to be appreciated the most often get taken for granted. The way they consistently fulfill their responsibilities and roles can be overlooked because they are always there, giving their best. They are so dependable and selfless that they seem not to need appreciation. We would do well to heed the wise mother’s advice and appreciate them as much as possible. We need to value those who are so valuable in our lives.

A concluding thought: The wise mother didn’t want to leave to chance her son’s choice of a wife. Why? Because those closest to us determine our level of success!

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 18”

Proverbs 31:10-30: “Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies.”

“Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain: but a woman that feareth the LORD, she shall be praised.”

In concluding her advice to her son, the wise mother tells him not to base his decisions on beauty or attraction but on other qualities. As she describes her prototype of a virtuous woman, she urges her son to consider her attitude, attributes, actions, and abilities, not just appearance.

Whereas beauty can be deceptive, a person’s consistent attitudes are very telling. They reveal how they think about themselves, others, and even God. Attitude is undeniable. *A negative attitude reveals the truth about what is going on in a person’s mind.*

Attraction can start a relationship, but sustaining and maintaining quality attributes is necessary. *Attributes reveal the habits of a person.* A kind person has developed the habit of being kind. A generous person is in the habit of thinking of the needs of others, not just themselves. Attributes reveal habits, and habits reveal the heart. A person who is lazy in their heart will be lazy in their role.

Actions are also great revealers of who a person is. What a person continuously does tells the truth about them. If their actions are mean, then they are mean. If their actions are consistently selfish, then they are selfish. Not a mistake in a weak moment that is out of character. But what is their normal baseline of behavior? Someone can possess physical beauty but can have repulsive actions and reactions.

Abilities are vital because they reveal their potential contribution to the relationship. The wise mother wanted her son to have a wife who would enhance her son’s life. She wanted him to be with a woman who could excel inside and outside the home. She wanted her future daughter-in-law to bring more than beauty to the relationship.

When choosing a partner of any type, five factors must be considered: *appearance, attitude, attributes, actions, and abilities.*

“A MOTHER’S ADVICE 19”

Proverbs 31:10-30: “Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies.”

“Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain: but a woman that feareth the LORD, she shall be praised.”

Finally, *agreement is the most critical factor in looking for a spouse or partnership of any kind*. The wise mother and her son were believers and wanted him to find a wife who would spiritually agree with him. She wanted him to find someone who practices his faith (“feareth”), not just believes half-heartedly. She knew that without spiritual agreements, there would be no harmony, only conflicts.

The prophet Amos asked, “Can two walk together, except they be agreed?” There will be no harmony or progress if two people go in different directions. Either *one will have to change* their direction, or they will grow *apart*! The wise mother wanted her son to have a partner who complemented his life and was compatible with his standards.

Not only does there need to be spiritual agreement, but there also needs to be agreement on roles and responsibilities. How can there be a successful partnership if there is disagreement on what each person is supposed to do? That will only lead to more conflict. *If there is capitulation from one or both, that will only lead to resentment, bringing more negativity.*

Understanding the importance of agreement should cause any partnership to communicate expectations clearly before forming a union. Too many people plunge into a relationship or partnership before knowing if they agree on significant issues. They try to work it out after the fact, only to realize they are on two sides of significant issues. Whether a marriage or a business partnership, this is a recipe for failure. Agree on the direction before you start the journey!

